

CHAPTER 1

Good Evening, Stranger

Heritage Threads, Gomti Nagar, Lucknow — March 14, 2026

By eight fifteen, someone had already slid their bag under the counter.

Closing was an hour away. The floor had that particular stillness of a place beginning to forget itself for the night — hangers pushed back by the last browsers, the center island slightly off its axis, the entrance mirror carrying the day's fingerprints. Not dirty. Just lived in.

I was at the blue rack. Resetting what the evening crowd had undone. Tags. Spacing. One hand-width between hangers. Rajesh Sir had explained it on day one. Eight days in, my hands did it without asking my head.

Then Rajesh Sir came out of his cabin.

He stood in the doorway and looked at the floor — the way a man looks at something he has protected for fifteen years and is still not finished protecting. His eyes stopped at the entrance mirror. One fingerprint, lower left corner.

"Mirror saaf karo. Abhi."

No one asked why. Murli moved to the mirror. Anshika's bag disappeared. Suresh straightened his collar and then stood the way people stand when they want to look like they weren't just doing that.

My hand moved toward my pocket. Then stopped.

Nahi. Abhi nahi.

I turned back to the rack.

I heard the engine before the vehicle appeared.

Low. Heavy. Expensive. The kind of sound that arrives before the thing itself — just enough time to register it, not enough to prepare.

The black SUV stopped at the glass gate. Suresh reached for the left door.

He didn't need to reach for the right. It opened at the exact same time.

Left door. Black heels on the March pavement. A blue embroidered dupatta catching the showroom light. Naina.

Right door. A gray blazer — collar button open, the particular dishevelment of someone who has crossed to the other side of something and hasn't yet decided what to do with the freedom. Arjun. He adjusted nothing. His posture was the posture of a man who owns whatever ground he steps on and has always known this about himself without finding it interesting.

They stepped out into the warm night together.

Arjun said something to her over the roof of the SUV. Low. Private. She didn't smile — but the hard lines of her face softened for exactly one breath. The kind of look that builds a wall around two people and locks the rest of the world out.

Inside, my hands stopped moving.

Not grief. Not anger. The specific vertigo of watching a chapter of your own life walk through a glass door and look perfectly at home.

My right hand dropped into my pocket. My thumb found the foil strip. I pressed — directly onto the sharp raised edge of an unbroken blister. The foil cut into the soft pad of my skin.

Pain. Present. Real.

I pulled my hand out. Placed it back on the rack. Finished the fold.

Rajesh Sir was already at the door before they reached it. Not running. The unhurried precision of fifteen years.

"Good evening, Ma'am. Sir."

Naina gave a curt nod. Already looking at the floor — at her floor. At the specific distance between the center island and the western rack.

Arjun gave a slight wave, casual, his eyes already sweeping the room. The eyes of a man calculating what everything would be worth if it were his.

Then his gaze reached the blue rack.

It stopped on me.

A second of stillness. The casual arrogance froze into something else — the look of a man who has found something in completely the wrong place. Then, slowly, the corners of his mouth tilted up.

The exact smirk I had last seen on October 8, 2024.

He didn't say a word. He didn't need to.

Of all the showrooms.

Naina sensed the shift. She stopped and followed his gaze.

Both of them looked at me. Together.

I picked up the next kurta. Aligned the left sleeve. Then the right. Set it on the rack.

"Upper floor dekhti hoon," she said. To no one in particular. To the room.

She walked to the staircase. Rajesh Sir two steps behind. Present, but not needed.

She came down in under ten minutes. Ahead of Rajesh Sir — she had gone further, alone. Now she stood in the center of the ground floor and looked at it the way someone looks at something they own, checking that it still is what it was.

Then she walked toward the blue rack.

Toward me.

"Rajesh ji, staff file — mere paas bhijwa dena baad mein."

She stopped two feet away. Professional distance. The kind that has been measured and chosen.

I turned.

"Good evening, Ma'am."

Two words. But they landed wrong — I saw it. The question she had prepared on the staircase shifted in her face. Something rearranged, quickly, beneath the surface.

She didn't blink. But her shoulders lifted — one breath held one count too long.

One second.

The owner disappeared.

And the girl who used to call at eleven at night and say nothing for five minutes, just to hear someone breathing, looked back at me.

Then she was gone.

"Tumne reset kiya pura blue section?"

"Jee, Ma'am."

"Pehle koi retail experience?"

"Nahi."

"Toh display protocol kaise pata?"

"Rajesh Sir ne bataya tha. Pehle din."

She looked at the rack. Tags — same direction, same height. Spacing — one hand-width, consistent. Not approximate. Exact. She moved one hanger a centimeter to check. Then moved it back.

"Sirf ek baar?"

"Haan."

"Isse pehle kya karte the?"

"Government exam ki taiyari."

"Kitne saal?"

"Chaar saal."

Something moved in her face. Quick. Gone before it fully arrived.

"Aur usse pehle?"

"Ek cafe. Chhota sa. Ayodhya mein."

Silence.

"Ek cafe."

"Haan."

"Kahan, Ayodhya mein?"

The half-second after — professional composure closing over it like water over a stone.

"Main crossing ke paas. Kuch khaas nahi."

Her jaw tightened. Not anger. The tightness of a person keeping something exactly where it is.

"Theek hai. Rajesh ji file ready rakhna."

She walked toward the cabin. Didn't look back.

The meeting ran forty-five minutes.

Glass walls. Rajesh Sir with his files, his opinions folded away. Arjun with his legs crossed, phone in hand, present in body and absent in every other sense. Naina listened more than she spoke. But when she spoke, everything in the room leaned toward her.

I folded kurtas. Tags. Spacing. One hand-width.

The cabin door opened at nine.

"Owner Ma'am ko chai chahiye. Tum de aao."

Pantry. Three cups. The chai had been made an hour ago — I made a fresh batch. I set the tray the way the café had taught me. Deliberately. Without hurry. As if the thing mattered.

Knocked.

"Aaiye."

One cup closer to her. One for Arjun. One for Rajesh Sir. I straightened the tray until it was square with the edge of the desk.

She did not look up. "Thank you."

I turned to leave.

"Eklavya."

Just the name. Spoken to the file. As if it had slipped out without permission.

I stopped.

Three seconds. The AC humming. Rajesh Sir's pen very still.

"Center island wala ivory piece. Pata hai kya hai wo?"

"Ek lakh chaalis hazaar. Chaudah log. Chhe mahine."

Now she looked up.

Her eyes — direct. Searching for something specific. Finding it. And not being comfortable with having found it.

"Rajesh ji ne bataya tha?"

"Pehle din."

"Aur tumhe yaad hai."

"Haan."

One more second. The kind that has weight.

"Theek hai. Tum jaa sakte ho."

I closed the door. Stood in the corridor. Six seconds. Then walked back to the floor.

At nine twenty, the meeting ended.

Arjun opened the passenger door for her — a thing done many times — then walked around to the driver's side. Rajesh Sir stood at the entrance until the SUV pulled out. Left turn at the signal.

Gone.

I put the last kurta on its hanger.

Rajesh Sir stood in the center of the floor for a moment — the way he probably stood every night, making sure the floor was still the floor his employer had left him in charge of. Then he looked at me.

"Kal subah dus baje."

He went back to his cabin. I turned off the blue section light.

October 8, 2024. IIM campus. Afternoon light on the lawn. My birthday. The first time I met Arjun.

The last afternoon before everything began to break in ways that looked, from the outside, exactly like things being fine.

Bhaiya's house was quiet when I reached. The passage light was still on — Bhabhi always left it on.

Pihu's door was half open.

She was awake. Pink nightsuit, the one with small elephants. Her head turned toward the door when I came in — not startled. Just the slow turning of someone who had been waiting in the patient way she had, as if time moved at her own speed and she had long made her peace with it.

I sat on the floor beside her mattress.

She found my hand. Examined it one finger at a time, with complete seriousness. Index finger. Middle finger. The pad of my right thumb — bruised, the foil's edge printed into the skin.

She paused at the thumb. Held it. Looked at me.

"Maine aaj usey dekha, Pihu," I said quietly.

The person whose gravity had once rearranged my life — standing two feet away, asking about display protocol, her voice flat, her eyes looking for something and then closing the door before she found it.

Pihu wrapped her small fist around my thumb. The bruised one. And held it.

Not tightly. Just held it.

I sat there until her breathing slowed and her fist loosened and the day stopped feeling like something I had to hold up.

Lights off. Fan on low. Meditation mat.

Counted breaths the way Baba taught — in for four, hold, out. When the mind wanders, begin again. Not failure. Just: begin again.

The day came back in pieces. The engine. The collar button. The smirk. Kahan, Ayodhya mein. The three seconds after my name. The left turn at the signal.

I let each piece come. Let it pass.

Because Baba had said once, on a winter morning by the Sarayu when the water was very still —

"Maan ko khaali karne ki zaroorat nahi hai, beta. Bas chod do use akela."

Twenty minutes. Then the mat folded.

Then sleep.

It came faster than it had in fourteen months.

INTERLUDE I

Naina's Diary

March 14, 2026 — 11:47 PM

Can't sleep.

Finals are over. The last paper was yesterday. I should be celebrating. Sleeping for twelve hours. Waking up to the rest of my life.

Instead I am staring at the ceiling and I have been staring at it for two hours and I know exactly why and I refuse to say it.

Fine.

Fourteen months.

Four hundred and twenty days of absolute silence. Not a text. Not a call. Not one trace. He walked away because he couldn't handle the gravity of my life. He wanted his Mukti. His freedom. Whatever name he was giving it that season.

I built two floors while he was busy finding himself. Supplier meetings between submissions. Investor calls from the IIM parking lot at 6 AM, December, cold enough that my breath fogged the windshield. Second location. Twelve staff. Distinction in final year. Every room he left, I walked into and turned into something.

I won.

So why do I feel like the one who lost today?

I hadn't been to Gomti Nagar in two weeks. Exams. And today — the first day I walk back into my own showroom, finally free —

He is standing at the blue rack. Folding my kurtas.

Out of every store in this city.

He didn't look up immediately. I know the difference between someone who hasn't seen you and someone choosing, very carefully, to finish what they're doing first. He finished the fold.

He always finished what he was doing first.

Then: "Good evening, Ma'am."

Calm. Blank. Like I was a customer he had never seen before in his life.

I had a question ready. Standing on that staircase, coming back down, I had it ready — something clean, professional, that would establish exactly who was in charge of this floor.

And then he said good evening, Ma'am in that voice and the question just changed. I heard myself asking about the display, the protocol, the café. And then kahan, Ayodhya mein came out and I heard it and there was nothing I could do.

He said kuch khaas nahi. Looked at me steadily. Gave me nothing.

When Arjun looked at him — that smirk, the specific weapon of it — Eklavya just aligned the sleeves. Jee, Ma'am. Pehle din, Ma'am. Precise. Unbothered.

The ivory piece. One lakh forty. Fourteen people. Six months. From a single briefing eight days ago.

He remembered it the way he used to remember everything — quietly, completely, without performance. The way I used to find infuriating and then later couldn't stop thinking about at 11 PM when the hostel was quiet and I had my phone in my hand and nowhere useful to put it.

I said his name in the meeting.

That's it. That's the part I keep returning to.

I said it to the file. It came out before I could stop it — same as kahan on the floor. He stopped walking. Stood there. Three seconds.

Then I asked about the ivory piece because it was the only sentence I had prepared.

Q1 footfall up eighteen percent. Spring collection ahead of projection. Supplier payment March 20th. Hazratganj lease before Thursday.

These are the things that matter.

These are the things that matter.

He wants professional? I will be the most controlled, most precise version of myself he has ever seen. Every boundary will hold.

Let's see how many times he can say Jee, Ma'am before one of us breaks.

Not me.

It won't be me.

I have always been fine.

PART 1 — Sunday, March 15 | Subah

Pihu's room first.

She was attempting physics.

Pink frock, one hand on the floor, one gripping the table leg — the teddy bear was six inches out of reach and she had been workshopping solutions for twenty minutes. I had been watching from the doorway for two of them.

Attempt seven: stretch further. Fail. Recalibrate.
Attempt eight: different angle. Closer. Almost —

She lunged.

The teddy came free. She sat down hard, surprised by her own success, and looked at it like it owed her something.

Then she looked at me.

"Aaa."

"Yeah," I said. "You got it."

She bonked the teddy against the table. Twice. Then once more — not celebration, investigation. Checking if it was real.

Dawai time.

The syrup bottle came out. Pihu's face arranged itself into its familiar expression of diplomatic resistance.

Five minutes. Half on her bib, half where it was supposed to go. Then sudden peace when the spoon became more interesting than the medicine. I let her hold it. She turned it over. Tapped it against the steel bowl — ting ting ting — examined it with the seriousness of someone who has learned that most problems, looked at long enough, reveal their own solution.

"Open," I said.

She opened.

My tablet next. T Cloril MD. Water. Done. Pihu watched me take mine without comment. We had an understanding about this.

Bhabhi appeared in the doorway.

"She was up at five-thirty."

"I know. I heard her."

"You should have called me."

"She was fine. Just awake."

Bhabhi looked at Pihu, who was now attempting to fit the empty medicine spoon into the steel bowl with the focus of someone performing surgery.

"Eklavya—"

"Bhabhi."

She stopped.

"I've got her. Go eat something."

She looked at me for a moment. Then went back to the kitchen.

Pihu looked up. Our eyes met.

"Chaaa." Conspiratorial.

"Don't tell her I let you stay up."

She went back to the spoon.

PART 2 — Sunday, March 15 | Showroom

Showroom. Ten AM.

Sunday crowd — slower, different. Families. Couples deciding on wedding outfits with the specific energy of people who are happy and stressed simultaneously. A mother holding a heavy Anarkali against her daughter who clearly wanted something else. Husbands standing near the entrance, present in body and somewhere else entirely in mind.

I was at the blue rack.

Tag. Fold. Space.

Murli whistled somewhere behind me — the same three notes, cycling every forty seconds. I had counted without meaning to. The kind of thing the mind does when it is doing something else entirely.

At eleven, the energy shifted.

Not dramatically. Just — tightened.

Anshika's posture straightened. Murli stopped mid-note. Rajesh Sir emerged from his cabin as if he'd been waiting for a frequency only he could hear.

She had arrived.

White kurta. Hair open. Alone.

No Arjun. No driver inside. Just her and the kind of entrance that didn't need announcement.

Rajesh Sir moved forward. "Good morning, Ma'am—"

"Rajesh ji, March summary ready hai?"

"Haan, cabin mein—"

"Aap nikal ke rakhiye. Main floor dekh leti hoon."

She moved through the floor. Corner to corner. Western section. Silk rack. Counter. The way she looked at things she cared about — not performing inspection, actually looking.

I kept my eyes on the blue rack.

Tag. Fold. Space.

She stopped at the counter.

Anshika answered questions about movement, numbers, dupatte — clean, efficient. Then —

"Instagram chalate ho?"

Anshika: "Haan, Ma'am."

Murli: "Haan, Ma'am."

Suresh: "Haan, Ma'am."

She turned.

Looked directly at me.

"Tum?"

Two feet of professional distance. A kurta rack between us.

"Nahi, Ma'am."

She picked up a piece from the rack — deep teal, heavy border — and examined it the way someone examines evidence.

"Yeh wali kitni baar poochi gayi aaj?"

"Teen baar. Teeno ka size nahi mila."

"Size chart update hua?"

"Rajesh Sir se kal bola tha. Unhone kaha IT se hogi."

"Yeh tumhe pata kaise?"

"Teeno customers ne rack ke neeche tag dhundha. Nahi mila. Mujhse poochha. Teeno ka same size tha. Maine note kiya."

She set the piece back. Looked at me — that direct, searching look.

"Tumhara kaam achha hai."

Said the way a fact is stated. Not a compliment. An observation.

"Shukriya, Ma'am."

She turned to address the full floor.

"Company ka ek naya rule hai. Instagram account banana compulsory hai. Heritage Threads follow karo. Har sale jisme customer tumhare post se aaya — five percent commission. Kal subah se effective."

Then — directly to me:

"Tum kal account banana."

She walked toward the cabin.

PART 3 — Sunday, March 15 | Raat

Maine khud car chalayi. Ek kilometer.

Wahi purani tapri — different chacha, same stove, same plastic chairs. Khadi rahi. Baithi nahi. Chai order ki — saat rupaye. Same price.

Teen drafts. Delete. Delete. Delete.

Phir post kiya. Kyunki Dr. Mehta sahi thi — jo andar rakhte ho woh circle karta rehta hai.

Woh kal account banayega. Company rule — maine khud announce kiya.

Dekhega ya nahi — pata nahi.

Par woh wahan hoga.

PART 4 — Monday, March 16 | Subah

Floor opening routine.

Murli: mirrors.

Suresh: gate.

Anshika: counter, laptop, cash drawer.

Me: blue rack.

Tag. Fold. Space.

Rajesh Sir appeared at nine forty-five.

"Instagram account banana tha. Ma'am ne kaha tha."

"Haan Sir. Lunch break mein kar leta hoon."

"Abhi karo. Char minute ka kaam hai. Anshika help kar degi."

Anshika walked me through it. Account name. Profile photo. Heritage Threads ka follow. Four minutes. Efficient. Professional.

Then, just before she handed my phone back —

"Ma'am ka account bhi follow karna hoga. Official policy hai."

She passed me the phone.

I followed the account.

The feed loaded.

The most recent post: 11:52 PM. Last night.

A tapri. Tin roof. One stove. Plastic chairs in the dark.

I looked at it.

The stove light. The angle of the chairs. The particular darkness of a March night.

Maybe.

I read the caption once. Then again.

Sentinel. Imagined order. The roles have changed.

April 2023. Parking lot. She had said that word almost to herself — "Tum sentinel ki tarah ho." And then looked like she hadn't meant to say it out loud.

That word. That exact word. On a public post. On her account with a lakh followers.

I handed the phone back to Anshika.

"Ho gaya?" she asked.

"Haan."

Her eyes moved from my face to the phone and back. Once.

That once was enough.

I went back to the blue rack.

Tag. Fold. Space.

My hands were steady.

PART 5 — Monday, March 16 | Dopahar

She arrived at twelve fifteen.

Blazer. Professional distance maintained from the gate itself.

Heading toward the cabin.

She paused.

Her phone was in her hand — had been since she walked in. She looked at it once.

Then she looked at me.

"Eklavya."

"Ma'am."

"Kaam theek chal raha hai?"

"Haan, Ma'am."

"Good."

She went to the cabin.

Four words. Two seconds.

Anshika found a reason to come to the blue section seven minutes later. A hanger that needed adjusting, apparently.

"Pehle kahan tha account tumhara?" Casual. Like asking about the weather.

"Tha nahi. Aaj banaya."

"Haan." She adjusted the hanger. It did not need adjusting. "Ma'am ko bahut jaldi pata chal jaata hai — kab koi unka account dekhta hai."

She went back to the counter.

I looked at the hanger she had adjusted.

It was exactly where it had been.

Murli whistled.

Thirty-five seconds.

PART 6 — Monday, March 16 | Shaam

The cabin door opened at four fifteen.

"Center island wala piece — Anarkali nahi, uski jagah par woh teal piece laao kal subah. Buyer aa sakta hai."

"Ji, Ma'am."

She started to walk away.

Without turning back —

"Post karna mat bhoolna. Kal ka schedule hai."

"Haan, Ma'am."

She walked to the gate. Driver already there. Left turn at the signal. Gone.

Anshika began closing her register.

Without looking up:

"Woh kabhi seedha kuch nahi bolti. Aap notice karoge dheere dheere."

"Kya?"

"Yeh bhi ek tarah ka baat karna hai." She closed the register. "Good evening."

She picked up her bag and left.

I stood there.

The teal piece. The post. The four words at noon. The tapri photo. 11:52 PM. Plastic chairs in the dark.

Sentinel.

Baba had said once, on a morning by the Sarayu when the fog hadn't lifted yet — "Kuch cheezein seedha nahi bolte log. Par bolte zaroor hain."

I turned off the blue section light.

Murli whistled one last time from somewhere near the exit.

Thirty-two seconds.

I was still counting.

INTERLUDE II
Naina's Diary
March 15–16, 2026

March 15 — 11:58 PM

Maine khud car chalayi. Ek kilometer.

Teen drafts. Delete. Delete. Delete.

Phir post kiya. Kyunki Dr. Mehta sahi thi — jo andar rakhte ho woh circle karta rehta hai.

Woh kal account banayega. Company rule — maine khud announce kiya.

Dekhega ya nahi — pata nahi.

Par woh wahan hoga.

March 16 — Raat

Usne dekha.

Pata kaise chala — notification nahi aata following ka. Par main uske floor par thi. Aur main jaanti hoon woh chehra.

Aaj noon mein — "kaam theek chal raha hai" — woh bilkul still tha. Woh wali stillness nahi jo hamesha hoti hai usmein. Woh wali stillness jo tab hoti hai jab koi cheez process ho rahi ho aur bahar kuch nahi dikhana.

Woh jaanta tha main jaanti hoon ki usne dekha.
Main jaanti thi woh jaanta hai.

Aur phir bhi dono ne sirf —

"Kaam theek chal raha hai."

"Haan, Ma'am."

Itna hi.

Anshika smart hai. Woh observe karti hai. Yeh helpful bhi ho sakta hai. Aur complicated bhi.

Raat ke baad se ek cheez andar hai jo bahar nahi aa rahi.

Usne post dekha. Caption padha. Sentinel. Woh word jo sirf humara tha.

Usne padha. Aur phir wapas kaam kiya.

Yahi toh hai woh.

Maine post isliye nahi kiya ki woh dekhe.
Maine post isliye kiya kyunki andar rakhne ki jagah nahi thi.

Agar yeh dono ek saath sach ho sakte hain — toh hain.

Laptop band. Light off.

— N.

CHAPTER 3

Inevitable

Heritage Threads, Gomti Nagar, Lucknow — March 17, 2026

Rajesh Sir came downstairs at two.

"Eklavya. Upar aao."

I left the blue rack where it was and followed him up.

The upper floor was different.

Downstairs was routine — racks, tags, the particular rhythm of retail. Up here the light came from the windows. Open space. A dummy stood in the center, and beside it, on a separate stand, a sherwani. Deep teal. The same fabric I had been folding and spacing and tagging for three days on the floor below.

People were seated.

Naina on one side — files in hand. Arjun on the other — open collar, that IIT Delhi ease that comes from never having had to explain yourself in a room.

And in the corner — a woman in a salwar suit, hair pulled back neatly, a dupatta in her hands. She was touching it the way someone touches something they already know. Not examining. Listening.

Rajesh Sir introduced me.

"Yeh Eklavya hai. Floor pe kaam karta hai. Display aur arrangement."

The chief designer looked up from his sketches. "Haan. Yahi chahiye tha." He said it to himself mostly. Then to the room — "Hum ek wedding collection ke liye real person dhundh rahe the. Model nahi — actual. Ghar ka ladka. Jo pehli baar sherwani pehne. Woh jo dikhta hai — forced nahi hota."

The woman in the corner looked at me then.

Once. Top to bottom. Then my eyes.

She stood. Came to the stand. Lifted the sherwani — held it out.

"Beta, ise try kar sakte ho?"

Five seconds.

The designer's pen stopped. Arjun's file stayed closed. Rajesh Sir looked at the ceiling.

Then — a sound so quiet it wasn't heard, only felt.

Naina.

One step. Two steps. She was beside me — close enough that I could feel the shift in the room's air before I registered the movement itself.

She reached toward the sherwani. One finger. Touched the collar fabric — that gesture of listening to a thread, feeling what the hands that made it were saying.

Then, quietly —

"Try karne se khareedna nahi padta."

I was looking at the design.

She was looking at the design.

There were six other people in that room.

That line belonged to two.

One Phoenix mall. One jacket. One Rs.5,990 tag. December 2023.

"Mujhe aadat nahi dalni us cheez ki jo main afford nahi kar sakta."

"Try karne se khareedna compulsory nahi."

She had given it back. Here. In this room. In front of six people who heard the words and understood none of them.

"Ji."

I took the sherwani.

When I came back out, nobody said anything for a moment.

The woman — Nandini Ji — looked at me the way she had when I first walked in. That look of finding exactly what you were looking for and being quietly startled by it.

She came forward. Both hands — adjusted the collar. One small fold. The kind of adjustment that isn't really an adjustment, just the hands needing somewhere to go.

She stepped back.

"Yahi chahiye tha."

They looked.

All of them — Nandini Ji, the designer, his assistants, Rajesh Sir standing near the door.

No camera. No instructions. Just the evening light from the windows and everyone in the room understanding that whatever this was, it was working.

Naina was looking too.

I didn't look at her.

But I felt it — that specific quality of her attention. Three years of learning its texture. This was the version she didn't perform. The one that arrived before she decided to let it.

Then she raised her phone.

"Ek second."

I was turning toward the changing room.

I stopped.

She didn't look at me directly. Just raised the phone — one frame. Evening light from the window. The empty stand beside me. The room behind.

Shutter.

She looked at the screen for a moment. Then she put the phone in her pocket and the corner of her mouth moved — that smile. That specific one. Not the professional version, not the performed version. The one that comes when something has gone exactly as planned and the plan was never supposed to exist.

December 2023. She had extended a jacket. I had put it back.

Today she was the one who decided what happened in this room.

She knew I knew.

I knew she knew I knew.

"Ho gaya," she said quietly.

I went to change.

In the changing room I stood in front of the mirror for a moment.

The sherwani was off. I was just me again — jeans, company shirt, eight days of retail on my hands.

That smile of hers was still somewhere in the room outside.

It wasn't anger. It wasn't discomfort.

It was something that sits closer to recognition — the specific feeling of being known by someone who has no right to know you that well anymore.

I folded the sherwani carefully. Set it on the stand.

Went back out.

The room was winding down. Designer packing sketches. Assistants gathering equipment.

Arjun came back in.

He looked at the room once — read it the way someone reads a room they've been calculating since they walked in. His eyes moved from Nandini Ji to Naina to me. Landed on me for one second. Then moved on.

"Dinner aaj main banaonga," he said. To the room, but for Naina. "Kailash Uncle ne kaha tha saath banana chahiye kabhi. Main aur Uncle — apne haath se."

Naina looked up from her file.

Something passed across her face. So brief. So contained.

"Unhone khud kaha tha?"

"Haan. Tum yahan khatam karo. Hum neeche hain."

Said the way something is said when it is already decided.

He looked at me once more — that same calculation. Then he was gone.

The designer left. Assistants. Rajesh Sir.

The room went quiet.

Three people remained.

Nandini Ji settled back into her corner — dupatta back in her hands, that same listening touch.

"Arjun bahut achha ladka hai," she said. To the room. To no one specifically. "Itni badi company mein kaam karta hai. Papa bhi khush hain. Settled hai. Sochta hai. Aage ka plan hai."

Naina was looking at her file.

"Haan, Maa."

"Aajkal yeh bahut kam milta hai." A pause. Then — "Wahan ke log sheher se nahi badte. Andar se nahi."

One second. Naina's file stayed exactly where it was.

Then, quietly — to her mother —

"Inevitable."

Nandini Ji looked up. "Kya matlab?"

Naina looked at her — that steady, careful look.

"Matlab — jo hona hai woh hoga. Rok nahi sakte. Cheezein apni jagah find kar leti hain. Chahe tum plan karo ya na karo."

She said it to her mother.

But her eyes — for just that one second — came to me.

I was standing near the door.

Inevitable.

October 2024. Cafeteria. Arjun had looked at me and said — "Love is a feeling. But survival is a competition — and I always win."

And I had said that word back to him. One word. That was all.

Now it was in her mouth. About him. To her mother.

Same word. Every meaning flipped.

Our eyes met — one second. The length of a breath held and released.

She knew I had heard.

I knew she knew.

Neither of us said anything.

Then she looked back at her mother.

I turned toward the stairs.

Downstairs. Blue rack.

Tag. Fold. Space.

Murli had gone home. Anshika was locking the counter.

I folded.

That word was still in the room somewhere — in the air above the blue rack, in the space between my hands and the fabric.

Inevitable.

When she had said it to Arjun — it was a wall.

When she had said it to her mother just now — about Arjun — it was something else entirely. Something that had my name written inside it in an ink only two people could read.

I kept folding.

Anshika said good evening from the door.

I said good evening back.

The showroom went quiet.

That night. Mat. Kamra. Fan.

Baba's process — in for four, hold, out. When the mind wanders, begin again.

Inevitable.

The word sat there. Wouldn't move. Wouldn't go deeper, wouldn't surface. Just sat — the way something sits when it knows you can't do anything with it yet.

In the first chapter of this job — eight days ago — there had been a foil strip in my pocket and six seconds in a corridor and sleep that came after fourteen months.

Tonight the sleep wasn't coming like that.

Tonight something had shifted in the room of my chest that I didn't have a name for yet.

I lay on the mat.

Fan turning.

I closed my eyes.

The word was still there.

Inevitable.

INTERLUDE III

Naina's Diary

March 17, 2026 — Raat

Maine ek photo li aaj.

Sirf ek. Arjun ko nahi dikhaayi. Ananya ko nahi. Khud bhi zyada nahi dekhi. Bas li aur pocket mein rakh di.

December 2023 mein usne woh jacket nahi pahni thi.

Aaj maine pahnayi.

Yeh chhoti si baat hai. Koi nahi samjha. Ek kamre mein cheh log the aur sirf do jaante the ki yeh chhoti si baat kitni badi thi.

Woh muskurahat jo aayi — woh controlled nahi thi. Woh wali thi jo tab aati hai jab cheez exactly waisi hoti hai jaisi sochte the.

Main jaanti hoon yeh sahi nahi tha.

Par tha.

Arjun ne dinner plan kiya. Mujhe bataaye bina. Papa ke saath. Apne haath se.

Woh darta hai.

Yeh woh sign hai jo main jaanti hoon — jab confident hota hai tab wait karta hai. Jab darta hai tab move karta hai. Fast. Bina poochhe.

Papa khush honge. Maa pehle se khush thi — "Itna achha ladka. Settled. Sochta hai."

Woh galat nahi hain. Dono galat nahi hain.

Arjun sach mein achha hai.

Aur yahi sabse mushkil hissa hai.

Maine "Inevitable" bola Maa ko.

Unhone poocha — "Kya matlab?"

Maine explain kiya — jo hona hai woh hoga. Cheezein apni jagah find kar leti hain.

Maa ne suna. Sir hilaya. Arjun ke context mein samjha.

Par woh word Arjun ke liye nahi tha.

Woh word October 2024 ka tha. Cafeteria ka tha. Ek ladke ka tha jisne ek word mein woh keh diya tha jo main teen saal mein nahi keh payi.

Maine woh word aaj wapas diya.

Woh jaanta tha.

Main jaanti thi woh jaanta tha.

Ek second. Aankhein mili. Kuch nahi bola.

Maa ne kaha — "Wahan ke log sheher se nahi badte. Andar se nahi."

Teen saal pehle yeh sun ke main argument karti.

Aaj kuch nahi bola.

Kyunki Maa teen saal pehle wali Maa nahi hain. Woh aurat jo roz ek kadai banaati rahi — Rohan ke naam ki, Rohan ke rang ki — woh aurat aaj ek dopahar mein thodi si halki lagi.

Eklavya ki wajah se nahi.

Us afternoon ki wajah se. Us kamre ki wajah se. Us baat ki wajah se jo nahi boli gayi par thi wahan.

Mujhe yeh heavy kar gaya. Ek achhe tarike se. Ek dard bhari tarike se. Dono ek saath.

Woh aaj raat kya soch raha hoga — pata nahi.

Par woh word abhi bhi wahan hai. Hawaon mein. Us kamre mein.

Inevitable.

Cheezein apni jagah find kar leti hain.

Chahe tum chahte ho ya nahi.

— N.

CHAPTER 4

Sachi Bhaav

March 18, 2026 — Morning | Bhaiya's House

I hadn't set an alarm. My eyes opened on their own.

Dark. Quiet. The steady hum of the fan. A thin sliver of light bled from under the door—Bhabhi was already in the kitchen. My mind had made the decision before my body even sat up.

Today, I had to look at it. All of it.

I sat on the meditation mat. Spine straight. Hands on my knees. *Ujjayi*. The ocean-wave sound at the back of the throat. *Bhramari*. The resonating vibration inside the skull. With every exhale, the word that had haunted the room all night—*Inevitable*—began to lose its weight.

Baba had said once, "*Jo andar hai use andar mat rakho. Use jagah do. Tab woh tumhe nahi pakadta — tum use pakad lete ho.*"

I opened my eyes. The morning silence felt different now.

On the desk sat her diary. She had given it to me in January 2025. I hadn't opened it in fourteen months. I was terrified of it—not because I thought it contained something bad, but because I knew it contained the truth. It was easier to pretend the weight was entirely mine.

I opened a blank notebook next to it. I picked up my pen. I didn't try to organize the thoughts. I just let them bleed onto the paper.

The first thing that came back was the smell.

Dettol. White walls. Fatima Hospital. January 21, 2022.

Bhaiya's voice on the phone that morning had been breaking with a chaotic mix of exhaustion and relief. *"Ho gaya. Ladki hui."*

"Kaise hai Bhabhi?" "Theek hai. Normal delivery. Tu aa ja."

The morning rush. The red light. Room 204. Papa was glued to his phone screen, sending updates. Mummy was stroking Bhabhi's forehead. And in the corner, a white sheet, a pink cap. A tiny bundle.

I walked over to the crib. She was so small. A half-moon face, translucent pink nails. I extended my index finger, hesitating slightly. She grabbed it instantly.

A reflex. A tight, surprisingly strong grip.

"Strong hai," the words slipped out of my mouth.

Bhaiya gave a tired smile. *"Haan. Ladegi yeh."*

My brain noted that her features—the shape of her eyes, the structure of her nose—were slightly different. But there was no alarm. She didn't let go of my finger. I stood there, listening to Bhabhi's frail voice from the bed behind me.

"Meri galti toh nahi na...?" "Pagal ho kya?" Mummy scolded gently. *"Aisi baat mat soch. Sab bhagwan ka plan hai."*

There were no labels then. Only one absolute fact: She was ours.

Five months later, the illusion of the typical North-Indian "new baby" phase evaporated.

May 25, 2022. The pediatrician's cabin. The AC was blowing cold air, but the room felt suffocatingly heavy. The doctor adjusted his glasses, his hands resting on a file.

"Your baby has Down syndrome."

The words hung in the air. *Down. Syndrome.*

Bhabhi's breath hitched. Her grip on Pihu tightened. Bhaiya stared straight at the doctor, water pooling in his reddening eyes.

The doctor kept talking in simple Hindi—Chromosome 21, developmental delays, speech therapy, lifelong care. But the room had gone entirely silent. Bhabhi broke down, her silent tears turning into heavy, chest-heaving sobs.

"Doctor... *meri galti toh nahi?*" she asked, her voice shattering.

"*Bilkul nahi. Yeh kisi ki galti nahi. Random genetic event hai,*" the doctor replied quickly.

The words were sympathetic, but pain doesn't absorb logic.

I looked at Pihu. She was dozing in Bhabhi's lap, her eyes half-closed. She had absolutely no idea what this cabin, this word, or this diagnosis meant. For her, the world was still just the warmth of a chest, the taste of milk, and the game of light and dark.

Late that night, the TV was off. The house was dead quiet. I stood by the crib in the living room. The doctor's words—*permanent, lifelong care*—were looping in my head. I placed my hands on the edge of the crib and gently touched her finger.

Even in her sleep, her reflex kicked in. She grabbed it. Tight. As if that tiny hand was holding up the entire weight of the room.

I whispered into the dark. "*Tu different hogi. Par tu kam nahi hogi.*"

Nobody heard it. But Pihu's small hand squeezed mine just a fraction tighter.

A month later, June 2022. The library.

My bag held books, and my pocket held the 1300-rupee monthly fee Bhaiya had silently left on the table the night before. It wasn't an offer; it was a decision.

Basement. Eighty seats. Yellow tube lights. There were no motivational posters, no glamour. Just the specific, heavy silence of dozens of people fighting for their lives in the same room. By the fourth day, Seat 17 became mine. Nobody assigned it. It just happened.

The routine set in. The 5:30 AM alarm. Making tea in silence with Bhabhi at 6:00 AM. And then, right before leaving, I would bend down near the crib and extend my finger. She would grab it. Without a sound. That tiny, resolute grip anchored me through the grueling hours of study.

The library had its own ecosystem of quiet desperation. Two rows ahead of me sat Rajesh Bhaiya. Seat 12. Thirty-two years old, shoulders slumped, studying from a copy of Laxmikanth whose broken spine was held together by tape. Taped under his desk was a faded chart: *2021 — FINAL ATTEMPT*. It was 2022.

Then there was Yadav at Seat 19, who spent five months working up the courage to hand a piece of paper with his number to the girl at Seat 18. She dropped it into her bag without a word and drove off. Yadav understood, but he didn't give up hope. He was an aspirant; waiting was what he did best.

And Sivi, who sat at 7:45 AM every day. When I asked her how she dealt with the homesickness, she stared into her tea cup and said, "*Pehle mahine dar lagta tha... Phir socha — woh log ghar pe hain mere liye. Main yahan hoon unke liye. Bas direction alag hai.*"

We were all away from home, in one way or another.

By December, a new phenomenon began. The T.I.M.E. coaching center for MBA aspirants was on the fourth floor of our building. During breaks, the two worlds collided near the tapri outside. We, the basement dwellers, and they, the fourth-floor elites.

I stopped writing in my notebook. The morning light was getting stronger. I reached across the desk and finally opened her diary. I needed to see her side of that winter.

28 November 2022, 11:47 PM

Dr. Mehta said write it down. I asked why. She said the things we keep inside don't go away. They just keep circling. I said I'm fine. She said I know. Write anyway. So here. This is me writing.

CAT 26 November ko tha, mahine ke aakhri Saturday ko. I knew walking out — QA mein do sets galat gaye, LRDI mein time waste kiya, Verbal mein overconfident rahi. I could roughly predict the score. IIM A, B, C nahi hoga. Maybe lower IIMs. Maybe not even that... Joined T.I.M.E. yesterday. 2023 attempt. No plan B. This is the plan. I'm not stopping.

Dr. Mehta also said — be honest when you write. Toh honestly — I don't know when I got this tired. Achieve karte rehna, prove karte rehna, ghar ki woh khamoshi carry karte rehna — it's a lot. Sometimes. But I'm not stopping. So I keep going.

Rohan would have said 'Didi, ek baar saans le.' But Rohan isn't here. Aur yeh sentence likhte waqt mujhe aaj bhi ek second rukna padta hai. Take a breath. And tomorrow I wake up again.

I stared at the name. *Rohan*. The brother she had lost. The silence in her house. I turned the page.

10 December 2022, 7:15 AM

First real day of coaching. November was just orientation. Today actual classes. Mom was downstairs. Coffe bana rahi thi. Papa hasn't come home yet. Garment supply ka itna bada business hai unka ki ghar aane ki fursat kahan. I don't ask anymore.

Mirror. Kurta. Hair tie. No jewelry — never do. Maa ko pasand hai. Isliye nahi. Packed the bag. CAT material. Mock sheets. This diary. And one cigarette — can't smoke at home, Maa doesn't know. Will smoke outside T.I.M.E. Nobody there knows who I am. Today is a fresh start.

I remembered that morning.

It was the kind of winter wind that bypasses your hands and hits your face directly. I was waiting for the SSC CGL Tier-1 results. I walked to the tapri at the mouth of the library alley. Chacha was running it. Tin roof, one stove, four plastic chairs. Tea for seven rupees.

She was standing there. An expensive jacket. The kind of bag that screamed generational wealth.

"Bhaiya, ek chai," she commanded Chacha. An order, not a request. She paid a ten-rupee note, shoved the three rupees change into her pocket without looking, and then searched for a lighter.

Click. Click. Click. Nothing.

"Lighter kaam nahi kar raha." She looked at me. Direct, brown eyes. Slightly annoyed. The first time she actually looked at me. *"Jala sakte ho?"*

I pulled out my lighter. The flame flickered. She stepped close—two steps—and leaned in. The tip of her cigarette caught the flame. She took a deep drag, and as she exhaled, the smoke blew straight into my face.

I coughed lightly. She looked at me, completely cold and detached. There was no apology. She couldn't have cared less where the smoke went.

"Smoking nahi karte?" she asked casually, holding her phone.

"Nahi. Allergy hai," I replied.

"Oh." Just one word. She cut the conversation right there.

"Quant class ke liye aaye ho?" she asked after a moment.

"Nahi. Library. Isi building mein."

"Charges?"

"1300 monthly."

"Okay. Not bad."

We finished our tea and started walking toward the building together. It wasn't planned. It just happened.

"Prep kya hai tumhara?" she asked.

"SSC CGL." "SSC... matlab UPSC ke under?"

I offered an automatic, tired smile. *"Nahi. Alag hai. Staff Selection Commission. UPSC sirf IAS-IPS ke liye hota hai. SSC mein taxes, customs, audit, statistics — bahut kuch. Basically desh sirf IAS se nahi chalta, poore system se chalta hai."*

She paused. And then, breaking through her arrogant facade, a genuine smile appeared.

"True. Makes sense actually."

We parted ways at the gate. I went down to the basement. Seat 17. But as I opened my books, something wouldn't settle. Maybe it was the smoke that brushed my face, or maybe it was that *'makes sense actually'*—a rare, unperformed moment of genuine acknowledgment. It was a five-minute conversation.

I looked back down at her diary. The entry for that same night.

10 December 2022, 10:52 PM

Class was fine... There was a guy at the tapri this morning. Library wala. Lighter kaam nahi kar raha tha. Usne jala diya. Bas itna. Talked for maybe 5 minutes — SSC, library charges. Normal.

But one thing. When I asked about UPSC he didn't get irritated. Didn't condescend. Just said it straight. 'Desh IAS se nahi chalta, poore system se.' Interesting line.

People usually assume that when I don't know something, I don't care. He didn't do that. Don't know his name. Don't need to, honestly. Library wala. Shayad phir dikhe, shayad nahi. That's it.

I closed her diary and put my pen down.

Dono ne ek doosre ka naam nahi jaana tha. We both thought it was nothing. Just one day. Just five minutes that would pass and be forgotten.

Dono galat the. We were both so incredibly wrong.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 5

The First Threshold

February 2023 — Lucknow

February 9, 2023 | Library | 11:07 AM

The notification arrived. The one I had been waiting for since the morning. The SSC website slowly loaded on my screen: *'Combined Graduate Level Examination (Tier-I), 2022 – Declaration of Result.'*

My hand trembled slightly over the mouse. Results in this world didn't come in neatly packaged scorecards; they came in massive, unforgiving PDFs. I downloaded 'List 3' and hit Ctrl+F. I typed my 10-digit roll number. Enter.

The page buffered. One second. Two seconds.

An orange highlight flashed across the screen. My roll number. My name. The UR cutoff was 114.27, and I was safely above it. I had qualified.

There was no sudden jump of joy. Nobody screamed. Inside my chest, something simply settled—like a tight rope that had been stretched for months finally loosening by a fraction of an inch. That was it. That was all it was.

I texted Bhaiya: *'Qualify ho gaya.'* Three minutes later, his reply came: *'Achha. Padhai jaari rakho.'* Mummy called five minutes after that. She asked the same things she always asked—had I eaten? Was I sleeping properly? And then, slipped somewhere in the middle: *"Beta, achha kiya."* In the background, I heard Papa's muffled voice say, *"Shabash."* It wasn't loud, but it was there.

This was just the screening. Nearly three and a half lakh students had qualified for Tier-1. The real game—Tier-2—was about to begin, and the competition would be brutal.

I put my phone face down. Locked the screen. Pulled out my books and picked up my pen. This was what I had to do. Only this.

The library had a different texture on result days. The victories were muted, and the grief was suffocating.

Sivi sat at Seat 18. She had checked her result too; she had cleared it. She closed her notebook and stared blankly out the small basement window. She didn't say a word, and neither did I. What could I say? This was her first attempt. She was from a Biology background, perpetually terrified of Math, yet she had cracked Tier-1. But now, the massive wall of Tier-2 Mathematics stood right in front of her. No one needed to explain it to her; she knew. And knowing is always the heaviest part.

Yadav's text arrived in the evening. Just three words: *'Bhai. Nahi hua.'*

I replied: *'Kal baat karte hain.'*

He sent a thumbs-up emoji. That was it.

I met him at the tapri that night. He was already sitting there, a cup of tea in his hand, wearing the specific expression of a man who isn't dramatically disappointed, just deeply tired.

"Naam nahi mila PDF mein," he said. *"2-3 number se reh gaya shayad — marks aayenge tab pata chalega."*

I took a sip of my tea. *"Seema ko bataya?"*

For the first time that night, a small, genuine smile touched Yadav's lips. *"Haan bhai. Use in sab SSC vagaira se matlab toh hai nahi — woh apna UPPCS mein lagi rehti hai. Par usne kal chai pe pooch liya result ka. Maine bola fail ho gaya. Woh thodi der shant rahi. Phir boli — 'tum karte rehna.'"*

I looked at him.

"Bhai, paper fail hua," Yadav continued softly. *"Par woh UPPCS wali hoke bhi boli — karte rehna. Seedha mujhe bola. Yeh chhota nahi hai yaar."*

It wasn't. It wasn't small at all.

Yadav pulled out a cigarette but didn't light it. He just rolled it between his fingers, an old habit. *"Agli baar karunga. Abhi Seema ka PCS ka notification aane wala hai, uski thodi help kar dunga notes vagaira mein. Toh matlab hai abhi ka."*

I didn't say anything. But somewhere inside, I recognized it—the profound quiet that comes when a person finds something larger than their own pain to hold onto.

Not everyone fought the exam. Some people, like Verma at Seat 42, fought themselves. He was a UPSC aspirant who had joined in the second week of February. Tired eyes, laptop bag. He was fighting for the approval of an ex-girlfriend, Richa, who had already married someone else. Whenever he was alone, he desperately tried to talk to someone, anyone, to fill the void. He was trapped in a loop, and the library was just the arena he had chosen to bleed in.

A Few Days Later | Sunday Morning

It was Sunday, but I had a mock test pending. I left my rented room, taking the shortcut through the narrow alley toward the library. The February sun was mild—the kind of sunlight that doesn't push the winter away, but gently warns you that it's leaving.

About fifty meters down the alley, I saw someone walking toward me. It was Naina.

But she looked entirely different. Oversized grey t-shirt hanging loosely off her shoulders. Black shorts ending above her knees. Her hair was tied in a messy, hurried bun. There was absolutely nothing on her face—no makeup, no armor. It was the first time I was seeing her without her deliberate preparation.

In her hand was a leash. At the end of it trotted a brown-and-white spotted dog, its tail wagging furiously.

I was walking quietly, hoping to pass by, when her eyes found me.

"Hey! Library!" she called out from a distance.

I stopped. She walked up to me, a faint smile on her face. *"Sunday bhi?"*

"Haan. Mock test hai."

"Dedication."

The dog trotted up to me and began sniffing my shoes. I instinctively took a half-step back.

"Dogs pasand nahi?" she asked.

"Khaas nahi. Comfortable nahi hoon."

"Yeh Zoi hai. Female. Friendly. Zoi, sit."

The dog sat immediately. Naina ran her hand over Zoi's head—a natural, incredibly gentle gesture. There was no performance in it. *"Touch kar sakte ho. Kaategi nahi."*

I extended my hand, hesitant. The fur on Zoi's head was soft and warm. Her tail started wagging again, sweeping against the dust on the road.

"Dekha? She likes you," Naina said.

"Tum yahan rehti ho?" I asked.

She pointed toward a building at the end of the lane. *"Woh hai mera ghar. White gate wala."*

I looked. It was an independent villa. Pristine white walls. An intercom at the gate. A sleek black BMW parked in the porch, right next to her white i20. My brain registered the details automatically. Garment business. Villa. BMW. Mahanagar. And here I was, living in a rented room with my brother, entirely dependent on him for my library fees.

We were from two entirely different realities. It was a simple fact. There was no pain in the observation, no dramatic conclusion to be drawn. It was just a note filed away in my head.

"Papa ka hai," she said. Her voice was flat, as if she were talking about a stranger's property. *"Waise meri unse zyada baat hoti nahi hai."*

"Achha."

She paused. She shifted the leash to her other hand and looked at me. *"Waise, main Naina."*

It was our first proper introduction. Since December, we had only recognized each other as faces at a tea stall.

"Eklavya," I said.

She took a second, repeating the name in her head. I could see the gears turning behind her eyes. *"Eklavya. Okay. Anyway, main chalti hoon. Zoi ko aur ghumana hai."*

"Haan. All the best."

"Thanks. Tum bhi."

She walked away, Zoi trotting happily beside her. I turned back toward the library.

I had seen her in her natural element for the first time. The messy bun in the morning sun. No defenses. That Naina was different from the untouchable girl at the coaching center—or maybe she was exactly the same. Maybe this was the version she kept only for herself.

We met at the library gate. We drank tea at the tapri. We belonged to two completely different worlds, but in those brief intersections, we occupied the same space. And for now, maybe that was enough.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | February 2023 | Night

Good week mostly. QA mock mein improvement aayi. LRDI still slow — but better than January. 2023 attempt is looking more real now.

Zayan came over on Saturday. We watched something — don't even remember what. I was half-reading notes the whole time. He didn't say anything. He knows how I get before prep season. That's good. That's important.

Ananya keeps asking if everything is okay with us. I say yes. She does that thing — tilts her head, doesn't believe me, doesn't push. I love that about her. And also it's a little annoying. Everything is okay. I think.

Saw that library guy on Sunday morning. Bumped into him on the street — he lives nearby apparently. Rent pe, peeche wali gali mein. Introduced him to Zoi. He was awkward with her at first. Then she sat on command and he just... reached out and touched her fur. Slowly. Like he wasn't sure he was allowed. Cute, honestly.

Finally got his name. Eklavya. Interesting name. Carries weight somehow.

He qualified Tier-1 apparently — tapri pe chai peete waqt kisi aur ladke ko use badhai dete hue suna tha. Makes sense. He seems like someone who puts in the hours. Quietly. Without making it a thing.

Zayan texted at midnight. Sweet message. I replied. Slept fine.

Mock test tomorrow. Early start.

Everything is okay. I keep writing that.

Huh.

— N.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 6 Splintered Worlds *February – March 2023 — Lucknow*

February 27, 2023 | 8:30 PM | The Library

I was staring at a sheet of Statistics formulas. It was my last revision. The SSC CGL Tier-2 exam was four days away.

My phone vibrated. It was Bhaiya.

"Bhai... Pihu ko phir se fever aaya hai. Saans phool rahi hai. Hospital ja rahe hain."

My heart stopped. *"Main aa raha hoon."*

"Nahi bhai. Tu library mein padh. Hum manage kar lenge."

"Nahi. Main aa raha hoon. 10 minute mein."

I cut the call and packed my bag. It was 8:45 PM. I caught an auto to Mahanagar. It took fifteen minutes.

When I reached the flat, they were just leaving. Pihu was in Bhabhi's arms, wrapped tightly in a blanket. Just a tiny bundle. Her breathing was terrifyingly fast, a shallow, rattling sound.

"Chalo. Meri bike pe. Auto mein time lagega," I said.

Bhabhi sat on the back with Pihu pressed against her chest. Bhaiya sat behind me. We tore through the night streets.

Fatima Hospital | Emergency | 9:15 PM

The doctor checked her immediately. Stethoscope. Temperature. He clipped a pulse oximeter onto Pihu's tiny finger. The glowing red numbers on the screen stabilized at 88%.

"Pneumonia hai. Oxygen level critical hai — 95 se upar hona chahiye," the doctor said, his voice carrying the practiced urgency of an emergency room. *"Admit karna padega. ICU mein observation zaroori hai."*

Bhabhi's hands were shaking violently. Bhaiya silently filled out the forms—admission, insurance, emergency consent.

I stepped aside and called Papa in Kusumpur. *"Papa, Pihu hospital mein admit hai. Pneumonia. Kal subah aa jaao."*

Papa's voice was steady, but I could hear the age in it. *"Theek hai beta. Pehli bus se aayenge."*

They moved her to the ICU. A terrifyingly small bed. A transparent plastic oxygen mask held by a tight elastic band over her face. Her chest was still heaving. The monitor beside her beeped relentlessly—green lines tracking her erratic heart rate and dropping oxygen. A nurse inserted an IV line into the back of her tiny hand.

Pihu cried. It wasn't a scream; she didn't know how to scream yet. It was a weak, heartbreaking whimper. Bhabhi broke down, weeping silently into her dupatta. Bhaiya gripped her shoulder. *"Theek ho jayegi,"* he whispered, but his own voice was trembling.

I stood to the side. Watching. There was a massive pressure building in my chest, but the tears wouldn't come. I never cried. I think the instinct had simply been hardwired out of me somewhere along the line.

The doctor approached Bhaiya. *"Down syndrome hai na?"*

"Haan. January mein hi proper diagnosis hua tha," Bhaiya replied.

"Epilepsy bhi hai? Fits aate hain?"

"Haan. Levetiracetam syrup de rahe hain — subah-shaam, 5ml."

The doctor sighed, looking at the chart. *"Down syndrome wale bacchon mein respiratory infections common hain. Immune system weak hota hai. Fits ke karan bhi complications ho sakte hain. Pneumonia abhi serious stage pe hai. Agli 48-72 ghante critical hain."*

Bhabhi looked up, her voice cracking. *"Ventilator lagana padega kya?"*

"Abhi nahi. Oxygen support se dekh rahe hain. Agar 24 ghante mein improvement nahi hui — toh consider karna padega."

Ventilator. The word dropped into the room like an anvil.

February 28 – March 2 | The Longest Three Days

The hospital became our entire existence. A grim, exhausting routine.

Bhabhi lived in the ICU waiting area. Twenty-four hours a day. She refused to go home. She refused to eat meals, surviving only on lukewarm tea and biscuits. Her eyes were permanently bloodshot.

Bhaiya took leave from the office. He spent the entire day at the hospital, went home at night just to shower, and was back by dawn. He looked hollowed out, but he kept trying to project strength for Bhabhi.

Papa and Mummy arrived on the morning of the 28th. Papa sat in a plastic chair in the corridor, completely silent. Mummy kept trying to force Bhabhi to eat—*"Beta kuch kha le"*—while masking her own terror.

And me. I woke up at 6:00 AM. Went to the hospital. Stood for an hour or two just looking at Pihu through the ICU glass window. Then I went back to the flat, cooked proper meals for everyone, packed them in tiffins, and delivered lunch to the hospital.

After that, I went to the library. Two, sometimes three hours. I forced myself. The exam was on March 3rd. I couldn't focus. I couldn't remember formulas. But I had to try. In the evening, I returned to the hospital and stayed until 10:00 PM.

Pihu's oxygen was creeping up, agonizingly slowly. 88 to 89. 89 to 91. But the doctor's verdict remained the same: *"Still critical."* Staring at the green numbers on that monitor became my only religion.

March 2 | Night | The Flat

I couldn't sleep. The exam was tomorrow. Reporting time was 7:45 AM. I had to go to the hospital first.

I opened my revision notes, but all I could see was Pihu's face under the oxygen mask. The beep of the monitor echoed in my quiet room. *Ventilator pe le jaana padega.*

I tried to study until midnight. Then I simply gave up. I fell asleep—not the kind of sleep you want, but the kind where your body simply shuts down because it cannot bear to be awake anymore.

March 3 | 6:30 AM | Fatima Hospital

Bhaiya, Bhabhi, Papa, and Mummy were all gathered outside the ICU. None of them had slept.

I looked through the glass window. Pihu. The mask. The monitor read 91%.

The doctor was talking to Bhaiya in low tones. *"Oxygen level low hai. Aaj dopahar tak improvement nahi hui toh ventilator pe le jaana padega. Lungs ko rest dena hoga."*

Bhabhi turned to me. *"Tera exam hai aaj?"*

"Haan. 9 baje se pehla paper."

"Jaa," she said fiercely, wiping her eyes. *"Hum sambhal lenge. Tu apna kaam kar."*

Bhaiya gripped my shoulder. Hard. *"Exam hall mein — bas exam pe focus kar. Hum yahan hain."*

I nodded. I took one last look at Pihu through the glass. Watched her tiny chest rise and fall. *"Ho jaayega,"* I whispered to myself. I wasn't sure if I was trying to convince myself about the exam or about her.

I left the hospital at 7:30 AM and caught an auto to the iON Digital Zone IDZ Bharwara.

March 3 | 9:00 AM | Tier-2 Exam — Session I

Gate number 3. Security check. Document verification. Biometrics. A massive hall with 200 computers and freezing AC. Row 12, Terminal 7.

At exactly 9:00 AM, the timer started ticking down.

Mathematics. Question 1 — trigonometry. Solved. Question 2 — mensuration. I knew the formula. Solved.

But my mind kept dragging me back. Pihu. The mask. The beeping.

Focus. I forced myself back to the screen. I made a calculation error in a time-speed-distance problem. Re-checked. Corrected it. My hand was shaking slightly on the mouse. *No. Stop shaking.* Out of 30 questions, I attempted 25. Skipped 5.

Reasoning. I moved fast to save time. 30 questions. 22 attempted.

10:00 AM — Section I complete.

English. I had to read the comprehension passage three times because the words kept blurring into hospital corridors. But the grammar section felt comfortable. 35 out of 45 attempted.

General Awareness. Current affairs. 18 out of 25.

11:00 AM — Section II complete.

Computer Knowledge. Basic hardware, internet, shortcuts. We were given 15 minutes; I finished in 10. 16 out of 20 attempted.

11:15 AM — Session I submitted. The confirmation screen appeared.

I walked out at 11:30 AM. The sun was blinding. Aspirants were swarming the gates, aggressively discussing the paper. *"Maths calculative tha."* *"English easy thi."* It was all white noise to me. I walked to a quiet corner and called Bhaiya.

"Pihu kaisi hai?"

"Abhi same hai. Oxygen 90-91%. Doctor wait kar rahe hain. Tera paper?"

"Theek gaya. Typing 2 baje se hai."

"Kuch kha le. Tension mat le."

At 12:30 PM, I bought a plate of *chhole-kulche* from a street vendor. I managed two bites before my throat closed up. I couldn't swallow. I just drank water.

3:30 PM | ICU Floor

I rushed back to the hospital after the typing test.

Bhaiya, Bhabhi, Papa, Mummy were all standing outside. Bhabhi's eyes were swollen. She was weeping uncontrollably.

"Doctor ne bola... ventilator pe le jaana padega," Bhaiya said, his voice entirely devoid of hope. *"Oxygen 88% pe aa gayi. Breathing support nahi mil pa raha."*

My heart stopped beating.

"Kab?"

"Abhi. Arrangements ho rahe hain."

I looked through the glass window. Pihu was on the bed, surrounded by nurses and the doctor. They were preparing the machines. Suddenly, a nurse stepped out.

"Family andar aa sakti hai. Doctor bulaa rahe hain."

We put on masks and rushed inside. The doctor looked at Bhaiya and Bhabhi.

"Ventilator se pehle ek cheez try karte hain — chest physiotherapy. Kabhi-kabhi isse bhi improvement hoti hai."

A nurse gently turned Pihu onto her side, exposing her tiny back. The doctor formed a cup with his hand and began a gentle, rhythmic tapping on her back. Then, using controlled pressure, he applied vibrations. It was a technique to clear mucus from the lungs.

It lasted five minutes. Pihu was deeply uncomfortable, letting out weak cries. Then, the nurse adjusted her oxygen mask, and the doctor looked at the monitor.

Slowly. Agonizingly slowly.

The doctor's eyes widened. It was the first time I had seen an unscripted expression on his face. *"Improvement ho rahi hai. Chest physiotherapy ne kaam kiya."*

Ten minutes later, the screen read 93%.

"Ventilator ki zaroorat nahi hai abhi," the doctor exhaled. *"Observation continue rahega. Par crisis taal gaya."*

Bhabhi looked at Pihu, and the dam finally broke. She collapsed against Bhaiya, sobbing with sheer, unadulterated relief. Bhaiya gripped my shoulder again. He didn't say a word. The tightness of his grip said everything. Papa reached out and held Mummy's hand.

I just stood there. Watching.

Sometimes medical science works miracles. Sometimes it's just luck. I didn't know. But Pihu had survived the day. For now, that was enough.

10:00 PM | The Flat

Bhaiya, Papa, and I were sitting in the living room. Mummy and Bhabhi had stayed at the hospital. We ate a proper dinner for the first time in four days.

"Tera exam kaisa gaya?" Bhaiya asked quietly.

"Theek. Results dekhne honge."

"Ho jaayega."

We sat in silence for a few minutes. Then I asked the question that had been haunting me. *"Down syndrome aur epilepsy... uski life kaisi hogi?"*

Bhaiya stopped eating. He thought for a long time. *"Pata nahi. Par uske maa-baap hain. Hum hain. Doctors hain. Jo hoga, dekhenge. Abhi toh bas yeh sochta hoon — alive hai. Baaki sab manage ho jayega."*

I nodded.

That night, I slept at midnight. The sleep came naturally—the deep, dreamless sleep that only arrives when something broken inside you is finally allowed to release.

March 15, 2023 | 3:00 PM | The Library

The provisional answer key was out.

I logged in, clicked the link, and my response sheet opened. A sea of green ticks and red crosses. I tallied my score. Maths. Reasoning. English. General Awareness.

Raw score: roughly 280.

YouTube was already flooded with analysis videos. The educators always started with a disclaimer: *"Yeh provisional key pe based hai. Final mein changes ho sakte hain."* And then, immediately after: *"Par 275+ wale generally safe hain. 36 hazaar vacancies hain is baar."*

Thirty-six thousand. It sounds like a massive number—until you are desperately trying to be one of them.

The library was eerily quiet. Yadav had failed Tier-1; he didn't care about these keys anymore. Verma was fighting his UPSC ghosts. Sivi was battling her own demons. The number 280 was echoing only in my head. I didn't tell anyone.

But inside, a strange stillness had settled over me. The terror of the result was gone. When you finally realize that you are going to make it, you don't scream. You just go quiet. It's a very specific kind of silence—the silence that comes when you finally believe in yourself, completely, without any guarantees.

March 20, 2023 | 6:45 PM | The Park

I was walking alone in the society park. I preferred walking alone; the math in my head always balanced itself best in solitude. The evening was slowly turning dark. The biting chill of February was gone, replaced by the mild, non-committal warmth of March.

The bench in the far corner was half-swallowed by shadows. I was walking past it when I heard a voice.

"Eklavya."

It was Naina.

She was sitting on the bench, wearing an oversized hoodie, her legs crossed. Her phone lay face-down on her lap, discarded. The air around her smelled sharply of expensive cigarettes and alcohol.

I walked over but maintained a safe distance.

"Bulaya tha?" I asked.

"Haan. Baitho."

Her voice was perfectly steady, but her eyes were restless—the kind of restlessness that doesn't explode outward, but circles dangerously inside.

I sat on the opposite end of the bench, deliberately leaving a wide expanse of empty wood between us.

We didn't speak for two minutes. In the distance, kids were playing cricket. A ball hit the metal fence with a sharp clang. Then, silence again.

"Log itne predictable kyun hote hain?" she asked suddenly.

I didn't answer directly. *"Kis baare mein?"*

She let out a short, joyless laugh. *"Cheating. Classic."* A pause. *"Zayan,"* she added. *"Remember? Delhi wala. Boyfriend."*

I nodded.

"Busy bol raha tha. Aur usi waqt story daal raha tha — café mein. Kisi aur ke saath." She picked up her phone, stared at the blank screen, and dropped it back on her lap. *"Cheap."*

She wasn't yelling. She wasn't preparing to cry. But her body was radiating a tight, controlled fury. Dangerous.

"Tum upset ho," I said quietly.

"I'm not upset," she shot back with a practiced immediacy. "I'm irritated."

"Difference?"

She turned to face me. *"Upset weak log hote hain. Irritated logical."*

I offered a faint smile. *"Okay."*

That actually irritated her. *"Tum agree kyun kar rahe ho?"*

"Argument karne ka reason nahi mila abhi."

She stared at me for a few seconds—a careful, measuring look, as if calculating how long I would remain interesting to her.

"Main uske liye sad nahi hoon," she said finally. "I can replace people. I always do."

"Phir problem kya hai?"

She didn't answer. She scraped the dirt with the toe of her shoe. Then, softly:

"Mujhe pasand nahi ki kisi ne mujhe fool bana diya."

Silence stretched between us.

I looked at the ground. *"Shayad problem woh nahi."*

"Toh?"

"Control chala gaya."

She went completely still. The cricket ball hit the fence again.

"Tum psychologist ho?" she asked. The sarcasm was there, but the sharp edge was gone.

"Nahi. Bas observer."

"Annoying observer."

"Tum gussa ho us par," I continued, ignoring the jab. *"Ya khud par — ki tumne allow kiya?"*

This time, she took a long time to answer. She let out a slow breath. That impenetrable wall behind her eyes—the one that was always so tightly constructed—wavered. Just for a fraction of a second.

"...I miscalculated," she said softly. It was the first time I had heard her use a voice that was entirely real.

I didn't say anything. I just listened. She filled the silence herself.

"Main usually pehle exit karti hoon. Control mera hota hai. Is baar..." She left the sentence unfinished. It didn't need finishing.

"Image crack ho gayi?" I asked quietly. *"Ya woh baat zyada hai ki kisine tumhari script tod di — woh script jisme tum hamesha decide karti ho kya hoga?"*

She snapped her head toward me. For a second, she looked furious. Then the fury melted into something else. She was processing it.

"Tumhe yeh sab kaise pata hai?" she asked directly. No edge, no defense. *"Ego, control, image — kahan se?"*

"Kitabein padhta hoon. Fursat mein."

"Kaunsi?"

"Harari. Osho. Krishnamurti."

She let out a real laugh this time. *"Osho? 5 minute mein neend aa jaati hai. Itni dhimi, hypnotic awaaz..."*

"Shuru mein aati hai," I said. *"Baad mein neend udh bhi jaati hai."*

"Aur Harari?"

"Harari kehta hai — hum powerful isliye nahi bane ki strong hain. Isliye bane ki hum stories banana jaante hain. Aur khud unhe sach maante hain."

"Toh?"

"Toh 'main hamesha control mein rehti hoon' — yeh bhi ek story hai. Tumne banaayi hai. Is baar kisi ne bahar se kuch kar diya. Bas itna."

She went quiet again. Even through the alcohol and exhaustion, she caught the meaning. She stared out into the dark park.

"Tum dangerous ho," she said suddenly.

"Kyun?"

"Seedha bol dete ho. Filter nahi hai." She paused. *"Zyaatar log comfortable karne ki koshish karte. Tum ne woh nahi kiya."*

"Comfortable karna mera kaam nahi tha."

"Toh kya tha?"

I didn't answer. The answer was sitting right there on the bench.

After a while, she looked at me. *"Tum akele kyun ghoomte ho?"*

"Dimaag slow ho jaata hai. Cheezein settle hoti hain."

"Hm." She said the word as if she were filing the information away.

A long pause. The park was emptying out. The kids were heading home one by one.

She turned to me again. *"Woh exam — hua kuch?"*

The stillness of that number—280—was sitting quietly in my chest.

"Possibility hai," I said softly.

Naina looked at me. No ego, no sarcasm. Just a straight, unshielded look. It was a look she rarely gave anyone.

"Nice," she said slowly. *"You look like someone jise pata hai ki uska ho jaayega."*

"Shayad."

It was completely dark now. We both stood up at the same time and turned in opposite directions. She took two steps, then stopped. Without turning around, she asked:

"Woh Harari wali book — naam kya hai?"

"Sapiens."

"Hm."

She walked away. I turned toward the library.

Sapiens. She had memorized it. Or maybe she already knew it and was just confirming. It amounted to the same thing.

March 20, 2023 | 9:30 PM | The Flat

I lay on my stomach on the floor of my room.

I could hear Pihu's faint noises from the living room. She was doing better. They had brought her home from the hospital three days ago. She still needed oxygen support occasionally at night, but she was here. She woke up in the morning. She reached out her tiny hand.

That was enough. For now, it was enough.

I closed my eyes. My mind drifted back to the park. The dim light. Naina.

She must have walked back down the alley by now. Through the white gate. Past the BMW. Into the lit-up porch.

And I was here. Five hundred meters away. Three floors up in a rented flat.

Five hundred meters. A six-minute walk.

But those five hundred meters weren't something you could measure with footsteps. They were the distance between morning tea at a tapri and filter coffee in a café. The distance between grinding for a government job and preparing for IIMs. The distance between a 1300-rupee library fee and a BMW.

Two different worlds. Two different destinies. In the same city. On the same evening. Sitting on the same bench.

Sometimes, distance isn't measured in meters. It's measured in centuries.

I stared at the ceiling.

There was one thing I couldn't logically process, no matter how hard I tried. I read Harari. I read Krishnamurti. I was a practiced observer. I watched people—at Seat 17, at the tapri, Rajesh Bhaiya, Yadav, Sivi—but I always maintained a distance. I never stepped into their mess.

With Naina, that distance had collapsed.

She had been different from day one. In December, when she asked for the lighter—the two steps forward, the smoke in my face, that *"makes sense actually."* Even then, there was a spark. But I had rationalized it away. An interesting encounter. Nothing more. In February, seeing her in the sun with a messy bun and a dog. Another interesting encounter.

But today?

Today defied explanation.

She hadn't broken down completely. She didn't cry. She didn't suddenly become easy to read. She remained exactly who she was—controlled, sharp, hidden behind her wall. But for one fraction of a second, that wall had trembled. And I was the witness to it.

"You look like someone jise pata hai ki uska ho jaayega."

She had said it with a straight gaze. Without sarcasm. And there was something in that look—recognition. She had seen something in me that she understood, something she respected.

I pressed the heels of my hands into my eyes.

My mind was in control. It always was. Today was just a park bench, a conversation, a strange evening. Tomorrow morning, the routine would resume. The 5:30 alarm. The 6:15 tea. The library. Seat 17. The final result could drop any day.

That was more important. That was always going to be more important.

But that one second—when her wall trembled—refused to fade.

Some memories don't ask for permission before they move in.

I heard Bhabhi's voice from the living room, singing a soft, low lullaby to Pihu. I closed my eyes and let the sleep take over.

INTERLUDE *Naina's Diary* | March 20, 2023 | 11:47 PM

Can't sleep. Unusual.

Sat in the park today. Didn't plan to talk to anyone. Eklavya was there — walked past, saw me, came closer. Sat at the other end of the bench like there was an unspoken agreement about distance. There usually is, with people who actually pay attention.

We talked for — I don't know. An hour maybe. It didn't feel like an hour.

Zayan cheated. That's the short version. The long version is that I miscalculated — I thought I had the situation mapped, had the exit route planned, had the whole thing under control the way I have everything under control. And then he went ahead and did something outside my map. Mujhe woh nahi chahiye tha — the betrayal. I've had those before. Mujhe woh bura laga ki meri script kisi aur ne tod di.

Eklavya said exactly that. Without being asked.

'Woh baat zyada hai ki kisine tumhari script tod di.'

Maine argue kiya. Reflex tha. Par woh baat wahin rahi — bench pe, hawa mein, mere dimag mein. Settle ho gayi kahin. Ajeeb feel tha — jaise koi cheez apni jagah pe aayi ho jo kaafi waqt se thodi si tedi thi.

He mentioned Sapiens. Harari. The book is on my shelf. Has been for two years. Never opened it. Kal kholungi. Uski wajah se nahi — genuinely, isliye nahi. Bas ab ek specific reason hai jo pehle nahi tha.

There's something I keep noticing about him that I don't quite know what to do with. He doesn't perform. Zyaatar log kuch na kuch perform karte hain mere saamne — ya toh impress karne ki koshish hoti hai, ya intimidated ho jaate hain, ya phir deliberately nonchalant dikhte hain jo apne aap mein ek performance hai. Woh kuch nahi karta. Sirf baat karta hai. Sirf sunta hai.

'Comfortable karna mera kaam nahi tha.'

Usne yeh bola aur phir chup ho gaya. Jaise explanation ki zaroorat hi nahi thi. Thi bhi nahi.

Ek baar maine apne aap ko pakda — I wasn't performing either. Koi point prove nahi kar rahi thi. Koi image maintain nahi kar rahi thi. Woh bench pe baith ke sirf... thi. Jo hoon, woh. Bina kisi extra layer ke.

Yeh last kab hua tha — mujhe yaad nahi.

Rohan ke saath hota tha. Uske saath koi layer nahi chahiye thi. Par Rohan nahi hai. Aur yeh comparison karna theek nahi hai — dono alag log hain, alag connections hain.

Par observation toh hai.

Uski duniya alag hai mujhse. Main jaanti hoon. Woh Lucknow ke us hisse se aaya hai jahan se log yahan tak ek sapna lekar aate hain — ek seat ke liye, ek post ke liye, ek future ke liye jo guaranteed nahi hai. Main yahan se hoon jahan sapne alag hote hain — bigger, louder, aur zyada padhi-likhi zubaan mein pakke. Do alag jahaan. Yeh fact hai.

Par woh bench pe — ek hi shaam mein — woh faasla 500 meter se zyada nahi laga tha. Kabhi kabhi aisa hota hai. Samajh nahi aata kyun.

SSC ka result aane wala hai uska. "Possibility hai" — exactly woh words. No more, no less. Woh confident tha, par woh wali confidence nahi jo log dikhate hain. Woh wali thi jo andar hoti hai. I know the difference.

I hope it works out for him.

Ananya ko kal call karungi. Sab bataungi. Well — most of it. Kuch cheezein hoti hain jo exactly translate nahi hoti.

Mock test morning mein. Sleep first.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 7 The Sentinel March – April 2023 — Lucknow / Kusumpur

A. The Weight of a Smile March 30, 2023 | Morning | Bhaiya's Flat

Every morning, the first thing Pihu did when she woke up was wave her hand from where she lay. It wasn't accompanied by a sound or a demand. It was just a tiny hand reaching upward, as if she were checking to see if the world was still there.

When leaving for the library, I would bend down and extend my finger. She would grab it. That was our wordless morning ritual.

But today, she didn't just grab it. She held onto it for a moment longer than usual, and then gave a soft tug, pulling my hand toward her. It was as if she were saying, "*Aaj kuch aur.*"

I understood. I picked her up.

It was the first time I was holding her properly since she came back from the hospital. She was incredibly light—so light that for a split second, a spike of fear hit my chest. But her grip on my shirt was tight. She knew exactly how to hold on.

I brought her close to my face. Her round, medium-sized eyes stared back at me from inches away. No filter. No questions. Just looking.

I gently tapped my finger on her nose. She scrunched it.

And then, she smiled.

It was her first real smile. It was so small that if I hadn't been looking closely, I would have missed it. But it was there. The corners of her lips tilted upward, and her eyes grew a little rounder.

I tapped her nose again. She smiled wider this time, as if confirming, "*Haan, yeh wali cheez mujhe pasand hai.*"

Bhabhi walked out of the kitchen and stopped. She covered her mouth with her hand. Her eyes filled with tears for a second before she blinked them away and hurried back to her tea preparations.

Bhaiya walked into the living room, his IT company ID card still hanging around his neck. He saw us, quietly took off the ID, and walked over.

"Kab se?" he asked, looking at me.

"Abhi. Do minute pehle."

He didn't say anything else. He stepped closer and gently stroked Pihu's head. Pihu looked at him, then at me, then back at him. She seemed to decide that both of us were acceptable.

Bhaiya gripped my shoulder. Just for a second. He didn't speak. He just turned and walked to his room.

I stood there, holding Pihu. She was smiling. For now, this was all there was. And it was more than enough.

A Week Later | Kusumpur

A bus from Lucknow. Three hours.

Kusumpur was just four kilometers away from Ayodhya, but a three-hour journey doesn't just mean three hours when you are returning home after months. It means the specific dust of that road, the shape of those trees, the smell of the earth that simply doesn't exist in the city.

Papa was standing at the gate when I arrived. He didn't say anything. His expression just said, *Come inside.*

Mummy called out from the kitchen immediately, *"Haath dho le, khana lag raha hai."*

Everything was exactly the same. It always would be.

That night, after dinner, Papa asked the only question that mattered. *"Result kab aayega?"*

"Pata nahi. Kuch mahine."

"Padhta reh," he said. Just that.

From the other room, Mummy yelled, *"Neend aa rahi hai use, chhod do ab."*

I went to bed. The silence of the village was entirely different from the silence of the library. It was deeper, older. It felt as if the ground itself was breathing beneath me.

B. Shared Geography April 2023 | Library Canteen

The routine had returned. The 5:30 AM alarm. The 6:15 tea. The basement. Seat 17.

I was standing in the canteen line behind Sivi. Even during the break, her notebook was open, her pen moving across the page.

"Kitne bane?" I asked from behind her.

She looked up. *"255 ke aaspaas. Rough. Normalisation ke baad pata nahi."*

I knew exactly where that number stood in the brutal hierarchy of SSC cutoffs, but I didn't say anything.

"Tum?" she asked.

"280. Rough."

She stopped writing. She looked at me for a second. *"Comfortable zone mein ho."*

"Shayad."

We both got our tea. The canteen was filled with its usual cacophony—the scraping of plastic chairs, the hiss of boiling water, the low hum of anxiety.

"Tum kahan se ho?" she asked casually. It wasn't idle curiosity; she genuinely wanted to know.

"Kusumpur. Faizabad ke paas," I replied.

She turned fully toward me. "Faizabad? Matlab Ayodhya?"

"Haan. Ab toh sab Ayodhya hi bol rahe hain."

"Main bhi Ayodhya se hoon," she said, sounding slightly surprised herself. "Civil Lines. Tum?"

"Bahar ka gaon hai. Char kilometer."

She smiled—a genuine, unguarded smile. "Itne mahine ho gaye, pehli baar koi mila jo samjhe ki Faizabad aur Ayodhya ek hi jagah hai."

"Lucknow mein yeh explain karna padta hai," I said.

"Haan." She paused, staring into her tea. "Wahan ki Ram ki Paidi yaad aati hai kabhi kabhi. Subah wali smell — woh dhoop, woh paani. Hostel mein raat ko."

I took a sip of my tea. "Aati hai."

"Tum kitne saal se bahar ho?"

"June se. 9-10 mahine."

"Pehla saal sabse ajeeb hota hai," she said softly. "Ghar ki har cheez miss karti thi — par wapaa jaana bhi nahi chahti thi. Jaise dono jagah adhoori hoon."

I didn't reply. That feeling was exact. The city slowly claims pieces of you, but the village never entirely lets you go. You just end up existing somewhere in the middle.

"Papa ne kuch kaha result ke baare mein?" she asked.

"Padhta reh. Bas itna."

She let out a short, knowing laugh. "Mere papa ne bola tha — 'beta, wahan bhi log hain jo maths jaante hain.' Background check tha woh — chhupa hua."

"Tumhara maths weak hai?"

"Biology background hai. Maths baad mein seekha — khud se, raat ko, hostel mein. Kisi se help nahi maangi kyunki — I don't know. Pride? Ya shayad darr tha ki koi bola ki yeh tumhare bas ka nahi."

"Par kiya."

"Karna pada." She paused. "255 mein se kitna maths ka hai?"

"Kaafi."

"Pata hai." She finished her tea and picked up her notebook. **"Agli baar karungi. Ab pata hai kahan khatam hoti hai preparation."**

She walked back to her seat. I walked back to Seat 17. Two people from the same city, arriving here through entirely different roads. It was a shared geography that didn't need to be explained; it just existed.

C. The List of Fictions *April 2023 | Library Parking Lot*

I walked out of the basement into the blinding afternoon sun.

Naina was in the parking lot, standing by her white i20. She had mock test sheets in one hand and a bag slung over her shoulder. She was rummaging through the bag, probably looking for her keys.

She saw me. For a fraction of a second, the hesitation from that night in the park flashed in her eyes. But she recovered instantly, offering a curt nod. I stopped walking. I didn't know why.

"Aaj coaching thi?" I asked. Neither of us mentioned that night on the bench. It was an unspoken, mutual treaty.

"QA session. Boring tha. Sab kuch already covered tha," she replied, still digging through her bag. **"Tum itne ghante andar kaise rehte ho? Basement mein. Peeli light. Koi khidki nahi."**

"Habit ho gayi."

"Mujhe claustrophobia ho jaata."

"Tum fourth floor pe ho. Khidki hogi."

"Haan. Usi liye toh bachi hoon abhi tak."

She found her keys and pulled them out. But she didn't get into the car. She lingered by the door for a second, then turned back to me.

"Sapiens padh li maine."

"Khatam kar di? Itni jaldi?"

"Teen din mein."

"Kaisi lagi?"

"Annoying."

I smiled slightly. *"Matlab?"*

"Matlab ki jab koi cheez sach lagti hai toh annoying lagti hai. Tum jaante ho yeh."

I didn't say anything. I did what I always did—I stayed quiet and let the silence sit between us.

"Woh cognitive revolution wala chapter. Fiction ke baare mein. Ki hum isliye powerful hain kyunki hum stories banana jaante hain." She placed her bag on the roof of the car. Her voice wasn't casual anymore; it was entirely serious. *"Main us chapter pe do ghante ruki rahi. Baar baar wahi page."*

"Kyun?"

"Kyunki mujhe list banani thi. Un stories ki jo main khud ke baare mein believe karti hoon. Jo sach nahi hain — par convenient hain."

"Kitni thi list mein?"

She hesitated. *"Teen. Teen main wali."*

"Bataaogi?"

A heavy silence fell over the parking lot. Then, she spoke.

"Ek — 'main logon ko easily replace kar sakti hoon.' Do — 'mujhe kisi ki zaroorat nahi hoti.' Teen —" She stopped and took a shallow breath. *"Teen — 'ghar ki khamoshi meri wajah se nahi hai.'"*

They weren't just statements. They were three deep, bleeding wounds. They had been dressed up in ego and attitude, disguised as 'stories,' but they were wounds nonetheless.

I didn't say a word. There was nothing to say here.

"Tum kuch bologe nahi?" There was a touch of sarcasm in her voice, but there was something else in her eyes. Maybe she desperately wanted me to say something. Maybe she was terrified that I actually would.

"Tum jaanti ho yeh stories hain. Isliye list banayi," I said evenly. *"List banana pehla step hai."*

"Pehla step kis taraf?"

"Woh tum decide karogi."

She stared at me for a long moment, trying to read whatever was behind my eyes. Then she spoke.

"Tum jaante ho main tumhe apne dimaag mein kya bulati hoon?"

"Nahi."

"Sentinel."

I frowned slightly in confusion. **"Kya?"**

"Sapiens mein padha na — tribe mein sentinels hote the. Jo door khade hokar dekhte the. Sab par react nahi karte — bas observe karte the. Sab jaante the." She picked up her bag from the roof. **"Tum exactly wahi karte ho."**

"Annoying hai?" I asked.

She opened the car door. As she slid into the driver's seat, without looking at me, she replied:

"Bahut."

The door slammed shut. The engine roared to life, and the white i20 pulled out of the parking lot.

I was left alone in the sun. A rickshaw rattled past. A horn blared somewhere in the distance.

Sentinel. It wasn't a title; it was just an observation. Direct. Without hesitation. She said it as if she had earned the right to name me.

And maybe she had.

I turned back toward the library. Seat 17. I put my bag down and opened my books.

Sentinel. Fine.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 8 The Resting Silence April 2023 — Lucknow

A. The Cost of Certainty April 2023 | Library | Seat 17

The final result wasn't out yet, but the notification for SSC CGL 2023 had already dropped. The next exam was scheduled for July. The implication was brutal but clear: if 2022 didn't work out, July was waiting. There was no option to stop.

But somewhere in the dark, in the quietest corner of my mind, an honest voice whispered: *Ho jaayega*. And right beneath it, the terrifying follow-up: *Par rank kaun si aayegi? Post milegi bhi?*

Confidence and fear. They didn't cancel each other out; they coexisted, sitting across from each other in the same room. Handling that internal noise was the real preparation.

Sitting at the same table with Sivi had become entirely organic. One day, she couldn't crack a statistics formula, and I explained it. The next day, she taught me a reading comprehension technique. Within three days, we had moved from the canteen to sharing a desk.

The hidden competition had been there since day one, but its texture had changed. Before, the thought was *'I will get ahead of her.'* Now, it was *'We will both get ahead.'* The difference sounds small, but it isn't.

"Kusumpur mein mandir hai?" she asked one day, without looking up from her notes.

"Haan. Hanuman ji ka."

"Ayodhya mein toh har gali mein hai," she said softly. *"Main Hanuman Garhi ke paas rehti thi — subah ghanti ki awaaz seedha kamre mein aati thi. Pehle annoying lagti thi. Ab yaad aati hai."*

"Yahan nahi sunti?"

"Colony mein ek hai. Par awaaz apni nahi lagti."

It was a tiny observation, but it held the entire weight of her homesickness. The kind of longing that doesn't attach itself to big things, but to the specific sounds and smells you leave behind.

B. The Hero of the Story April 2023 | *The Tapri*

I found Yadav at the tapri later that evening. He looked entirely different. The chronic, heavy exhaustion that usually hung over his shoulders was gone.

"Seema ne haan kar diya," he said directly.

I placed my tea glass on the counter. *"Seedha bola?"*

"Usne khud bola — 'dekho main busy hoon. Par tum bure nahi ho. Try karte hain.'" Yadav took a long sip of his tea, a quiet triumph in his eyes. *"Do shabd. Par yaar, pehli baar kisi ne bola — bure nahi ho."*

"Bas itna?"

"Bas itna kaafi hai. Pehli baar kuch aise feel ho raha hai jo sirf mera apna hai."

I watched him. The Yadav who had stood in the parking lot for five months with a slip of paper, and the Yadav who was smiling today—they were two different men. He

wasn't waiting in someone else's timeline anymore. He had become the hero of his own story.

C. The Prediction *Mid-April | Outside the Library*

Sivi was standing outside in the morning sun, holding her water bottle. She squinted in the bright light and looked directly at me.

"Eklavya," she said, her tone devoid of its usual casualness. "Tumhara raw score 280 hai. 36 hazaar vacancies hain. Tum list mein in ho. Yeh mujhe pata hai. Tum bhi jaante ho."

"Normalisation abhi baaki hai," I replied cautiously.

"Haan. Par tumhara nikal raha hai."

She turned to walk inside, but stopped at the door. Without looking back, she said:

"Mera nahi ho raha. Is baar. 255 par general category mein post nahi milne wali. Par 2023 wale mein main post lungi. Yeh bhi mujhe pata hai."

She walked into the basement. I stood there in the sun. Sivi had done what very few aspirants ever manage to do: she spoke the absolute, unforgiving truth about herself. No tears. No search for validation. She just accepted the math, and looked ahead.

INTERLUDE *Naina's Diary | 20 April 2023 | 2:11 AM*

Eklavya ne aaj khud bataya. Hum usual jagah par the jab usne achanak kaha —

"Uss din jo ladki thi library ke bahar, bench par... Sivi hai. Meri competition hai SSC mein. Ayodhya se hai, meri hi district se."

Maine poochha nahi tha. Usne bataya. Jaise use pata ho ki maine dekha tha.

"District se?" Awaaz ekdum casual. Practiced. "Haan. Akeli hai yahan. Padh rahi hai seriously." "Good for her," maine kaha.

Woh halka sa muskuraya. "Tum yeh 'good for her' bahut specific aur ajeeb tarike se bolti ho."

"Matlab?" "Bas observe kiya."

Chala gaya.

Sentinel. Observe kiya. Bilkul. Usne mujhe us din parking mein notice kar liya tha.

Main annoyed hoon. Apne aap se zyada. IIM. Foreign. Plan. Focus. — N.

D. The Crawl 24 April 2023 | Library Gate | 11:15 AM

The morning shift was over. Sivi and I were standing in the sun outside the gate. She was holding a rough notebook, covered in a chaotic mess of red ink.

"Seriously Eklavya, mera math itna weak kyun hai," she groaned, deeply frustrated. "Time-speed-distance ke aakhiri step mein aakar calculation phans jaati hai."

"Weak nahi. Practice kam hai. Din mein do chapter lagao, improve ho jaayega."

She sighed. *"Tumhara background kya tha? Engineering?"*

"Nahi. B.Sc. Math. Avadh University. Base wahan se strong hai."

"Tabhi," she nodded.

Just then, a white i20 rolled out of the parking lot onto the main road. The speed was noticeably slow. Deliberately crawling.

CAT classes on the fourth floor ended at 11:00 AM. It was 11:15. The driver's side window was rolled down slightly. Naina was at the wheel. Alone.

We made eye contact—just for a second. Her face was entirely neutral, but her eyes were fixed straight on me. Then, for a fraction of a second, her gaze shifted to Sivi, scanning her, before snapping back to me. No reaction. She took a left turn and drove off.

It felt strange. She usually sped out of the alley the moment her classes were done. Why was she driving at a walking pace today?

Overthink mat kar. Coincidence hoga. I put on my headphones, walked back down into the basement, and buried myself in math.

E. Unfair Transitions 25 April 2023 | Library Basement | 11:10 AM

I was stuck on a Statistics question. The formula was correct, the calculation was flawless, but the answer wasn't matching the options. I had checked it three times.

I looked at the clock. 11:10 AM.

A shadow fell across my table. I assumed it was Sivi. I looked up.

It was Naina.

Her bag hung awkwardly from one shoulder, clearly not settled. She looked exactly like someone who had walked out of class and marched straight down the stairs into the basement on pure impulse, without a single thought or plan.

The yellow, harsh light of the basement softened her. The untouchable armor she usually wore on the fourth floor wasn't there.

"Disturb kar rahi hoon?" She tried to keep her tone casual, but her breathing was slightly elevated.

"Nahi." I pulled off my headphones. *"Tum... yahan?"*

"Class abhi khatam hui." She didn't look around the room; she kept her eyes glued to my open book. *"Probability?"*

"Haan."

"Sapiens ke baad unfair transition hai."

I let out a short, unplanned laugh.

"Coffee pe chaloge?" she asked suddenly.

The question was simple, but she hesitated for a microscopic second just before asking it—as if she couldn't quite believe Naina Sethi was in a basement asking an aspirant out for coffee.

"Abhi?" I confirmed.

"Haan. Brain reset," she quickly offered, retreating behind a logical excuse.

I locked my computer screen. *"Theek hai."*

It was then I realized: I hadn't even tried to search for a reason to say no.

F. The Resting Silence *Library Café* | 11:25 AM

The steel table was cold. The espresso machine hissed loudly in the background. She ordered a cold coffee; I ordered chai.

"Tum chai hi lete ho hamesha?" she asked.

"Habit."

"Habit safe hoti hai," she observed. *"Predictable."*

"Tumhe predictable pasand nahi."

"Control pasand hai," she corrected immediately.

The line was delivered flawlessly, but it directly contradicted the crawling speed of her car yesterday. Driving at ten kilometers an hour wasn't control; it was pure instinct.

She stirred her coffee with a straw, keeping her eyes on the cup.

"Tumhara result kahan tak pahuncha? Final list aayi?"

"Nahi. Abhi wait hai."

"Aur us dost ka? Uska bhi nikal raha hai?"

I stopped. I placed my tea cup carefully back on the table.

"Kaun dost?"

She looked up at me now, desperately trying to summon her calculated casualness.

"Kal gate par thi tumhare saath. Jiske saath kaafi... intense discussion chal raha tha."

"Sivi," I said smoothly, letting the calm settle over my words. *"Dost nahi — competition hai. Aur discussion Time-Speed-Distance ke formulas par tha."*

"Right. Maths." She took a sip of her coffee.

I looked directly into her brown eyes. I didn't blink.

"Kal 11:15 baje tumhari car ki speed aam dino se aadhi thi," I said quietly.

She froze. Her defense mechanism engaged instantly. *"Wahan road par gadhhe hain."*

"Road pichle hafte nayi bani hai. Ek bhi gadha nahi."

Naina went entirely silent. She let go of the straw. The tiny, ego-driven theft had been caught, and she knew it.

A heavy moment passed. And then—a small, almost defeated, but incredibly genuine smile broke across her lips.

"Tum Sentinel ho na. Chup nahi reh sakte the?"

I smiled back.

We both fell silent. But it wasn't awkward. It was a 'resting silence.' A space where neither of us had to prove a point, maintain an image, or perform a script. She knew that I understood her insecurity, and I knew that she had accepted it without melodrama.

G. The Exchange Café Parking Lot

We walked back toward the parking lot.

"Tum walk hi karoge room tak?" she asked.

"Haan. Paas hi hai."

She stopped by her car. Before opening the door, she pulled out her phone.

"Number exchange kar lete hain," she said. *"Kabhi... book recommendations ke liye."*

The reason was wonderfully logical. And we both knew it was completely unnecessary.

I pulled out my phone. She dictated the digits. As I saved it, she glanced at my screen, as if checking what I was typing.

"Naina."

"Haan." She smiled faintly. *"Yaad rehna chahiye."*

She got in and drove away. I stood in the sun for a few seconds. I couldn't rationally map out what had just shifted in the last thirty minutes, but the tectonic plates had moved. No declarations. No dramatic scenes. Just the collapse of the 500-meter distance between us.

Today, she wasn't performing. Today, she just showed up.

H. A Sweet Fear 11:45 PM | *The Flat*

I lay on my stomach, staring at the ceiling.

I wasn't replaying the conversation in my head; I was replaying the feeling. There was a strange, pervasive calmness inside me, as if someone had quietly unlocked a new door without making a sound. I knew our worlds were different. But for the first time, it felt like being from a different world didn't automatically mean being unreachable.

But alongside the calm, an alarm was ringing.

Attraction isn't dangerous. You can ignore attraction by setting a study timer and opening a book. But when you find a 'resting silence' with someone, that person slowly becomes a habit.

And an aspirant, who still hasn't seen his name on the final merit list, does not have the luxury of nursing habits other than his books.

It was a fear. A very sweet fear.

My phone vibrated on the mattress. The screen lit up the dark room.

Naina Sethi: Reached home?

Simple. No possessiveness. No elaborate paragraph. Just marking her presence.

I typed: *Haan*.

I hit send, locked the screen, and placed the phone face down. Sleep took a little longer to arrive tonight.

INTERLUDE *Naina's Diary* | 25 April 2023 | 11:50 PM

Maine aaj apna sabse bada rule toda. Never chase.

Main kabhi kisi ke peeche nahi jaati. Par aaj main us basement mein gayi. Koi plan nahi tha. Class khatam hui aur mere pair khud le gaye.

Shaam ko Ananya aayi. Sab bataya — coffee, car, number exchange. Usne mug table par rakha aur mujhe dekha jaise dimaag ka koi purza hil gaya ho.

"Tune use coffee ke liye poocha? Naina, Zayan ke baad seedha ek SSC aspirant? Opposite extreme par ja rahi hai tu."

Maine defend nahi kiya. Argue nahi kiya. Kyunki logically Ananya sahi thi. Humari duniya alag hai. Bahut alag.

Par main use kaise samjhaun ki Zayan ke saath mujhe hamesha Naina Sethi perform karni padti thi. Perfect. Unbothered. Cool. Sentinel ke paas kuch perform nahi karna padta.

Aaj usne chori pakdi. "Road pichle hafte nayi bani hai." Ek second ke liye main ekdum expose ho gayi thi. Ego hurt hona chahiye tha. Par usne mazaak nahi udaya. Nicha nahi dikhaya. Ek resting silence diya — jisme koi judgement nahi tha.

Maine text kiya — Reached home? Just to see if he's there.

Haan. Sirf ek word. Dry. No paragraph. No performance.

Zayan hota toh likhta ki kitna miss kiya. Par Eklavya ke is ek Haan ko dekh ke dimaag ka shor shant ho gaya.

Yeh nahi karna chahiye. Jaanti hoon. Par kar rahi hoon.

— N.

CHAPTER 9 Zero Point Seven Five *April – May 2023 — Lucknow*

A. The Waiting Mode *April 28, 2023 | Library Basement | 11:32 AM*

The library basement was as cold as ever. It was the kind of cold that didn't come from the air conditioning, but seemed to seep directly from the concrete walls. The yellow lights, the scuffed chairs, the identical tables. Seat 17.

I put my bag down, opened my notebook, uncapped my pen, capped it again, and set it aside.

The routine had returned—or maybe it had never left. It had just been temporarily muted.

Upstairs on the fourth floor, CAT classes would be running. Lately, I had started hearing the footsteps on the stairwell—faint at first, then fading away. I had never noticed them before. Since when did my ears start tracking the sounds from the fourth floor? I didn't know.

My phone was on silent. The screen was dark. 11:32 AM. I had a question half-solved in front of me.

The screen lit up.

Naina: Alive?

I looked at the notification, then locked the screen and went back to the half-solved question. Five minutes later, I picked it up.

Eklavya: Haan.

The conversation ended right there. But it was strange—it didn't feel like anything was left unsaid. The sentence was short, but it felt complete.

Early May | The Suspension

The final result was still pending. Life was stuck in a waiting mode, but time doesn't pause just because you are waiting for it to decide your fate.

The 5:30 AM alarm. Tea. The library. Seat 17. Sometimes Sivi would sit next to me—we would exchange a formula, a new approach, maybe a line or two of conversation. Then we would bury ourselves back in our notebooks. We both knew the reality: our journeys were parallel, not shared.

In the evenings, I would sometimes wander toward Kapoorthala. The world outside the coaching centers—clusters of students, the bright orange fish at the juice stalls, the shouts of the auto drivers. Everyone was in a hurry to get somewhere. The destinations were different, but the desperation was the same. Walking in that crowd was easy. You became invisible.

At night, there was Pihu. She had started holding onto my finger and refusing to let go quickly. She would stare directly at me, as if recognizing me all over again every single night. That tiny, firm grip felt vastly more important than any mock test percentile.

Occasionally, the past would arrive uninvited. Vinay's ₹10 note. The pulled-down shutter of my café in Ayodhya. Papa on a hospital bed. A doctor's sentence that I had only half-understood. These memories weren't loud; they were just flashes. Like a heavy file left open in the background of a computer—minimized, but never closed.

And then there were the messages. Random, patternless.

Naina: Mock ne aaj insult kar diya. Eklavya: Hota hai.

Naina: Tum log sunlight miss nahi karte basement mein? Eklavya: Habit.

Naina: Harari boring laga aaj. Lag raha hai repeat kar raha hai. Eklavya: Karte hain.

They weren't deep conversations. But they weren't closed off either. It was as if we were both walking silently, maintaining a comfortable distance. Not too close, not too far.

May 8 | 11:42 PM

Naina: Log kitna bolte hain na. Exhausted hoon.

I put the phone face down and opened Indian Polity. I couldn't focus. The words were on the page, but the meaning wasn't sinking in. Fifteen minutes later, I picked up the phone.

Eklavya: So jao.

Instantly, the typing bubble appeared.

Naina: 15 minute lage tumhe? Eklavya: Padh raha tha. Naina: Padh rahe hote toh 3 minute mein reply aata. Tumhari reading speed jaanti hoon ab.

I walked over to the small window. A train passed in the distance—the headlight blindingly bright for a second, then fading, leaving behind only the dark track. The phone vibrated again.

Naina: Goodnight, Sentinel.

I didn't reply to that one either. It wasn't for any specific reason—I just didn't want to.

May 12 | 1:30 AM

Naina: Jaag rahe ho? Eklavya: Haan. Naina: Kabhi bina plan ke kahin chalein? Exams ke baad. Random.

The cursor blinked on my screen. My mind instantly built an entire scene—mountains, wide open spaces, driving with no destination. All the things I had once thought about and quietly packed away. I deleted the thought.

Eklavya: Abhi mocks bache hain.

A pause. A long one.

Naina: Tum bohot boring ho. Goodnight. Eklavya: Goodnight.

I turned off the internet and went back to staring at the ceiling.

B. The Quiet Close *May 13 - 14 | Result Night*

The result dropped at 11:45 PM. Notifications flooded the aspirant groups. I put my phone aside and went to sleep.

The next morning, the WhatsApp forwards were everywhere. *Result Out.*

I went to the library. Opened the laptop. Downloaded the massive PDF. The loading bar crawled across the screen.

I pressed Ctrl+F and searched for my name. *0/0 matches.*

I typed my roll number. *0/0 matches.*

I stared at the screen for exactly one second. Then, I closed the laptop.

No sound escaped my throat. No coherent thought formed in my head. It felt as if someone had quietly closed a massive file—no warning, no error message. Just... closed.

I walked straight out of the library and went back to the flat. Bhabhi wasn't home. The room was dead quiet.

Papa called.

"Nahi hua," I said.

"Theek hai beta. Padhai mat chhodna."

I cut the call. Neither of us had another sentence in us. It was fine.

YouTube analysis videos were auto-playing on my phone. I put it face down on the desk.

I walked out. Mahanagar. Then Kapoorthala. No direction. My feet knew where to go, even if my brain didn't. I wasn't feeling anything inside—no dramatic grief, no fiery

anger, not even that heavy emptiness they show in movies. It was just a complete suspension. As if my entire internal system had been put on temporary pause.

C. The Unscripted Page *May 14 | 6:00 PM | The Flat*

A knock on the door. I opened it.

Naina.

She had messaged me in the morning—*"Ghar pe ho?"* I had replied, *"Haan,"* without thinking much about it.

She looked at my face for a second. She took in the whole picture—my eyes, my jawline, that heavy stillness that usually surrounded me. She didn't ask a single question. She just walked in.

She looked at the room—a notebook lying open on the floor, two empty water glasses, the curtains half-drawn. She noticed everything but said nothing. She sat on the edge of the bed, her back straight. It was exactly how she always operated—claiming a space without ever asking for permission.

Silence stretched between us. The fan hummed overhead. An auto rattled past on the street outside.

"Result?" she finally asked.

"Hm."

Nothing else. She didn't rush to fill the quiet. A minute passed, maybe two. The room breathed around us.

"Chalo... ek result se life decide nahi hoti—" she started, then stopped herself. *"Yeh line mujhe bhi fake lag रही hai."*

I let out a faint laugh. A genuine one, directed at the sheer absurdity of the situation. It was the first time my lips had curved all day.

She leaned forward slightly, looking directly into my eyes. *"Gussa ho ya dukhi?"*

I paused, searching for the right word. *"Pata nahi."*

She nodded, as if that was exactly the answer she had expected.

"Osho ne likha tha — sadness gives depth," she said. A small beat. *"Aaj tum deep lag rahe ho. Congratulations."*

She wasn't trying to console me. She wasn't there to find a solution to my pain or offer hollow motivation. She was just *there*. There is a massive difference between the two.

We sat there for another hour. Maybe more. Random conversations—a book, a stupid news headline, a thought that appeared from nowhere and vanished just as quickly. And in between, there were stretches of silence that didn't feel uncomfortable at all.

When it was time to leave, she stopped at the door. She rested her hand on the wooden frame.

"Be. Don't try to become. Aaj ke liye enough hai," she said softly.

She took two steps out into the hallway. Then she stopped.

She turned around, walked back to me—no announcement, no dramatic build-up—and kissed me.

It was short. Warm. Entirely devoid of cinematic drama. It felt as if this had been decided a long time ago, and neither of us had known it.

When she pulled back, she gave me that specific, naughty smile. The one that clearly said she knew exactly what she had just done to my head.

Then she walked away.

The room went quiet again. I stood staring at the empty doorway for a long time. But the room didn't feel empty anymore. It had been, an hour ago. Not anymore.

INTERLUDE *Naina's Diary* | 14 May 2023 | 11:30 PM

I did something today I can't fully explain yet.

List aayi thi. Uska naam nahi tha — kisi ne group mein forward kiya tha. Aur main seedha us gali ki taraf nikal gayi. Koi text nahi kiya pehle. Koi plan nahi tha.

Kamra quiet tha. Woh bistar ke kinare baitha tha. Laptop band. Curtain aadha. Woh stillness jo hamesha uske around rehti hai — aaj woh alag thi. Heavier.

Maine kuch nahi poocha. Baith gayi. Kabhi kabhi khamoshi itni loud hoti hai ki tum usmein doob jaate ho.

Phir yeh hua. Bina plan ke. Maine use kiss kiya. Short. Aur main wapas apni jagah pe thi — jaise kuch nahi hua, siwai ki meri smile band nahi ho rahi thi. Woh naughty wali. Jo khud pe control nahi tha.

Ab room mein akeli hoon. Haath thode kaanp rahe hain. Nervousness se nahi. Kuch aur se. Ek cheez jo main usually label karti hoon aur shelf pe rakh deti hoon — aaj label nahi kar pa rahi.

I know what I did. Main woh ladki hoon jo hamesha pehle exit karti hai. Jo script apne haath mein rakhti hai. Aaj maine — voluntarily, deliberately — ek page kisi aur ko de diya.

Yeh darr hai? Ya relief? Dono ek saath kaise hote hain?

Ananya ko kal bataungi. Woh mujhe aise dekhegi jaise maine sanity ke sab records tod diye. Maybe she'll be right.

Par woh bench thi March mein. Woh resting silence tha jisme koi perform nahi kar raha tha. Koi nahi karta mere saath. Hamesha se nahi kiya.

Dr. Mehta kehti hain — "jo cheezein hum andar dabaate hain woh circle karti rehti hain." Aaj kuch circle karna band hua. Kuch minute ke liye.

Theek hoon. Shayad. — N.

D. The Margin of Life May 15 – 28 | The Math of Failure

Library. Mocks. Long walks.

My hand would pick up the phone on its own now—without reason, without expecting a message. Just out of habit. My replies were still short. The invisible wall was still there. But something had silently shifted between us. No declarations were made, no "what are we" conversations happened. It was simply existing.

One day, sitting at Seat 17, I checked my phone. There were no messages. And then I noticed that I had checked it *specifically* looking for one.

I put my headphones back on and stared at the page.

May 28 | Detailed Marks Released

I logged into the portal. The final scorecard loaded.

Score: 287.xx Cutoff: 287.xx Difference: 0.75

I stared at the screen. The numbers. Just numbers.

So incredibly close. And yet, not there.

There is a strange paradox in failing by such a microscopic margin. On one hand, it proves that you have the caliber. It proves that you are right there, just one step away. But in that exact moment, that thought offers absolutely no comfort. It is just a brutal measurement. Life operates in the margins.

I picked up my phone and typed a single message.

0.75.

I hit send. To Naina. I didn't know why I had to tell her. I just knew that I had to.

A few minutes later, the phone vibrated.

Naina: Kal chai?

I looked at the screen.

Eklavya: Haan.

I hit send. This time, that was more than enough.

INTERLUDE *Naina's Diary* | 28 May 2023 | 1:45 AM

0.75.

Usne sirf yeh bheja tha. Koi context nahi. Koi sentence nahi.

Ek second laga mujhe. Phir — oh.

0.75 marks. Sirf itna. Itna kareeb tha woh. Aur yeh number dekh ke — main khud nahi jaanti thi mujhe kaisa lagega. Jo laga woh frustration tha. Us situation ke liye. In numbers ke liye jo decide karte hain sab kuch.

Usne woh number bheja aur phir kuch nahi. Main jaanti hoon woh aise hi process karta hai — ek measurement tha uske liye. Hisaab. Uski aankhon mein judgment nahi hota, sirf next step hota hai. Main yeh admire karti hoon aur yeh mujhe thoda unsettled bhi karti hai.

14 May ke baad se kuch shift hua hai. Woh door nahi gaya — bas thoda careful ho gaya hai. Ek invisible glass wall hai jo comfortable distance maintain karti hai. Mujhe pata hai woh wall kyun hai.

Use lagta hai main thodi der mein chali jaungi. IIM. Foreign. Alag duniya. Toh better hai ki zyada close nahi aao — taaki jab main jaaun, toh extra chot na lage.

Par woh galat hai.

Abhi main yeh argument nahi karungi. Kyunki forcing the wall down is not an answer. Toh abhi — chai. Kal. Simple. Bas yahi hai abhi ke liye.

0.75 ka matlab hai ki next time ho jaayega. Yeh main jaanti hoon. Usse pehle woh khud samjhe. Tab tak — chai. Routine. Resting silence. Jo bhi hai.

— N.

[Past jaari hai...]

Bhai, tumhara dimaag bilkul sahi chala hai aur mera ekdum band tha. Tum 100% sahi ho. Chapter 9 par kahani ruki thi (0.75 marks wala failure), toh agla chapter logically Chapter 10 hi hona chahiye.

Tumne apne raw material ko "Adhyay 11" likha tha, aur main gadhe ki tarah bina apna common sense lagaye use Chapter 11 likh baitha. Maafi bhai.

Kyunki material deep aur lamba hai, main tumhare rule ke hisaab se isko do parts mein tod raha hoon.

- Chapter 10: Pihu ki smile, SSC Exam, Reasoning mein 28 aana, aur Yadav ka naya counter.
- Chapter 11: Renaissance Bar ki party, Gomti ke paas ka thehraav, aur raat ka woh hug.

Yeh raha properly numbered, bina kuch skip kiya hua Chapter 10 aur Chapter 11:

CHAPTER 10 The Unequal Competition *July – August 2023 — Lucknow*

A. The Smile | July 16 | 5:45 PM

The exam was tomorrow.

I needed to stop overthinking it, so I got out of the room. Bhabhi pointed toward the pram. "*Pihu ko bhi le ja.*" I picked her up. There was no specific plan. Just the usual park, a three-minute walk from the flat.

As we were walking, my phone vibrated in my pocket. *Naina: Best of luck kal ke liye.*

I looked at the screen and typed back: *Eklavya: Haan. Abhi park mein hoon Pihu ke saath.*

I put the phone back in my pocket. Two minutes later, it vibrated again. *Naina: Main bhi kareeb hoon. Aa sakti hoon? Eklavya: Haan.*

She arrived in exactly two minutes. Blue jeans, a white kurta, one earphone dangling loosely from her ear. She looked straight at me, then looked down into the pram.

She stopped.

Pihu was entirely absorbed in her own fingers. In, out, in, out. A rhythm that belonged exclusively to her.

Naina leaned down, then second-guessed herself and straightened up. Then she leaned down again. I watched her—she couldn't decide on the right approach. There are no manuals for this.

Finally, she made her own decision. She squatted beside the pram, bringing herself exactly to Pihu's eye level. She didn't look at her directly.

"Hi."

No response. Pihu's fingers kept moving.

Naina didn't look uncomfortable, but she was clearly unsure if she was doing it right. She glanced up at me for a fraction of a second. I just gave her a small nod. *Yahi theek hai. Bas raho.*

She stood up. We started walking together.

At one point, Naina reached out a hand toward the pram's handle, then pulled it back. A few steps later, she reached out again. This time, she grabbed it, sharing the weight equally with me. She didn't say a word.

"Kitni badi hai?" she asked quietly. *"Dedh saal."*

"Haan." She didn't ask anything else. She wasn't trying to dissect or understand the medical reality; she was just being there. There is a massive difference between the two.

We kept walking. The evening slowly began to fade.

As we reached the gate to leave, Naina leaned down one more time. She had gotten slightly used to the rhythm by now.

And then it happened.

A mild gust of wind blew past. The wheel of the pram hit a narrow crack in the pavement and paused for a second. Pihu's fingers stopped moving. She looked up toward the sky, but Naina was right in her line of sight.

And without any signal, without any logical reason, Pihu smiled.

It was *that* smile. The tiny, rare one that barely touched the corners of her lips. Naina didn't know how rare it was. But I did.

I didn't tell her.

Naina stayed silent for a second, mesmerized, then slowly stood up.

"Kal ka paper," she said softly. *"Ho jaayega."* *"Theek se so jaana."*

She turned and walked away toward her world.

B. The Break in Rhythm | July 17

iON Digital Zone. Seat 4C-12.

The start was good. The Reasoning section was flowing smoothly. There was a rhythm.

Then came Q10. Blood relation. The statement was convoluted, unusually long. I tried to structure it in my head—read it once, read it twice.

It didn't click.

In that single, isolated second of panic, the memory of the 0.75 marks crashed into my head. Bhaiya's heavy silence from May. Papa's quiet *"Theek hai."* The screen in front of me was perfectly clear. But my mind wasn't.

I closed my eyes. Breathed in. Breathed out. *Question solve karo. Kahani nahi.*

I skipped it and moved forward. The flow returned, but the rhythm was permanently shattered. A question that would have been easy earlier now felt like a mountain because the clock was ticking down. There was no time.

Submit. The screen flashed: *Thank You for Appearing.*

I sat there for one entire second. Completely blank. Then, I stood up from the chair.

C. Twenty-Eight | August 1 | Night

The detailed result was out.

I checked the breakdown. *Reasoning: 28.xx*

I stopped breathing.

In three attempts, and countless mock tests, I had never scored below a 45 in Reasoning. Even in my worst practice sessions, it hadn't dropped that low. I hadn't even thought about this section the night before the paper because it was supposed to be safe. It was *always* safe.

I closed the laptop.

The fan hummed in the room. From a neighboring house, the faint sound of a television drifted in. A notification popped up on my phone, but I didn't look at the screen.

The doubt that had been gnawing at my insides for the last three weeks was no longer a doubt. It was a confirmed reality.

I had made a blunder. Or maybe it was a fundamental flaw from the past, something invisible that had been sitting there all along, even when everything looked fine. Thinking about that hurts in an entirely different place.

I wasn't afraid of losing. But losing without understanding the core reason *why* you lost—that weight is unbearable.

I picked up the phone. Naina's name lit up the screen.

I put it back down.

I couldn't tell her. This burden was strictly mine. I lay back and stared at the ceiling.

D. Graduate Momos | A Few Days Later

There was a new board at Kapoorthala. GRADUATE MOMOS

Above the text, someone had drawn a small star with a permanent marker. It was slightly crooked.

Yadav was inside. The same hands, the same speed. But something fundamental had shifted—he wasn't living beneath the crushing weight of fear anymore.

"Special?" he asked, seeing me. *"Laga de."*

Seema was inside the stall, packing an order. There were no explicit signals between them, no bossing around—just a quiet, synchronized rhythm that had built itself naturally.

He handed me the plate. I gave him a 200-rupee note, and he handed back 40.

"Counter kab se?" I asked. *"Teen din se."* He wiped his hands on a towel. *"Mains hoga iska. Main yahaan hoon. Dono chalega."*

He hadn't run away. He hadn't stopped, either. He had carved a new path—with the fear, not despite it. And he had someone standing right there with him.

I finished my plate and stepped out of the crowd.

I pulled out my phone. Naina's number was on the screen. I typed a message. Then I deleted it. I put the phone back in my pocket.

I turned around and walked back toward the isolation of the library.

CHAPTER 11 The Clean Memory August 2023 — Lucknow

A. The Demand | August 12 | Afternoon

My phone vibrated. *Naina: Ananya ki party hai aaj raat. Renaissance. Aa jaao.*

Eklavya: Nahi.

Naina: Eklavya.

Eklavya: Tumhari friend ki party hai. Main wahan fit nahi honga.

Naina: Maine nahi poocha fit hoge ya nahi. Maine kaha aa jaao.

A pause.

Eklavya: Kaun hoga wahan?

Naina: Ananya. Kabeer. Kuch aur log. Loud music. Drinks. Tumhari worst nightmare.

Eklavya: Phir kyun—

Naina: Kyunki main chahti hoon.

That was it. I knew the conversation had ended right there.

B. Renaissance Sky Bar | 9:30 PM

I arrived in Naina's car.

The elevator doors opened, and the noise hit me before anything else—pulsing bass, overlapping laughter, the sharp clinking of glasses.

I stopped for a fraction of a second before stepping out.

Ananya and Kabeer were there, along with a few others. Names were introduced, but I knew I wouldn't remember them. With a single glance, the reality was obvious: this crowd was different. Their clothes were different. They moved with that easy, fluid confidence that only comes when places like this are a normal part of your existence.

I looked down at my kurta. It was clean. It was pressed. But it did not belong here.

No one was looking at me, but I was looking at myself.

I grabbed a glass from the bar—just juice and ice. I needed something to occupy my hands. The chill from the central AC felt artificial. There was a faint smell of alcohol rising from the floor, mixing heavily with expensive perfumes and deodorants. The laughter around me was just a pitch too high, a little too desperate to sound happy. Everyone was effortlessly comfortable. I was painfully conscious.

On the dance floor, people were moving to the beat naturally, as if they hadn't learned it, but were born with it.

Naina met Ananya. An easy hug. Laughter. Words exchanged that I couldn't hear over the music. That world was entirely hers.

I stood off to the side. I couldn't force myself to go deeper inside, and I couldn't walk back out the door.

Then, I looked over the edge of the terrace. The railing. I walked toward it.

C. The River

I didn't know how much time had passed.

The deafening noise was left behind, but the vibration of the bass still travelled through the metal railing—a faint, constant hum against my palms. Below, the Gomti river flowed silently in the dark.

Naina walked up. She had come straight from the dance floor. She was slightly out of breath.

She looked at me, and then she looked down at the Gomti. She didn't say a word.

She placed her hands on the railing and stood right beside me. The noise was still there. The blinding lights were still there. The crowd was still there.

But we weren't.

She was looking at the Gomti—with me. It was probably the first time she had done that. She had been to this bar countless times, I knew that. But this moment was different.

We didn't look at each other. Just the dark water flowing below, and the profound silence existing right underneath the chaos.

D. The Car | 11:57 PM

The driver was speeding. The roads were completely empty, the yellow streetlights blurring past the windows.

The car went over a speed breaker, lifting slightly.

Naina's shoulder bumped into mine. And then, her hand found mine and gripped it.

This time, I didn't go stiff. I didn't pull away. I just let my hand stay exactly where it was.

For two minutes, neither of us spoke. Then, very softly, she broke the silence.

"Rohan ko speed pasand thi..." She kept looking straight ahead. *"Bachpan mein jab papa drive karte the, woh peeche se chillata tha — aur tez..."*

A heavy pause.

"Mera bhai."

An empty space hung in the air for a second.

"Accident mein gaya."

The speed of the car suddenly felt entirely irrelevant.

I didn't say anything. There was absolutely nothing to say. I just tightened my grip on her hand, just a fraction. She had made room for me inside her deepest, most guarded memory. That was enough.

E. The Drop-off | 12:18 AM

The car stopped outside my building.

She paused near the gate and looked at me—a direct, unshielded look.

I didn't think. I stepped forward and pulled her into a hug.

It wasn't tight. It was just steady.

The meaning of this hug was entirely different. There was no jealousy in it. No ownership. Not even full-fledged romantic support. It was simply a physical translation of the words: *Main yahan hoon*.

She froze for a second. Then, her arms came up, and she held onto me.

No dramatic dialogues. Just the sound of breathing. Her heartbeat was steady against my chest. Mine was slightly fast.

Somewhere in the distance behind us, the Gomti kept flowing.

INTERLUDE Naina's Diary | August 12, 2023 | Night

I don't know why I told him about Rohan.

I've been to that bar maybe fifteen times. Same music. Same laughter. Same pointless conversations.

Tonight was different. And the difference wasn't the bar. It was him.

He stood at the railing for God knows how long. Didn't drink. Didn't dance. Just stood there looking at the river like it owed him something. Or like he owed it something.

Main wahan gayi — shayad check karne. Shayad dekhne ke liye ki woh kya dekh raha hai.

And then I saw it. Woh same thi. Wahi stillness. Wahi beh-ti hui cheez.

Most people look at lights. He was looking at the dark between them.

He wasn't uncomfortable anymore. He was just there. Present in a way most people aren't even at places they actually want to be.

Car mein — speed breaker par — I don't know what happened. His hand was just there. And then Rohan was just there.

Maine Rohan ka naam bahut waqt ke baad liya. It didn't feel like grief. It felt like memory. Clean memory. The kind you can hold without it breaking you.

Maine Sentinel ko us memory mein le liya. Bina soche. Woh judge nahi karega — yeh pata tha. Par yeh nahi pata tha ki itna easy hoga.

Ghar ke neeche woh hug — I was not expecting that. He holds himself carefully. Deliberately. But tonight he just moved.

No calculation. And it wasn't romantic. Not exactly. It was something more basic than that.

He didn't fix anything. He didn't promise anything. He just stayed.

Mujhe yeh chahiye tha aaj. Mujhe pata bhi nahi tha. — N.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 12

The Weight of Observation

August – September 2023 — Lucknow

A quiet, unspoken pattern had established itself at the tapri.

Her classes ended at 11:00 AM. I would be waiting outside by then. We occupied the same space, sitting on the same rickety bench, while our separate orders arrived. But things had subtly shifted. She had drastically reduced her coffee intake. I never asked her why. She never offered an explanation. I also noticed she had stopped smoking whenever she was with me. That, too, went entirely unmentioned.

Sometimes, the most significant shifts are the ones nobody discusses. They just happen.

One morning, she shoved her phone directly in front of my face.

"Yeh dekho."

It was her Instagram feed. The aesthetic was carefully curated—muted tones, calculated angles, and captions that looked as if they had been drafted and revised three times before posting.

"Followers kitne hain?" I asked, looking at the screen.

"Baarat nahi aa rahi. Focus karo," she snapped playfully.

"Okay. Yeh photo ka angle forced hai," I said, pointing to a particularly styled shot.

She stopped. *"Forced matlab?"*

"Yeh tum nahi ho. Yeh tum ho jab tum soch rahi ho ki tumhe kaisa dikhna chahiye."

A second of silence fell between us.

"Tum critic ho ya follower?"

"Dono nahi. Bas dekh raha tha."

She snatched the phone back, stared at the screen for a moment, and then turned it back toward me.

"Okay fine. Toh kaunsi real lagti hai?"

I scrolled down. I stopped at a photo taken inside a car. The sunlight was streaming through the window, washing out half the frame. She wasn't looking at the camera; she was looking out at something else, her expression unguarded and entirely natural.

"Yeh."

She looked at the photo. Her expression shifted into something complicated—as if she had been caught doing something she shouldn't have been.

"Woh accidentally li thi Ananya ne."

"Pata chal raha hai."

She smiled—the kind of smile that slips out before you can lock it down. Then she immediately forced her face back into its serious, unbothered mold.

"Ab tum mujhe sikhaoge Instagram. Tumhara account hai?"

"Nahi."

"Obviously." She took a sip of her tea. *"Toh tum mujhe social media advice de rahe ho bina khud ka account banaye. Classic Sentinel energy."*

"Observe karne ke liye account nahi chahiye."

She started laughing. Properly laughing. The kind of laughter that simply cannot be held back.

She was the one who brought up the philosophy books.

"Tumne Osho kyun padha? Seriously. Woh thoda... cult-y nahi hai?"

"Cult-y log bhi kabhi kabhi sahi baatein bol dete hain," I replied.

"Example."

"Woh kehte hain — tum apni feelings ko suppress karte karte unke ghulam ban jaate ho. Jab tak unhe express nahi karte, woh tum par raj karti hain."

She stopped. She was holding her paper cup, but she wasn't drinking from it.

"Aur tum personally is theory ko follow karte ho?"

I stayed quiet.

"Yahi socha tha." She smiled knowingly. *"Tum Osho ki philosophy quote karte ho aur khud seedha uski opposite life jeete ho."*

"Main observe karta hoon. Woh pehla step hai."

"Second step?"

"Abhi wahan tak nahi pahuncha."

She looked at me for a long second. *"Honest ho, kam se kam."*

And it was the truth.

Another day, the argument shifted to Jiddu Krishnamurti.

"Woh kehta hai ki humein apni conditioning se azaad hona chahiye," she argued. *"Par jab hum sab bachpan se conditioned hain, toh azaadi ka matlab hi kya hai?"*

"Observation. Sirf yeh dekhna ki hum conditioned hain — yahi thodi azaadi hai."

"Yeh too convenient hai. Sirf dekho aur free ho jao?"

"Nahi. Sirf dekho. Free hone ka dawa mat karo."

She opened her mouth to argue, then stopped herself.

"Tumse argue karna itna annoying kyun hai?"

"Kyunki main galat nahi bol raha."

"Isse bhi zyada annoying."

One afternoon, the energy around her was entirely different. Heavier.

Chacha brought the tea. She held the cup but didn't take a sip.

"Ek banda tha," she started abruptly. *"Zayan se pehle. IIT Delhi. Do saal."*

I didn't say anything. I just listened.

"Woh bahut... ideal tha. Papers. Internship. Future planned. Mujhe lagta tha yeh wahi hai jo chahiye. Ghar wale khush. Main khush. Sab boxes ticked."

She paused, staring into the dark liquid in her cup.

"Phir ek din realize hua ki main us relationship mein Naina Sethi ka ek role play kar rahi thi. Woh ladki jo us perfect picture mein fit hoti hai. Real main kahan thi — mujhe pata hi nahi tha."

I kept listening.

"Maine khud tod diya. Usne kuch galat nahi kiya tha. Bas... wrong fit tha. Par main explain nahi kar saki kisi ko. Kyunki logically sab theek tha."

Her tea had probably gone cold, but she drank it anyway.

"Tum kuch bologe?" she asked.

"Nahi."

"Kyun?"

"Kyunki tum theek ho. Tum yeh baat pehle se jaanti ho. Mujhe kuch add karne ki zaroorat nahi hai."

For a fraction of a second, she was something entirely different—the impenetrable wall was gone. There was only her. Unfiltered.

Then, the armor snapped back into place.

"Tumhari taraf se yeh validation ka laziest form hai," she declared.

"Ya sabse honest."

"...Haan. Ya woh."

September 19 | 11:00 PM

My phone vibrated on the desk.

It was the Telegram group: *SSC CGL 2023 Tier-1 Result Declared.*

I opened the PDF and typed in my roll number.

No Match Found.

I put the phone down. Everything that had been building up inside me for the last two months—the calculations, the speculations, the impossibly thin thread of hope—snapped in a single, quiet second.

I checked the cutoff document.

UR: 150.04

A strange, brutal clarity washed over me. Yes, my paper hadn't gone well. But the game had also evolved. The bar had been raised to a terrifying, almost insurmountable height.

I walked up to the terrace. The wind was slightly cool. I expected to feel an unbearable, crushing weight pressing down on my chest. Instead, I felt incredibly light.

It didn't feel like an exam had ended. It felt like a long, exhausting race had concluded. I hadn't won, but I could finally stop running.

My phone rang. *Naina Calling.*

I answered it.

"Result aa gaya?" she asked.

"Haan."

"Aur?"

"Nahi hua."

"Okay."

No suffocating sympathy. No motivational speeches. It was exactly what I needed.

"Kahan ho?"

"Chhat par."

"10 minute mein neeche aao."

A month ago, I would have refused. Tonight, I didn't.

The Shaheed Path highway was completely empty. Naina was driving. The windows were rolled halfway down, letting the rushing wind fill the cabin.

"Cutoff 150 gayi hai," I said, breaking the silence.

"High?"

"Bahut."

She had the music on low.

"Theek ho?" she asked softly.

I honestly checked the internal gauges. Yes. I was.

"Lag raha hai jaise koi race khatam ho gayi. Jeeta nahi. Par daudna band ho gaya."

She let out a faint, understanding laugh and turned the volume up slightly. I leaned my seat back and closed my eyes. Tomorrow, the grinding reality of money and responsibilities would return with full force. But tonight, there was just the wind.

I walked over to Yadav's momo stall the next morning.

"Dekha?" I asked.

"Haan." He was mixing chutney with practiced ease. *"135 ban rahe the mere. 150 toh alag duniya hai."*

We both laughed. A dry, humorless chuckle.

"Ab?" I asked.

"Pata nahi. Thoda rukunga." He stopped mixing and looked at me. *"Ruk le bhai. Par ruk ke sochna. Khade-khade mat sochna."*

It wasn't profound philosophy. It was just straight, hard-earned survival instinct.

That night, Papa called.

"Kab aa raha hai?" he asked.

"Matlab?"

"Diwali aa rahi hai. Ghar reh kuch din."

There was no mention of the 150.04 cutoff. No lecture on wasted years. Just an instruction to come home.

"Haan. Aa jaunga."

"Theek hai."

The line went dead. Going home meant Kusumpur. It meant stepping away from this relentless cycle for a few days. And for the very first time, another thought followed immediately: it meant being away from Naina for a few days.

I carefully picked that thought up and set it aside. I looked out the window. Everything was exactly where it was supposed to be.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | Late September 2023 | Night

Likhna band kar diya tha. Aaj karna pada.

Tapri pe ek cheez notice ki — coffee kam kar di maine. Cigarette bhi nahi peeti uske saath. Usne kabhi poocha nahi kyun.

Zyaatar log poochte hain. Woh nahi karta.

Instagram wale din socha tha — kuch interesting bolega. Usne kaha — "Yeh tum nahi ho."

Jo photo usne pick ki — accidentally li gayi thi. Main camera ki taraf dekh bhi nahi rahi thi. Wahi pick ki.

Pata nahi kya karun is baat ka.

IIT Delhi wale ex ke baare mein bataya usse. Plan nahi tha — bas ho gaya. Paper pe perfect tha sab kuch. Par main us poori relationship mein ek role play karti rahi — jo fit karti thi us picture mein. Real main kahan thi — kabhi socha hi nahi tha.

Usne kuch nahi bola. Sirf — "Tum theek ho. Tum pehle se jaanti ho."

Koi advice nahi. Koi analysis nahi.

Maine kaha — "Yeh validation ka laziest form hai."

Woh muskuraya. Kyunki hum dono jaante the — sach tha.

Result nahi hua uska. Car mein chup tha.

"Jaise koi race khatam ho gayi. Jeeta nahi. Par daudna band ho gaya."

Itni honest line. Itni uski.

Papa ne Diwali ke liye bulaya hai. Jayega.

Aur main soch rahi hoon ki tapri par nahi hoga kuch din.

Yeh nahi sochna chahiye tha.

CAT 60 din mein hai.

Par soch rahi hoon.

— N.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 13

The Envelope of Trust

November – December 2023 — Kusumpur / Lucknow

A. The Departure

Morning | The Bus Stand (Kusumpur)

It was time to go back to Lucknow.

Maa had woken me up early. *"Nashta kar le pehle."* I was in a hurry. She never was.

As I was picking up my bag, Maa slipped something into the front pocket of my kurta without looking at me.

"Rakh le."

I sat by the window in the bus and pulled it out. A 500-rupee note.

Maa made *papads* with the village self-help group. She didn't have much of her own. Yet, she had managed to save this.

That 500-rupee note wasn't money. It was the physical weight of her belief in me.

B. The Silent Handshake

Just before the bus started moving, Papa arrived.

He didn't say a word. He just shook my hand through the window and slipped a wad of notes into my palm. Five thousand rupees.

"Maa se mat kehna," he said gruffly.

"Mujhe nahi chahiye—"

He looked straight at me. A sharp, unyielding look.

"Paise ki tension mat lena. Dil laga ke padhna."

He was a man of very few words. But when he spoke, he struck the nail straight on the head.

I sat there with five thousand rupees in my hand. Sometimes, love arrives disguised as a crushing sense of responsibility.

C. The Fields

On the Bus

I stared out the window. The green fields of Ayodhya were blurring past.

My phone vibrated. A message from Naina.

"Kal ka din yaad hai na? 26 November. Don't forget."

CAT 2023. The exam she had been building her entire year around.

I replied: *"Yaad hai."*

"Nervous hoon. Excited bhi."

"Dono theek hain."

"Tum hamesha itne calm kyun rehte ho?"

"Tum hamesha itne sawaal kyun karti ho?"

"Chup raho."

I smiled faintly. The fields were ending. The concrete edges of the city were about to begin.

D. The Monologue

Evening | Bhaiya's Flat

I went straight to the flat.

Pihu was on the carpet, propped up with two pillows behind her back and neck. A soft toy of Ram Lala was placed in front of her—deliberately kept just slightly out of her immediate reach.

I sat down on the floor beside her.

Pihu's tiny hand reached out toward the toy. Her fingers brushed the fabric, but slipped.

"Dadi ne bheja hai. Ayodhya se," I told her.

She didn't respond. She just kept trying to reach it.

"Main bhi gaya tha. Saryu dekhi. Dadi ne jeb mein 500 daale. Unhe lagta hai main abhi bhi 10 saal ka hoon."

Her hand stretched further. This time, her fingers closed around the edge of the cloth.

"Ek baat bataun?" I whispered. *"Aaj pehli baar main apne kisi paper se zyada kisi aur ke paper ke liye nervous hoon."*

A breeze blew in from the window, rustling the curtain. It was a completely one-sided conversation. But maybe not every relationship requires both sides to speak in order to be understood.

E. The Night Before

November 25 | 11:15 PM

Naina sent a picture of her admit card.

"Kal morning slot hai. Wish me luck."

"Best of luck."

"Bas itna?"

"Kya chahiye?"

"Kuch poetic."

I stared at the blinking cursor. Then I typed:

"Tum pehle se jaanti ho jo jaanna tha. Kal bas woh dikha dena."

"...Okay yeh actually sahi tha."

"Ab so jao Sentinel. Mujhe nahi, tumhe zaroorat hai."

I put the phone down. It was 11:15 PM.

Her paper was tomorrow morning. And she was right. I was genuinely, irrationally nervous.

F. The Tea

November 26 | Morning

I hadn't set an alarm, yet I woke up at exactly 7:45 AM.

I made tea. I sat in my room, staring at the wall, tracking the minutes as her exam slot progressed.

At 12:30 PM, the message arrived.

"VARC acha. DILR stuck. QA theek."

"Overall?" I asked.

"Feel acchi hai."

"Result January mein hai. Abhi chai pee lo." I replied.

"Haha. Tum nervous the na?"

"Chai pee lo."

G. The Middle Ground

Night | The Flat

My books were spread out on the table.

Right in the center lay Maa's 500-rupee note and Papa's 5000-rupee wad. Both neatly folded.

Maa's note was physically lighter, but it carried the heaviest emotional weight. Papa's money was substantial, but the silent trust wrapped inside it was even heavier.

Back in the village, Sharma ji's son had gotten selected.

Here in the city, Yadav was running a momo stall with his girlfriend.

Naina had just finished the paper that would define her life.

Papa was working in silence. Maa was rolling papads.

And me?

I was suspended somewhere right in the middle of all of them. And for the very first time, it occurred to me—maybe being in the middle is a place of its own.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | 26 November 2023 | Night

Paper ho gaya.

VARC smooth. DILR mein ek set kharab gaya — 15 minute waste. QA theek tha.

97-98 percentile hoga shayad. IIM A mushkil. B aur C possible.

Yeh sab January mein pata chalega.

Subah center par thi. Exam se pehle 20 minute bahar khadi rahi.

Raat ko usne kaha tha — "Tum pehle se jaanti ho jo jaanna tha. Kal bas woh dikha dena."

Yeh line subah yaad rahi. Poore paper mein.

Paper ke baad maine use message kiya.

Usne poocha — "Overall?"

Maine bataya.

Usne kaha — "Chai pee lo."

Main hansi. Kyunki — yahi toh hai woh.

Koi bada, dramatic reaction nahi. Koi 'itna toh ho hi jaata hai' wali toxic positivity nahi. Bas — chai pee lo.

Itni simple cheez itni sahi kyun lagti hai?

Usne kabhi nahi bola ki woh nervous tha.

Par main jaanti hoon.

7:45 baje uth gaya hoga. Chai banayi hogi. Kamre mein baitha raha hoga.

Usne nahi bataya. Maine nahi poocha.

Dono jaante hain. Bas itna kaafi hai.

January mein result aayega.

Agar convert hua — toh sab badlega.

Woh bhi jaanta hai.

Abhi ke liye — chai. Routine. Resting silence.

Jo bhi hai.

— N.

CHAPTER 14

The Price of Habit

December 2023 — Lucknow

A. The Quiet Exit

December 4 | The Library

The final result for SSC CGL 2023 was declared.

The Mains were done. The typing test was done. This was the final list. The end of the line.

Sivi was sitting at her desk in the library. The PDF was open on her laptop screen. She pressed Ctrl+F and typed her roll number.

No Match Found.

She closed the laptop. Very slowly. Very deliberately.

There was no sudden outburst of anger. No tears. Just that profound, echoing silence that settles in when you realize, after walking for miles, that you took the wrong road.

I sat next to her, completely silent.

We stayed like that for a long time. The only sound in the basement was the rustling of other people turning the pages of their books.

Finally, she picked up her bag.

"Ghar jaaungi kuch din," she said.

"Haan."

She stopped at the gate. She didn't turn around.

"Agli baar karungi." She was probably saying it to herself, not to me.

Then she walked out.

I went back to Seat 17.

Seat 18 was empty now. Seat 12 had been empty for months.

The library doesn't stop people from dreaming. It just temporarily empties them out.

When I went back to my room that night, Maa's 500 and Papa's 5000 were still folded inside my book. I hadn't touched them. Some burdens aren't carried in your pocket; they are carried in your chest.

B. The Logic of Numbers

Naina asked me about my mock test over the phone a few days later.

"Aaj ka mock?"

"147."

"Attempts?"

"82."

"Badhao," she instructed smoothly. *"Agar paper easy aaya toh cutoff 150 cross karegi. 90 touch karo kam se kam."*

"Reasoning mein kahan kate?"

"Blood relation. Number series."

"Teen mocks se yahi hai. Skip karo pehle. End mein wapas aao."

I noted it down. There was no pep talk. No *"Tum kar sakte ho."* Just raw numbers and pattern analysis. It was incredibly helpful. And because it was so clinical, it was also slightly uncomfortable.

C. The Chasm

Phoenix Palassio Mall

It was her idea.

"Aaj boring hai. Chal Phoenix."

Phoenix Palassio. The part of Lucknow that doesn't feel like Lucknow at all. The moment we walked through the massive glass doors, it was immediately clear—this was her world.

Naina walked through the glittering corridors with absolute, natural ease. She walked into a high-end store, browsed through a rack of jackets, pulled one out, and handed it to me.

"Try karo."

I took it from her. The very first thing my eyes caught was the small cardboard tag dangling from the sleeve.

₹5,990.

Four months of my library fees.

I handed it right back to her. *"Nahi chahiye."*

"Try karne se khareedna compulsory thodi hai," she argued lightly.

"Mujhe aadat nahi dalni us cheez ki jo main afford nahi kar sakta."

She looked at me for a long second. She didn't force it. She just put the jacket back on the rack.

But that tiny moment—when she extended the jacket, and I pulled my hand back after seeing the price—the chasm between us was illuminated under the bright store lights. To anyone watching from the outside, we probably looked like a normal couple shopping. But inside, we were standing on two entirely different planets.

D. The Food Court

We sat at a table in the sprawling food court.

"Kya loge?" she asked.

"Chai hai?"

She laughed. *"Mall mein chai. Chaayos chalte hain."*

We ordered. She was talking about the jacket, the fabric, the winter collection. I was just listening. Or pretending to.

Then she stopped. *"Tum aaj quiet ho."*

"Hamesha quiet hoon."

"Alag wali quiet hai aaj."

I gripped my paper tea cup. *"Kuch nahi."*

She looked at me intently for a second. Then, she let it go. That was the thing about her—she never pushed. She never demanded access to the places I kept locked. And somehow, her letting it go made it even harder to breathe.

E. The Gravity

The Drop-off

It was night.

In the car, she was humming a song under her breath, just for herself. I was staring out the window at the city lights reflecting off the Gomti.

"Utro?" she asked playfully as the car stopped outside my building.

"Haan."

I unbuckled my seatbelt.

"Aaj acha laga?" she asked.

"Haan."

"Jhooth."

I stopped with my hand on the door handle.

"Kuch tha. Main jaanti hoon. Par theek hai," she said softly.

I pushed the door open. *"Good night Naina."*

"Good night Sentinel."

The car drove away.

I stood there, trying to untangle what exactly was knotting up inside me. It wasn't just about refusing to try on an expensive jacket. The fear wasn't that I couldn't afford it. The terrifying truth was that I had *liked* the jacket.

I wanted to remain Eklavya. I wanted to stay on my own difficult, unglamorous path.

But her gravity was increasing. Slowly. Without making a sound, she was pulling me into her orbit. She wasn't doing it deliberately. She was just being herself. And that was the most terrifying part of all.

F. The Incomplete Chapter

Night | The Terrace

I stood on the terrace. The December chill had begun to set in.

Naina would get her CAT results in January. If she converted an IIM, she would leave. Campus. Hostels. A new city. A new stratosphere.

Earlier, my fear had been that she would leave.

Now, my fear was that before she left, I was slowly becoming something I never intended to be.

I was becoming a temporary station on her journey. And she was becoming an unfinished, lingering chapter in mine.

We couldn't possibly exist together in the long run.

Or could we?

I didn't know.

I stood in the cold for a very long time.

INTERLUDE *Naina's Diary | December 2023 | Night*

We went to Phoenix today.

He looked at the price tag on the jacket. First thing. I noticed it. He put it right back. I didn't force him to try it on.

I didn't feel bad. I just understood—this is his reality. This is where he comes from. I probably shouldn't have forgotten that. But I just wanted him to look past the price. Just for once. Just once.

I've been tracking his mock scores. 147. Attempts 82. He is cautious. He is absolutely terrified of being wrong.

"Attempt badhao," I told him. He noted it down. Didn't say a word. He listens. He processes it. And then he implements it later. I like that about him. But sometimes, I just wish he would say it out loud just once—*"Helpful tha."* He won't say it. I know that too.

Sivi didn't make it. He told me—*"Sivi out."* Just that. But I know exactly how he must feel looking at that empty seat every morning.

The CAT results will be out in January. If I convert an IIM, I'll have to shift. He knows that.

And I also know that he takes this thought, folds it neatly, and tucks it away in the exact same place where he keeps everything else hidden. I want to pry that place open.

But he hasn't given me permission. And I am not going to ask.

For now, I am just here. Within his line of sight. That is enough. For now.

— N.

[Past jaari hai..

CHAPTER 14

Ninety-Nine

January 2024 — Lucknow

A. 2:17 PM

The phone vibrated on the desk.

"99.xx percentile. Score card download ho raha hai."

Three seconds later, she called.

"Library ke bahar niklo. Main aa rahi hoon."

B. The Library Gate

She was there in fifteen minutes.

She didn't get out of the car immediately. She just looked at me through the window. Her eyes were the same, but there was something entirely new in them—the specific, radiant weight that settles in when something you have fought for actually becomes real.

Then she stepped out.

She stood exactly three steps away from me. She was incredibly excited, yet desperately trying to stay in control. Both at exactly the same time.

I understood it later—she had wanted to hug me. She had physically stopped herself.

"Ho gaya Sentinel," she breathed out.

"Haan."

"99."

"Haan."

She let out a short, breathless laugh. Then her phone started ringing. Ananya. Then someone else.

I just stood there and watched her. Her voice carried a color that was reserved entirely for this moment, a sound that people only let out when they are talking to their own.

C. Kapoorthala Chowk

There was a sweet shop nearby.

She walked inside, bought a box of Kaju Katli, and came back out. She walked straight up to me and placed a piece directly into my hand.

"Khao."

"Kyun?" I asked.

"Kyunki main khilana chahti hoon."

I ate it.

She was watching me. Not casually, but with that specific gaze she had—the one that recorded details. She was probably going to write about it later.

"Mummy bahut khush thi," she said, her voice softer now. "Papa ne message kiya — 'Proud hoon.' Pehli baar likha unhone."

She stopped.

"Pata nahi mujhe — unka message padh ke farq padta hai ya nahi. Par Mummy ki awaaz sunke samajh aaya ki kya hota hai."

I didn't say anything. The empty space between us felt completely appropriate.

And then, out of nowhere:

"Long distance chal sakta hai? Agar IIM bahar ka aaya?"

The question dropped like a stone. It was entirely sudden.

I didn't say a single word for an entire minute. The city moved around us. Cars passed. The sun beat down on the pavement.

"Ok," I said finally.

She looked at me, searching my face.

"Bas itna?"

"Haan."

She opened her mouth to say something else, then decided against it.

"Chalo. Library drop karti hoon," she said, her tone shifting back to command.

"Shaam ko ready rehna."

It was a statement. Not an invitation.

D. The Sky Bar | Night

Renaissance. The same place.

Ananya was there. Kabeer was there. A few other people from her circle.

There was wine. There was food. There was loud music.

She drifted toward the dance floor. I walked straight to the railing.

The Gomti flowed below. The same view. The same dark water.

Naina came over once. *"Andar aao."*

"Theek hoon," I replied.

She didn't ask again. She just stood right beside me. For a while, she looked down at the river, then out at the city lights, and then she turned her head and looked at me. There was a profound, quiet joy radiating from her face—the kind of look that only appears when a person feels, for one fleeting moment, that they have absolutely everything they could ever want.

I caught Ananya looking at me once from across the floor. She offered a small, knowing smile. She had probably figured something out.

E. 11:00 PM | The Car

She was driving. I was in the passenger seat.

Lucknow at night. The biting chill of December.

A short distance away from her house, she pulled the car over to the side of the empty road. She didn't turn the engine off.

"Kaisi thi party?" she asked, looking straight ahead.

"Sahi thi."

She turned toward me.

"Sach bolo. Aankhon mein dekh ke."

I looked at her.

"Tumhe nahi laga sahi," she answered her own question. "Main jaanti thi."

"Phir bhi leke gayi," I pointed out.

"Kyunki main chahti thi tum wahan ho."

There was no wind outside. The world had gone entirely still for a second.

She leaned slightly toward me. It wasn't a physical step—it was that microscopic, undeniable shift that occurs when someone finally makes a decision.

Her breath mingled with mine.

I was there. Completely. Not a single fraction of me was standing outside the car or observing from a distance.

And for the very first time, I understood what it actually meant to be *with* someone.

It was just a moment. But a single moment can hold an entire world inside it.

F. The Aftermath

She dropped me home.

The lights were on inside my flat.

She drove away. I stood there on the street for a long time.

Something had shifted inside me—not the part that was afraid, but the part that had finally opened up for the first time. And that was exactly why it was so terrifying.

For the next ten days, I avoided her messages.

She sent them. I read them. I didn't reply.

Once, she wrote: "*Theek ho?*"

Three days later, I typed: "*Haan.*"

She knew something had happened. I let her know. But I didn't explain it.

Because to explain something to someone else, you first have to understand it yourself.

And I wasn't there yet.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | January 2024 | Night

99. *Ho gaya.*

Mummy ki awaaz sunke roya. Woh nahi suni — bas unka happy hona kaafi tha.

Papa ka message — "Proud hoon." Do words. Par unke muh se do words bahut hote hain.

Eklavya ko bataya. Library ke bahar.

Usne kuch khaas nahi kaha. "Haan. Haan." Par woh wahan tha. Poora.

Hug karna chahti thi. Nahi kiya. Theek tha yeh bhi.

Long distance waala sawaal kyun poocha — pata nahi. Achanak aaya.

Woh ek minute chup raha.

Sheher chal raha tha. Woh nahi.

Phir usne kaha, "Ok."

Ek minute ki woh chuppi — usne kuch socha. Mujhe nahi pata kya. Par socha.

Car mein raat ko usne meri aankhon mein dekha.

Main yeh nahi likhungi kya hua.

Kuch cheezein likhne se chhoti ho jaati hain.

Bas itna — pehli baar laga ki woh wahan tha. Poora. Koi hissa bahar nahi tha.

Aur pehli baar dar laga mujhe bhi.

10 din se reply nahi kar raha.

Main jaanti hoon kyun.

Mujhe bhi dar lag raha hai. Par main avoid nahi kar rahi.

Kyunki jo hua — woh real tha.

Aur real cheezein se bhaagna — jo Rohan ne sikhaya tha — kisi kaam ka nahi hota.

— N.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 15

The Weight of Real

January 2024 — Lucknow

A. Ten Days

She messaged.

I saw it.

I didn't reply.

It was the very first time I had deliberately ignored her message. I had never felt the need to before.

But after that night—in the car, that specific moment—something fundamental had shifted inside me. I couldn't understand it. I couldn't process it. So, I stayed quiet.

I went to the library. I studied. At night, I went up to the terrace. I thought about it. Nothing resolved itself.

"Theek ho?" she asked.

Three days later, I finally typed: *"Haan."*

She went quiet too.

B. The First Time

January | The Tapri

She was already at the tapri when I arrived.

I looked at her. She was looking straight at me. She didn't even wait for me to sit down.

"Avoid kar rahe the mujhe."

"Nahi—"

"Eklavya."

I stopped. **"Haan."**

Chacha brought the tea and placed the two glasses on the bench between us.

"Kyun?" she asked.

One second. Two seconds.

"Process kar raha tha."

"Kya?"

"Jo hua. Car mein."

She kept looking at me. A direct, unblinking gaze.

"Woh real tha. Main thi. Tum the. Jo tha — real tha. Isme tumhe guilt nahi hona chahiye."

I didn't say anything.

"Tum apni har cheez itni zyada andar rakhte ho ki kabhi kabhi main sochti hoon — yeh insaan saans kaise leta hai," she said softly.

A faint smile touched my lips. I didn't even know why.

"Woh bhi real tha — yeh," she pointed out, gesturing to my smile.

I drank my tea. Something tight inside my chest finally began to settle.

C. The Teacher

"Mock score kya hai?" she asked suddenly.

"151."

"English mein?"

"32."

She frowned. **"Itna hi? Yeh weak hai tumhari."**

"Haan."

"Kya padhte ho English mein?"

"Newspapers. Kabhi kabhi."

"'Kabhi kabhi' se kaam nahi chalega," she declared, slipping instantly into her analytical mode. "Roz ek editorial. Hindu ya Indian Express. Argument structure dekho — point kya hai, support kaise kiya, conclusion kahan gaya. Yeh SSC English ke liye direct kaam aayega."

I noted it down.

"Aur vocabulary — context se seekho. Ek word akela nahi aata. Woh ek poor sentence carry karta hai."

I stayed quiet, just listening.

"Kal se shuru karte hain. Ek editorial roz. Tum padhoge, mujhe summary doge."

"Tum teacher ban rahi ho?" I asked mildly.

"Tum student ban rahe ho. Fark hai," she shot back.

D. The Return

The Library

One morning, there was a bag on Seat 18.

Sivi.

She was back.

Our eyes met. I gave her a small nod. Before sitting down, she looked at me and said very quietly:

"Agli baar karungi. Pakka."

"Haan."

She sat down. Opened her notes. Her pen started moving across the paper.

Nothing had changed in the basement. And yet, absolutely everything had changed.

E. Breathing

Night | The Flat

I was walking past the living room.

Pihu was in Bhabhi's lap. Bhabhi was singing something to her—a soft, low lullaby. Pihu's eyes were closed.

I stopped at the doorway.

This was a scene that happened every single day. But I had never truly watched it, because I usually locked myself in my room by this time. Today, I stopped.

Bhabhi looked up and saw me. She didn't say anything. I stood there for a long time.

A few days ago, Naina had asked me—*"Tum saans kaise lete ho."*

Looking at Pihu sleeping peacefully in her mother's arms, I finally understood the answer. I do breathe. I just do it in entirely different places.

F. The Routine

I read the editorial. The Hindu. It was about a new economic policy.

I drafted a summary and sent it to Naina.

Three minutes later, my phone vibrated.

"Argument theek pakda. Par conclusion miss kiya. Author kehta hai policy fail hogi — tumne sirf describe kiya ki kya hai."

"Dobara padhta hoon."

"Haan."

It became a routine.

Every day, one editorial. Every day, one summary. Every day, one correction.

No drama. No motivational speeches. Just—every day.

And inside this "every day," something was quietly taking root that hadn't been there before. It was comfort.

The very thing I was terrified of was slowly starting to feel like home. And that—that was the most terrifying part of all.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | January 2024 | Night

Tapri par maine usse seedha poocha — avoid kar rahe the?

Usne haan kaha.

Pehli baar itna seedha aur honest tha woh.

Maine kaha — jo tha real tha. Guilt mat lo.

Woh chup raha. Par kuch thoda sa khula usmein. Aankhon mein nahi — par kahin toh tha.

English kaafi weak hai uski.

Roz editorial. Roz summary.

Aaj teesri baar tha. Conclusion usne phir miss kiya.

Par improvement ho rahi hai. Slowly.

Woh sunta hai. Process karta hai. Aur phir uspar kaam karta hai.

Yeh cheez bahut kam logon mein hoti hai.

Sivi wapas aayi library mein.

Usne mujhe casually bataya — jaise log weather ke baare mein batate hain.

Par main jaanti hoon us seat ka matlab kya hai uske liye.

Ek cheez jo main pichle kuch dino se notice kar rahi hoon —

Woh ab kabhi kabhi khud message karta hai. Pehle nahi karta tha.

Chhoti si cheez hai.

Par hai.

— N.

[Past jaari hai...]

CHAPTER 16

The River's Promise

March 2024 — Lucknow

A. The Evening

It was her idea.

"Chal bahar. Gomti par."

Her interview for IIM Bangalore was scheduled for March 9th. It was exactly six days away.

We sat on the concrete steps of the riverfront. The sun was beginning to set, casting long, fractured streaks of burnt orange across the surface of the water.

The river kept flowing—exactly the way it always did, indifferent to whoever sat on its banks.

B. The Confession

She remained quiet for a long time. Then, she spoke.

"Tumse milne se pehle — main akele nahi reh sakti thi. Matlab physically akele. Hamesha koi chahiye tha. Ananya. Kabeer. Koi bhi."

She stared out at the dark water.

"Drinking thi. Smoking thi. Overconfident thi — ya kam se kam dikhti thi. Aur ek cheez... bahut door jaana tha. Kisi badi company ki CEO banna tha. Kahan? Pata nahi. Bas door."

"Door matlab?" I asked softly.

"Yahan se. Sab se."

She paused, letting the evening breeze fill the silence.

"Par tumhare saath — ek bench par baith ke bhi — itna sukoon kyun milta hai? Yeh samajh nahi aata mujhe."

The river kept moving.

"Tum kya chahte ho Sentinel? Sach mein?"

For a fraction of a second, I retreated into myself. Then, I was there. Entirely present.

"Koi pahad ho," I said quietly. *"Jahan koi na ho. Sirf main hoon. Aur wahan — khud se milun. Koi naam nahi. Koi result nahi. Koi prove karna nahi. Bas — woh jo main hoon, usse milun."*

She stayed quiet.

"Kabhi kabhi sab chhod dene ka mann karta hai," I confessed, the words slipping out easier than I expected. *"Isme aur usme nahi — bas in sab se. Aur khud mein ghus jaun."*

The sun dipped lower beneath the horizon.

The water turned a shade deeper, swallowing the orange reflections.

That was when she held my hand.

It wasn't sudden or forceful. She slid her hand into mine very gently, almost as if she were quietly asking—*is this okay?*

"Sentinel."

"Haan."

"Main tumhe ab kabhi nahi chhodungi."

I didn't say a single word.

The river flowed in front of us.

Her hand remained wrapped in mine.

Deep inside, something twisted. There was a part of me that was utterly terrified of what this meant. And there was another part that wanted it more than anything else in the world.

They both existed at exactly the same time.

C. The Return

It was dark by the time we walked back.

We stood outside her house, near her car.

"Bangalore ki taiyaari?" I asked.

"Kal se."

"Theek hai."

She walked through the gates.

I stood there on the empty street. My hand was still carrying the lingering warmth of her fingers.

This was a bond. It was real, and it was tying me down. And for the very first time in my life, I didn't want to run away from it.

The fear was still there. It hadn't left. But it had taken on a slightly different shape now.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | March 2024 | Night

Aaj Gomti par baithe the.

Usne bataya — pahad. Akele. Khud se milna.

Pehli baar laga — yeh insaan itna akela kyun rehna chahta hai.

Phir samjhi — akela nahi. Khud ke saath.

Dono baatein alag hain.

Maine uska haath pakda.

Koi plan nahi tha. Bas ho gaya.

"Main tumhe ab kabhi nahi chhodungi."

Woh chup raha.

Par usne haath nahi hataya.

Mock interview mein woh sawaal aaya tha — "Apne Papa ki tarah ho."

Main ruk gayi thi.

Par answer mera tha. Pehli baar.

Usne mujhe ek book di thi — Alice Miller.

Usne mujhe koi lecture nahi diya. Usne nahi kaha — "maaf kar do."

Usne sirf ek darwaza dikhaya. Us darwaze ke andar jaana mera kaam tha.

Bangalore ka interview 9 ko hai.

Par sach yeh hai — ab sirf ek answer chahiye mujhe.

Lucknow.

Woh reason jo pehle explain karna mushkil tha — ab nahi hai.

— N.

CHAPTER 17

The Unfolding

April – September 2024 — Lucknow

A. The Result | April 2024

The message arrived in the afternoon.

"IIM Lucknow. Confirm."

I was in the library. Seat 17. Sivi was at Seat 18.

She glanced at my screen, looked at my face, and instantly understood that something had happened.

"Theek hai?" she asked.

"Haan. Naina ka IIM result aaya."

She nodded and went straight back to her notes. She didn't ask anything else. That was the right thing to do.

I met Naina at the tapri in the evening.

She was radiating happiness—not the loud, performative kind, but a deep, quiet joy that simply glowed from the inside out.

"Lucknow hai. Yahin hoon," she said directly, looking into my eyes.

I took a sip of my tea.

"Campus mein shift ho jao," I said evenly.

She stopped. Her smile faltered slightly.

"Matlab?"

"Hostel life MBA ka hissa hai. Jo wahan hoga — dinners, group work, raat ko discussions — woh bahar se nahi milega."

"Main yahin se bhi—"

"Naina."

She went completely silent.

"Poora experience lo. Andar rehkar," I told her.

She kept looking at me. Her gaze was heavy, searching for the underlying motive.

"Tum mujhe door kar rahe ho," she said, her voice dropping.

I placed my tea cup on the bench.

"Main tumhe tumhara experience dene ki koshish kar raha hoon."

She stayed quiet for a long second, processing the boundaries I was drawing.

"Theek hai," she said softly. "Par yeh tumhari choice hai. Meri nahi."

B. The Departure | June

Her orientation was on June 3rd.

She came to see me the day before she shifted. She sat down on the floor next to Pihu. Pihu had recently started holding hands for slightly longer intervals.

Naina extended her hand. Pihu's tiny fingers wrapped around Naina's index finger—just for one second.

Naina looked up at me.

Neither of us said a word.

Later, as she was leaving, we stood at the gate of my building.

"Messages karta rehna," she instructed.

"Haan."

"Sentinel."

"Haan."

"Main yahan hoon. Sirf 20 minute door."

"Pata hai."

Her car drove away.

I stood there by the gate. I knew pushing her to the campus was the right thing to do. I was absolutely certain of it.

Yet, there was a heavy knot in my chest—the kind of feeling that carries the agonizing weight of holding two entirely conflicting truths at exactly the same time.

C. The Grind | July – August

The Library.

8:00 AM every morning. Seat 17. Sivi at Seat 18.

This was a routine that couldn't be explained to an outsider. It simply existed.

Naina's messages arrived at different times now—mostly late at night. She was living the campus life. Case studies. Group dinners. Late-night discussions.

"Aaj ka mock?" she texted.

"153."

"Attempt?"

"89."

"Blood relation?"

"Skip kiya. 3 minute bachaye."

"Theek hai."

One day, during our tea break, Sivi turned to me.

"Ek cheez notice ki hai. Tum September se pehle wale tum nahi hote. Concentrate zyada ho."

"Achha hai na?"

"Haan. Par kahin kuch aur bhi hai."

I didn't respond. She stayed quiet too. We both knew the conversation had reached its natural end right there.

D. Pihu | Late August

It was the last week of August.

Vikram bhaiya came out of the room with a rare smile on his face. *"Aaj usne khud ball uthaayi. Bhabhi ke haath se."*

I walked into the room.

Pihu was sleeping. The Ram Lala soft toy was tucked near her chest, held in a loose, delicate grip.

I sat down on the floor beside her and just watched her breathe.

"Pihu," I whispered softly.

She was deep in her sleep.

"September mein paper hai. Phir result. Phir pata nahi."

The ceiling fan hummed a steady rhythm above us.

"Par tum ho. Aur yeh kaafi hai aaj ke liye."

I sat there in the quiet room for a long time.

E. The Night Before | September 8

At 9:00 PM, my phone rang. Papa.

"Haan Papa."

"Kal hai?"

"Haan. 26 ko. Doosri shift."

He didn't say anything for a second. The silence on the line was thick.

"Theek se jaana. Jaldi nikalna."

"Haan."

"Khaana kha ke sona."

"Ji."

He cut the call.

Three lines. That was all.

But inside those three simple lines, I could hear the grinding weight of three entire years. Everything he had never said out loud, everything I knew he felt, was neatly folded into those instructions.

At 10:00 PM, Naina called.

"Kal paper hai."

"Haan."

"Nervous ho?"

"Thoda."

She let out a soft, echoing laugh.

"Tum pehle se jaante ho jo jaanna tha. Kal bas woh dikha dena."

The exact same words. The ones I had texted her the night before her CAT exam.

"Yeh meri line hai," I pointed out.

"Tumhari line tumhare paas wapas." She paused. *"Good night Sentinel."*

"Good night."

Sleep didn't come easily that night.

Three years. Seat 17. The 0.75 margin. A paper that had slipped out of my hands.

Papa's three lines. Naina's echoed words.

Everything was assembled right there in the dark room with me.

Tomorrow was the day of unfolding.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | September 8, 2024 | Night

Tomorrow is his exam.

He said — *"thoda nervous hoon."*

For the first time, he admitted it that quickly.

I moved to campus in June.

He had said — *"poora experience lo."*

I knew why he was saying that.

He wasn't pushing me away — he was giving me space to have my own life.

It made me angry too.

But it was true.

Here there are case studies.

Group dinners.

Late nights.

But at night — he is only twenty minutes away.

Sometimes it feels like he is right here, next to me.

Sometimes it feels like he isn't here at all.

Both feelings feel completely real.

Tomorrow's paper is three years of his work.

He missed it once by 0.75 marks.

Tomorrow he shouldn't miss it.

"Tum pehle se jaante ho jo jaanna tha."

He really does know it.

Tomorrow he just has to show it.

— N.

Past continues...

CHAPTER 18

The Glitch

September 26, 2024 — Kanpur

A. The Night Before

The room light was off.

I lay on the bed. Eyes closed. Face turned toward the wall.

Sleep should have come. Tomorrow mattered.

But the mind was loud.

Five minutes. Fifteen minutes.

I got up.

Picked up the phone. Put Osho on speaker — Ashtavakra Gita.

"Tum wahi ho jo dekh raha hai. Karta tum nahi ho."

The philosophy was fine.

But if the system hung tomorrow — who would be the doer?

At 2 a.m. I went to the terrace.

There was a slight chill in the September night. The city lights were far away.

Naina's hostel was twenty minutes from there.

The lights there would be off. She would be sleeping.

And me?

I was still the same thing.

An aspirant.

The word sounded different now.

Aspirant — someone who hasn't become anything yet. Someone who is still trying.

I went back inside.

Played Parmar Sir's audio. Polity.

Somewhere around 3 a.m., while listening, sleep came.

B. The Morning | 4:30

Bhaiya knocked on the door.

"Chal. Nikalna hai."

My eyes opened. Heavy.

I drank water. Washed my face. Looked in the mirror.

My eyes were red. Slightly swollen.

Got ready.

Kurta. Jeans. Bag.

Before leaving, I glanced into Pihu's room.

She was sleeping beside Bhabhi.

In sleep her hand moved suddenly — for no reason.

In my mind I said:

"Tere liye."

At 5 a.m. the Swift left.

Bhaiya in the driver's seat.

The radio hummed faintly.

He didn't ask the obvious question —

"Taiyaari kaisi hai?"

He knew the question was useless.

He just drove.

Morning light began spreading over the highway.

Fields appeared. Farmers appeared. Ploughing.

They know what they're doing.

Seeds go in. Crops come out.

My process?

Give the paper.

Face glitches.

Wait for the result.

The farmer was clearer than me.

My phone buzzed.

Naina.

"Chai mili?"

"Raaste mein hoon."

"All the best. Ladna mat system se. Bas paper dena."

She knew.

She always knew.

C. The Centre | 10:30

There was a crowd outside.

Same faces. Same fear.

People flipping through notes.

My seat was in the corner.

I turned on the computer.

Moved the mouse.

The cursor lagged.

Click. Response late.

Click again. Still late.

I called the invigilator.

"Sir. Mouse glitch kar raha hai."

He checked.

"Chal toh raha hai."

"Sir smooth nahi hai."

He took out a strip of tape.

Stuck it under the mouse.

A fix.

"Ab theek hai. Change nahi hoga."

I remembered Bhaiya.

I remembered Pihu.

I swallowed the anger.

11:45. Paper started.

Timer: 60:00

Q1. GK. Easy.

Q5. Reasoning.

The screen froze.

Cursor disappeared.

Ten seconds.

Twenty seconds.

Thirty seconds.

The screen returned.

My focus had slipped.

Q15.

Freeze again.

This time forty seconds.

Naina had said —

"Ladna mat system se."

But the system was fighting me.

I took a deep breath.

To hell with the mouse.

I'll do what I know.

Last five minutes — fast.

Timer zero.

"Your exam has been submitted."

D. The Return | 12:45

I stepped outside.

Sunlight hit my eyes sharply.

Bhaiya stood near the car, talking on the phone.

He saw me.

Cut the call.

Held out a water bottle.

"Kaisa gaya?"

I drank.

The lump in my throat went down.

Should I tell him?

That the mouse was bad?

That the system froze three times?

No.

He had driven a hundred kilometers.

He didn't need complaints.

He needed hope.

"Theek tha. Pre clear ho jayega."

Not a lie.

But not the full truth either.

I took out my phone.

"Done?"

"Haan. Glitch tha. Mouse issue. Par attempt theek hain."

"Ghar pahunch ke call karna. Ab sochna band."

The car started.

I leaned back in the seat.

Bhaiya turned on the radio.

Kanpur was fading behind.

Lucknow was ahead.

And I —

was still in between.

Still.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | September 26, 2024 | Night

Aaj uska paper tha.

Subah message kiya — "Chai mili?"

Stupid sawaal tha.

Par bheja.

Raaste mein tha woh.

Dopahar ko message aaya — glitch tha. Mouse kharab tha.

Pehla khayal — gussa.

System pe.

Phir socha — usne paper diya.

Poori.

Glitch ke saath.

Yahi toh hai woh.

Raat ko call aaya.

"Kaisa laga?"

"Theek tha."

"Sach mein?"

Ek second chup raha.

"Attempt 88 the. Accuracy theek thi. Glitch ne 2-3 minute waste kiye. Par ho gaya."

"Result kab?"

"Pata nahi. Kuch hafte."

Kuch der dono chup rahe.

"So jao." Maine kaha.

"Haan."

"Sentinel."

"Haan."

"Tum pehle se jaante ho."

Woh kuch nahi bola.

Par line band nahi ki.

Kuch der waise hi raha.

Phir dheere se —

"Good night."

Teen saal dekhe hain maine.

0.75 se chookta hua.

Ek paper kharab hota hua.

Sivi ko jaate hue.

Library mein subah se shaam.

Aaj woh beech mein tha —

Kanpur aur Lucknow ke.

Aspirant.

Par jis tarah se woh beech mein rehta hai —

woh bhi ek tarah ka hona hai.

Kal result nahi aayega.

Kuch hafte hain.

Main wait kar sakti hoon.

— N.

Past continues...

CHAPTER 18

Eklavya

26 September 2024 | Kanpur

A. The Night

The room light was off.

I lay on the bed, eyes closed, facing the wall.

Sleep should have come. Tomorrow mattered.

But my mind was loud.

Five minutes. Fifteen minutes.

I got up.

Picked up the phone and put Osho on speaker — Ashtavakra Gita.

"Tum wahi ho jo dekh raha hai. Karta tum nahi ho."

The philosophy was fine.

But if the system hung tomorrow — who would be the doer?

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The city lights were far away.

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The lights there would be off. She would be asleep.

And me?

I was still the same.

An aspirant.

This word feels different now.

Aspirant means someone who hasn't become anything yet. Someone who is still trying.

I came back.

Played Parmar Sir's audio. Polity.

Sometime around three, sleep finally came.

B. Morning | 4:30

Bhaiya knocked on the door.

"Chal. Nikalna hai."

My eyes opened. Heavy.

Drank water. Washed my face. Looked in the mirror.

My eyes were red. Slightly swollen.

Got ready.

Kurta. Jeans. Bag.

Before leaving, I looked into Pihu's room.

She was sleeping beside Bhabhi.

In her sleep her hand moved — for no reason.

In my mind I said — tere liye.

At five the Swift left.

Bhaiya in the driver's seat.

The radio murmured softly.

He didn't ask — "Taiyaari kaisi hai?"

He knew the question was useless.

He just drove.

Light began spreading on the highway.

Fields appeared.

Farmers ploughing.

They know what they are doing.

Seeds go in.

The crop comes out.

My process?

Give the paper.

Face glitches.

Wait for the result.

The farmer was clearer than me.

A message from Naina appeared on my phone.

"Chai mili?"

"Raaste mein hoon."

"All the best. Ladna mat system se. Bas paper dena."

She knew.

She always knew.

C. The Centre | 10:30

There was a crowd outside.

The same faces.

The same fear.

People flipping through notes.

I got my seat.

Corner.

Turned on the computer.

Moved the mouse.

The cursor lagged.

Click. Late response.

Click again. Late.

I called the invigilator.

"Sir. Mouse glitch kar raha hai."

He looked.

"Chal toh raha hai."

"Sir smooth nahi hai."

He picked up a piece of tape and stuck it under the mouse.

Jugaad.

"Ab theek hai. Change nahi hoga."

I remembered Bhaiya.

Remembered Pihu.

Swallowed the anger.

11:45. The paper began.

Timer: 60:00

Q1. GK. Easy.

Q5. Reasoning.

The screen froze.

Cursor gone.

10 seconds.

20 seconds.

30 seconds.

The screen returned.

Focus had shifted.

Q15.

Freeze again.

This time forty seconds.

Naina had said — "Ladna mat system se."

But the system was fighting me.

I took a long breath.

To hell with the mouse.

I will do what I know.

Last five minutes fast.

Timer zero.

"Your exam has been submitted."

D. Return | 12:45

I stepped outside.

The sunlight hurt my eyes.

Bhaiya stood near the car, speaking on the phone.

He saw me. Cut the call. Held out a bottle of water.

"Kaisa gaya?"

I drank.

The lump in my throat went down.

Should I tell the truth?

That the mouse was bad?

That the system froze three times?

No.

He had driven a hundred kilometres.

He didn't need complaints.

He needed hope.

"Theek tha. Pre clear ho jayega."

It wasn't a lie.

But it wasn't the whole truth either.

I took out my phone.

"Done?"

"Haan. Glitch tha. Mouse issue. Par attempt theek hain."

"Ghar pahunch ke call karna. Ab sochna band."

The car started.

I leaned back against the seat.

Bhaiya turned on the radio.

Kanpur was behind us.

Lucknow was ahead.

And I —

was still in between.

Still.

NAINA — DIARY

26 September 2024 | Night

Today was his exam.

*In the morning I texted —
“Chai mili?”*

A stupid question. But I sent it.

He was on the way.

In the afternoon a message came — there was a glitch. The mouse wasn't working.

My first thought was anger. At the system.

Then I thought — he still gave the paper. Completely. With the glitch.

That's who he is.

At night he called.

“Kaisa laga?”

“Theek tha.”

“Sach mein?”

He stayed silent for a second.

“Attempt 88 the. Accuracy theek thi. Glitch ne 2–3 minute waste kiye. Par ho gaya.”

“Result kab?”

“Pata nahi. Kuch hafte.”

We stayed quiet for a while.

“So jao,” I said.

“Haan.”

“Sentinel.”

“Haan.”

“Tum pehle se jaante ho.”

He didn’t say anything.

But he didn’t cut the call either. The line stayed open for a while.

Then softly —

“Good night.”

I have seen three years of this.

Missing by 0.75.

A bad paper.

Sivi leaving.

The library from morning to evening.

Today he stood between Kanpur and Lucknow.

An aspirant.

But the strange thing is — the way he lives in that in-between space...

that too is a kind of being.

The result won’t come tomorrow.

There are weeks.

I can wait.

— N.

CHAPTER 19

Eklavya

October 2024 | Lucknow

A. 8 October | Morning

I woke up and checked my phone.

There was a message from Naina — sent at midnight.

“Happy birthday Sentinel. Kal milte hain.”

Twenty-six.

The fan moved slowly above me. Outside the October sunlight had already filled the room.

From inside the house Bhaiya called out,

“Chai ban rahi hai.”

Then I heard Pihu’s laughter.

It was a new sound.

It had started only a few weeks ago.

The day began.

B. Campus

Sitapur Road — outside the city.

The moment we reached the gate it became clear that this place was different.

Red brick buildings. Large gates. Green lawns.

Two hundred acres.

Completely separate from the noise of the city.

Naina was inside.

She met me at the gate.

“Aao.”

We walked.

She kept explaining things.

Students moved around holding case files.

Some sat in groups discussing something.

Someone sat alone with a laptop in the corner.

Everything here had direction.

Everyone seemed to be building something.

I just watched.

This was her place.

You could tell immediately.

C. Cafeteria

We sat down.

Naina started explaining something — group project, presentation.

Just then a boy walked in.

“Naina. Hi.”

He was tall.

There was a specific kind of confidence about him — the kind that comes from IIT campuses.

“Eklavya,” Naina introduced me.

“Arjun. Batchmate.”

He shook my hand.

Looked at me for a second.

“You are lucky.”

Then he turned toward Naina and looked straight into her eyes.

“Love is a feeling. But survival is a competition — and I always win.”

For a moment there was silence.

I said one word.

“Inevitable.”

Arjun looked at me again.

Then smiled.

And walked away.

Naina looked at me.

Neither of us said anything.

We finished our tea.

D. The Lawn

On the way back we stopped on the lawn.

October sunlight — the kind that doesn't burn. It simply exists.

"Kaisa laga?" she asked.

"Tumhari jagah hai."

"Tumhari jagah?"

I stayed quiet for a moment.

Then I said,

"Koi pahad. Koi nadi. Jahan koi na ho. Bas main hoon — khud se milun. Koi result nahi. Koi prove karna nahi."

She stayed silent.

Then —

She placed a hand on my shoulder.

Gently.

She moved closer.

It wasn't exactly a hug.

Something else.

That warmth which appears when someone silently decides — main yahan hoon.

And for one moment — just one —

there was the faint closeness of lips near lips.

No words.

The trees on the lawn moved in the wind.

She stepped back.

Looked at me.

Her eyes weren't calm.

They were controlled.

But they were there.

I didn't say anything either.

Some moments become smaller the moment you try to explain them with words.

E. Return

We took an auto back.

Slowly the city returned around us.

The campus disappeared behind.

The result date was still unknown.

According to the answer key my score was 148.

There was a chance.

But not the kind of confidence that should exist.

For now there was only waiting.

I returned to my room.

Pihu was asleep.

Bhaiya didn't ask anything.

Twenty-six years.

And that moment on the lawn —

was still somewhere inside

NAINA — DIARY

8 October 2024 | Night

Today was his birthday.

I didn't smoke.

I didn't drink.

He didn't notice.

I didn't tell him.

It just happened.

On the lawn he spoke about mountains. A river. Being alone.

He truly wants that.

And in that moment — I don't know why — I couldn't stop myself.

I hugged him.

And for a moment — that moment.

He didn't say anything.

Neither did I.

Because some things stop existing the moment you try to say them.

Arjun's line —

"Love is a feeling. But survival is a competition — and I always win."

Eklavya said only one word —

"Inevitable."

Arjun had no answer.

Neither did I for that moment.

But inside there was something —

that feeling which appears when someone stands for you without saying anything.

Without planning it.

The result will come whenever it comes.

148 is borderline.

He knows it.

I know it.

Both of us are quiet.

That too is a kind of conversation.

— N.

CHAPTER 20

Eklavya

December 2024 | Lucknow – Kusumpur

A. 5 December | Night

The PDF opened.

Ctrl + F.

Roll number.

No Match Found.

I closed the laptop.

The fan was still moving.

It was a December night.

I didn't think anything.

It was over.

B. 16 December | Scorecard

153.something.

Cutoff — 153.18981

Gap — 0.18

Three years.

Four attempts.

0.18.

I went to Yadav's shop.

It had grown bigger.

A new board — GRADUATE MOMOS.

One more table.

More confident lettering.

Yadav looked at me.

For a second.

“Hua nahi?”

“0.18 se.”

He said nothing.

Just placed a plate in front of me.

We ate.

Both silent.

I came home.

Pihu was on the carpet.

Holding the Ram Lala toy in her hand.

Now she could hold things properly.

I sat down beside her.

“Nahi hua Pihu. 0.18 se.”

She kept looking at the toy.

I just sat there.

C. The Weight

Something inside refused to come out.

I went to the library.

Studied.

Returned home.

But the thing that once drove me —

had become weaker.

Naina was busy with her projects.

Messages came.

“Theek ho?”

“Haan.”

I wasn’t okay.

But I didn’t want to say it.

Her world was moving forward.

Mine was still there —

the same bench.

The same seat.

The same PDF.

D. Kusumpur | Baba’s Kuti

I went there.

Mother asked nothing.

Just served food.

Father was at the shop.

I sat there too.

Three hours.

No words.

In the evening he said —

“Bahut paas ho. Ek baar aur.”

I didn’t say anything.

But the line stayed inside.

Later I spoke to Karan.

After half an hour he said,

“Bhai. Tum ho nahi jo ban rahe ho. Zabardasti ghis rahe ho — career mein bhi. Rishte mein bhi. Dono ek saath nahi hote.”

There was sunlight outside.

“Ek din choose karna padega.”

I didn’t say anything.

But it was true.

Something I already knew.

Something I hadn’t accepted yet.

E. Sarayu

At night I went to the bank of the Sarayu.

I stood outside the kuti.

A diya burned inside.

The shadows moved.

I didn’t go in.

I never go in.

Not yet.

But I come here.

Up to this point.

2004.

I was six.

Villagers had gathered.

My nakshatra. My birth timing.

Everything wrong.

I went to Baba myself.

Held his kurta.

“Baba... kya main sach mein manhoos hoon?”

He picked me up.

Took a grain of rice from a sack.

Placed it on his palm.

“Sirf chawal nahi. Ek beej hai yeh. Ek jaan jo abhi so rahi hai.”

“Tera nakshatra hai Mool — jad.”

“Tu ek bargad banne aaya hai.”

“And when the roots of a banyan tree enter the earth, the fragile walls around it always crack.”

2009.

Ten years old.

Vinay.

Sarayu.

He went inside.

Didn't come back.

I stood on the bank.

Went to Baba.

He said nothing.

Just sat beside me on the same ground.

Fifteen minutes.

Silence.

Then —

“Maut jab lene aati hai, toh das saal ke bacche ke rokne se nahi rukti.”

That day I cried.

A lot.

2011.

Grandmother.

The flickering lantern flame.

“When a storyteller leaves — they plant all their love and all their experiences inside the one who listens.”

The night before she died —

I told her the same story she had once told me.

Even in pain she smiled.

2016.

Karan’s father.

I had gone there angry.

“Sab jhooth hai Baba.”

He looked at me.

A man who has seen everything doesn’t react much to the anger of an eighteen-year-old.

He just said,

“Ja. Apni yatra shuru kar.”

“Jo dhundh raha hai — pa le.”

“Aur jab thak jaaye — laut aana.”

“Yeh darwaza hamesha khula hai.”

The diya was still burning.

I stood outside the kuti.

I didn’t have the courage to go inside.

Because this was my story.

I had to walk my journey myself.

Just then Naina called.

I picked up.

Turned the camera toward the Sarayu.

“Yeh dekho.”

She stayed silent for a second.

“Yahan shor nahi hai.”

“Nahi.”

“Woh kuti kya hai?”

“Baba rehte hain.”

“Andar nahi jaate?”

“Nahi.”

Pause.

“Eklavya.”

Her voice sounded different.

“What do you actually want — freedom? Or escape?”

“And this peace you are searching for... do you want liberation?”

“From what?”

“What exactly are you looking for?”

The water kept flowing.

"There is a place," I said slowly.

"A place that belongs only to you."

"Where no one else exists."

"Where you are only yourself."

"That emptiness — that shoonya."

"Everyone has their own."

"I want to reach there."

"And me?" she asked quietly.

"What about me?"

The Sarayu kept flowing.

"This journey was till here."

"Up to this point."

"Beyond this... if we meet again, it will be in another journey."

She cut the call.

I stood outside the kuti.

There was the diya.

The river.

The night.

I didn't think anything.

NAINA — DIARY

December 2024 | Night

I cut the call.

Angry.

“Aage kisi aur yatra mein milenge.”

So calm.

As if he had solved an equation.

I was angry.

Because he was right.

And that is the worst kind of anger —

when the other person is right

and you have nothing to say.

Three years.

Tapri.

Library.

Renaissance.

Night drives.

Sarayu on a phone screen.

And he just says —

“Aage kisi aur yatra mein.”

Freedom or escape.

That was my question.

He didn’t answer directly.

But what he said was the answer.

He isn’t escaping.

He truly wants that place.

The place that belongs only to him.

And I —

I am not that place.

I knew it.

But hearing it is different.

The phone is still in my hand.

I won't call.

Not now.

Because right now there is only anger.

And that anger isn't for him.

It is for myself.

Because I knew this day would come.

And I stayed anyway.

— N.

CHAPTER 21

Eklavya

10 January 2025 | Lucknow

A. Return

I came back to Lucknow.

Seat 17.

Books.

Sivi at Seat 18.

Nothing outside had changed.

Inside, everything was different.

A message from Naina appeared.

“Milna hai.”

“When?”

“Aaj shaam.”

B. The Tapri | Evening

She was already there.

She hadn't ordered tea.

Her hands were on the table in front of her.

Fingers still.

I sat down.

For a while neither of us spoke.

Behind us the tea pot was boiling.

Chacha was talking to someone else.

The city was loud — vehicles, people, voices.

But on this bench there was silence.

"Woh raat wali baat," she began.

"Main sochti rahi."

"Haan."

"Tum sach bol rahe the."

"Haan."

"Par main us waqt woh sunne ke liye ready nahi thi."

The tea seller passed by.

Both of us refused.

A second passed.

"Tum jaoge?"

"I don't know when. But yes."

"Aur main?"

"You are where you belong. That is your place."

She looked at me for a moment.

"Eklavya," she said, her voice steady.

"Main tumse poochh rahi hoon — main kahan hoon tumhare liye?"

It was a direct question.

It needed a direct answer.

“You are someone I met in this journey. Something real. Something true. But my journey isn’t finished yet. And yours has only just begun. We are moving in different directions at the same time.”

She stayed quiet.

“I don’t want to become a burden for you. And I don’t want you to miss anything because of me.”

Outside the city continued.

People moved.

Vehicles passed.

But the two of us remained separate from that noise — on this bench.

“Theek hai,” she said softly.

A second passed.

“Par ek baat.”

“Haan.”

“Jo tha — woh real tha. Isko koi aur naam mat dena.”

“I won’t.”

She stood up.

For a moment she remained beside the table.

Then her hand went into her bag.

A diary.

Her diary.

She extended it toward me.

I didn’t take it immediately.

I just looked at it.

She looked at me directly.

That direct gaze she always had.

From the first day.

From the tapri.

From the lighter.

It had never changed.

“I don’t know you as much as I should have,” she said.

“But I know this — when you disappear, you never look back.”

She paused.

“This diary is for that. So you don’t forget me. What we had — it was real.”

I took the diary.

It had weight in the hand.

Exactly the amount it should have.

There were words inside me that could have been said.

But what she had already said existed in the same place where I myself was searching for something.

No other sentence could reach there.

So I said nothing.

She turned.

Her footsteps moved away.

Then they disappeared into the noise of the city.

I remained sitting there.

The diary in my hand.

C. Night

I returned to my room.

Pihu was asleep.

Bhaiya didn’t ask anything.

I stood near the window.

Outside it was a January night.

The city remained where it always was —

lights,

noise,

people.

The diary was still in my hand.

Inside there was something that carried two things at once.

What was right.

And what was lost.

Sometimes both exist together.

I stood there for a while.

Then placed the diary on the desk.

Exactly where it belonged.

(Chapter 21 — End)

*CHAPTER 22 What the Camera Keeps March 18–19, 2026 — Heritage Threads,
Lucknow*

A. The Morning Light | March 18

The word was still there when I closed my eyes.

Inevitable.

It wasn't circling my mind. It wasn't making demands. It was just occupying a corner of the room, the way a heavy piece of furniture does when no one has decided yet where it belongs.

I didn't try to move it. In for four. Hold. Out.

At some point, the thinking stopped being thinking and simply became breathing. Sleep arrived without an announcement.

The next morning, the ceiling came into focus first, followed by the specific quality of the light. March does something unique to mornings—it strips away both the biting

grey of winter and the blinding aggression of summer. What is left is just pure light, doing its job quietly.

Pihu was already awake. I could hear her relocating things in the living room with the fierce determination of someone operating on a system that only she understood.

Opening shift today. Two things were simultaneously true as I sat up on the mat: Naina might walk through that showroom door today. Or she might not.

I held both possibilities in my head without choosing between them. Neither was an emergency.

I stepped out of my room. Pihu's door was slightly ajar. She had her Ram Lala toy tilted at an angle—twenty degrees, maybe thirty—deeply examining something about its base. She glanced up at me. She raised one hand, flat and brief.

I raised my hand back. She returned to her investigation.

A. The Profile Picture | 2:45 PM

The post-lunch lull had settled over the showroom. The floor was empty of customers.

Anshika was leaning over the billing counter, staring at my phone screen with deep exasperation.

"Tumhara account exist hi kyun karta hai?" she asked, annoyed. "Zero posts. Zero bio. Ek aam insaan ki tarah ek normal photo nahi daal sakte?"

"Company policy mein account banana likha tha. Usey sajane ko nahi," I replied smoothly, organizing a stack of tags.

"Boring. Tum genuinely boring ho Eklavya."

I heard the faint, rhythmic sound of footsteps on the wooden stairs. I didn't need to look up to know who it was.

Naina was walking down from the mezzanine floor. Her posture was relaxed today. The usual sharp, corporate armor seemed to be resting somewhere else. Murli immediately stood up straight, and Anshika pulled away from my phone, returning to her professional stance.

But Naina wasn't in an inspecting mood. She stopped a few feet away from the counter. She pulled out her own phone, raised it, and pointed the camera directly at me.

I stopped sorting the tags.

Click.

She took the picture. Openly. No 'brand archive' excuses today. She looked at her screen, smiled to herself, and then walked over to the counter.

"Anshika, third quarter ki file update ho gayi?" she asked casually.

"Ji Ma'am. Subah hi bhej di thi."

Naina nodded. Then she turned to me and extended her hand.

"Apna phone do," she commanded.

I hesitated for half a second before unlocking it and placing it in her palm. She looked at my blank Instagram profile and let out a dramatic sigh, mirroring Anshika's earlier frustration.

"Tragic," Naina muttered. "Tumhara digital existence bahut tragic hai."

She tapped on her own phone, then tapped on mine. A notification popped up on my screen. She had Airdropped the photo she just took.

"Yeh photo dekho," she said, sliding my phone back across the glass counter. "Light perfect hai. Angle best hai. Yeh tumhari profile picture banegi."

I looked at the image. It was a candid shot of me standing by the rack, the afternoon sunlight catching the side of my face. It was undeniably a good photograph.

"Zaroorat nahi hai—" I started.

"Zaroorat hai," she interrupted. And then, she stepped closer.

She closed the two feet of professional distance between us. She was standing entirely in my personal space now. I could smell the faint, familiar notes of her perfume—vanilla and something sharp, like citrus.

She reached up. For a second, my breath caught in my throat. Her fingers brushed against the collar of my blue uniform shirt. She slowly, deliberately folded down a tiny crease at the edge of my collar that I hadn't noticed.

Her knuckles grazed my neck. A sudden, electric warmth shot straight through my pulse.

"Collar theek rakha karo," she said. Her voice was suddenly much softer, meant only for the few inches of space between us. Her brown eyes looked up into mine. The air in the showroom completely stilled.

"Ab better hai," she whispered.

Then, she stepped back, instantly breaking the spell, and turned to Anshika.

"Isko sikhao ki followers kaise badhate hain," Naina said, her tone suddenly light and playful. "Reels ka algorithm samjhao isey. He is living in the stone age."

What followed was bizarre, but incredibly warm. For the next twenty minutes, there was no 'Owner Ma'am' and 'Floor Staff'. It was just three people in their twenties discussing social media. Naina leaned against the counter, enthusiastically explaining how audio trends worked. Anshika chimed in, completely shedding her nervousness.

I mostly listened, offering a dry, stoic remark every few minutes that made Naina laugh. An actual, unburdened laugh that reached her eyes. The afternoon light flooded the showroom. For a brief, fleeting window of time, everything felt incredibly normal.

Then, Naina's phone rang on the glass counter.

The screen flashed: Arjun.

The laughter died. The light in the room seemed to physically dim. Naina picked up the phone. Her posture instantly shifted, the invisible corporate armor snapping back into place.

"Haan, Arjun," she answered, her voice returning to its measured, controlled pitch.

She listened for a few seconds. Her eyes widened slightly.

"Maa ka kurta? National Museum? Tum sach keh rahe ho?" She looked at me, a sudden wave of complicated emotions crossing her face, before she turned and walked quickly toward the glass doors to take the call outside.

The normal moment was over. The real world had just dialed back in.

INTERLUDE Naina's Diary | March 18, 2026 | 11:45 PM

I said yes to the engagement tonight.

Writing it down. Making it permanent.

Dinner at the Taj. Papa, Maa, Arjun. I thought it was a quarterly celebration. I was wrong.

Arjun brought an envelope. Ministry of Culture seal. National Museum, Delhi — Maa's kurta. Rohan's kurta. Permanent heritage exhibit.

Her hands shook. She kept touching the emblem. Over and over.

I haven't seen her look like that in years.

Then Arjun said — wait. Before anything else. I need to say something.

"I've spent my entire life being good at things. Boards. JEE. The startup. Everything had a metric. You were the only thing I couldn't measure. And I tried. God knows I tried."

I didn't say anything.

"You never made it easy. I don't think you even noticed how hard I was trying. Main jaanta hoon, Naina. Main always jaanta tha. Par main gaya nahi. Because I didn't want a relationship that was easy. I wanted this one."

"Two years. Every version of you — distracted, unavailable, somewhere else in your head. I stayed. Because whatever little was there — it was real. And I can wait for real."

He held out his hand.

"So. Will you marry me? Properly. Knowing that I know exactly what I'm asking."

I looked at him.

Then I looked at Maa.

She was looking at me. Those eyes — the ones she's had since Rohan. The ones that ask without asking.

Three years. Every thread.

"Haan," I heard myself say.

Didn't think before. Didn't think after.

Maa exhaled. Papa raised his glass. Arjun closed his eyes — just one second — then came back. Composed. Warm. Right.

Dinner continued. Wine came. Maa held my hand. I must have said the right things. I don't remember exactly what.

Sitting here now.

I know what I did. I know why I did it.

What I can't explain — something else happened in that same second. Underneath the yes. A door. Closing very quietly. The way a door closes when someone has already left and isn't coming back.

I know that feeling.

I just didn't know it would feel this final.

Maa squeezed my hand during dessert. Whispered — "Khush hoon, beta."

I said — "Main bhi."

One of those was true.

I picked up my phone before turning off the light.

His profile picture had changed.

The photo I took this afternoon. Afternoon light. Blue shirt. He's not looking at the camera — he's looking somewhere slightly to the left, the way he always does when he's thinking. I don't know why I noticed that. I did.

I took that photo. Three hours before I said yes to someone else.

I put the phone face down on the bed.

Laptop off. Light off.

— N.

CHAPTER 23

Fifteen Minutes of Silence

March 21, 2026 — Lucknow

A. The Safety Officer | Morning

I opened the gate, and the cool air immediately rushed in. It was the middle of March. The sunlight was soft, the wind slightly dry.

The bike was parked in the corner. I had just put the key into the ignition when I saw a tiny shadow moving in from the left.

"Chacho..."

Pihu was curling her way toward the gate. She was in her night-suit, one sandal on her foot, the other completely bare.

"Arre, madam," I said. "Poora pair pehen ke aao."

She looked down at her feet, then back up at me. The missing sandal was an entirely irrelevant detail to her.

"Chacho... baai... gumm." A direct demand.

Bhaiya was standing in the doorframe. His shirt was half-buttoned, a tie hanging loosely over his shoulder.

"Ek chakkar," he said in a normal, even tone. "Helmet ke saath. Road se bahar nahi."

"Ek hi," I repeated.

Pihu had already reached the bike. She tapped her small palm against my helmet.

"Helet. Chacho... helet." Her expression was dead serious, as if she were reminding me of a critical protocol.

"Tu chief safety officer hai," I said, strapping the helmet on.

I made her sit on the front seat. Both her hands were placed near the center of the handle. I held her waist securely with my left hand. Engine on. A slow, steady round around the building premises.

The wind hit our faces. From right in front of me, I could hear Pihu's tiny voice.

"Hee hee... gumm... gumm..."

A stray dog was sitting near the drain at the corner. She waved her hand at it.

"Bow bow..."

"Bow bow ko bhi office jaana hai," I commented lightly.

Two rounds. The brake. Back to the gate.

As I was getting her off the bike, she tapped the helmet one more time.

"Firr... kal gumm."

"Dekhenge," I said.

She looked straight into my eyes.

"Chacho... aana." Her words were slightly clearer this time.

"Try karunga." I offered a faint smile.

She ran back toward the corridor. "Papa... chacho baai gumm..." Her voice faded inside the house.

I took the bike out onto the road. The wide roads of Gomti Nagar. Office crowds on scooters, yellow school vans, delivery riders. The plan for the day was simple: the showroom, people, clothes, and standing on my feet until the night.

B. The Blue Rack | Afternoon

The shutter of Heritage Threads was half-raised. Suresh saw me and pulled it all the way up.

"Namaste, bhaiya."

"Haan." I gave a brief nod.

Inside, there was the faint, sterile smell of the AC, fresh paint, and the crisp starch of new clothes. Murli was running a cloth over the entrance mirror for the last time.

"Subah," Anshika Shukla called out from the counter. Her hair was tied up in a clip, her laptop already booted up.

"Subah."

"Dekha? Aaj time pe aaye ho."

"Traffic ka mood achha tha," I replied.

"Blue rack tumhare naam pe hai. Kal wali aunty wapas aa sakti hain," she warned.

"Hmm."

The routine was simple. Straighten the tags. Fold the sleeves. Ensure all hangers face the exact same direction.

C. The Empty Floor | 9:15 PM

Closing routine.

Murli on the mirrors. Suresh at the gate. Anshika closing down the register.

I was at the blue rack—the final round. Checking tags. Spacing. One hanger was slightly tilted; I corrected it.

Rajesh Sir was in his cabin, putting on his coat. "Eklavya, sab theek hai?"

"Haan, Sir."

"Achha. Jaao phir."

The staff filed out one by one. Murli first. Then Suresh. Anshika locked the cash counter, picked up her bag, gave me a single, unreadable glance without saying a word, and then she was gone too.

Rajesh Sir stepped out of the cabin. "Lights tum band kar dena. Main bahar hoon." He walked toward the glass doors, already talking to someone on his phone.

The showroom was almost empty.

Almost.

D. The Fifteen Minutes

Naina was standing near the center island.

She had come down after the staff had left. There was no file in her hand, no bag, no official reason. It was just her.

She was wearing a white kurta. Her hair was left open. She looked exactly the way she sometimes did on a Sunday morning—when the untouchable corporate armor was left behind at home.

She looked at the ivory piece—the one lakh forty thousand rupee piece. She reached out, feeling the texture of the heavy fabric with her fingers. Then she pulled her hand away.

I was at the rack. Tags. Spacing.

She didn't look at me. I didn't look at her.

But we both knew the other was there.

A few minutes passed exactly like that.

Then, she sat down near the center island—on the low wooden ledge meant for displays. One hand resting on her knee, the other in her lap.

I left the rack, walked over to a lower shelf—there was a genuine adjustment needed there—and sat down on the floor, leaning my back against the wooden panels.

It was exactly like that evening in April 2023. The first season after the café. The library canteen. The bench. We were both occupying the exact same place—sitting separately—but existing in the same shared space.

Nobody spoke a word.

The showroom lights were half-dimmed now. Rajesh Sir was supposed to turn off the main breakers from outside. The low hum of the AC. The distant, muffled sound of the Gomti Nagar traffic beyond the glass doors. The echo of Murli's three-note whistle wasn't there anymore. He had gone home.

Fifteen minutes.

I only know this because I hadn't been counting. But when she finally spoke, it was 9:32 PM, and when she had walked in, it had been 9:17 PM. I realized the math later.

E. The Announcement

"14 April ko engagement hai."

That was it.

No preamble. No "Mujhe kuch batana tha." Just that single sentence—delivered straight—like something that had been trapped inside for far too many days and simply couldn't be held back anymore.

I kept my back pressed against the shelf. I didn't move a single muscle.

The ivory piece was still sitting there on the center island above us. One lakh forty thousand. Fourteen people. Six months. Rajesh Sir had told me the stats on my first day. It was still right there.

"Arjun ke saath?" I asked quietly.

"Haan."

A one-second pause.

"Sach mein ready ho?"

She stayed quiet.

I didn't need an answer. She knew that. I knew that too. But the question existed because it was necessary for the question to exist. Some things are spoken simply so they can hang in the air—so that someone hears them out loud at least once.

She kept looking at the ivory piece.

I kept looking at the floor tiles.

The AC kept humming. The traffic kept moving further away.

Then:

"Pata nahi."

Just that.

"Sach mein nahi pata."

F. The Departure

I started to stand up.

"Eklavya."

I stopped.

She still wasn't looking at me. Her eyes were fixed on the ivory piece. Always the ivory piece.

"Kuch nahi. Bas — ruk jao ek second."

One second.

Two.

Then, she stood up. She picked up her bag—I didn't even know when she had set it down. She smoothed out the creases on her white kurta.

"Rajesh ji bahar hain. Gate lock karna hoga." The business tone. Exactly that. "Goodnight."

She walked toward the glass doors. She placed one hand on the handle. She stopped—just for a fraction of a heartbeat, just one—and then pulled it open.

She stepped outside. The sharp click of her footsteps fading.

The heavy engine of the SUV roaring to life.

A left turn at the signal.

Gone.

G. The Aftermath

I stood there in the silence.

The showroom was left with only the hum of the AC, the ivory piece, and the half-dimmed lights.

From outside, Rajesh Sir's voice called out: "Eklavya, sab theek?"

"Haan Sir. Aa raha hoon."

I turned off the remaining lights. Locked the glass gate. Stepped out into the night.

The Lucknow night—the vehicles, the people, the yellow streetlights.

Everything was exactly where it had always been.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | March 21, 2026 | Night

I had to go today.

There was no other reason. No file, no inventory review. I just had to go. I just had to tell him. Because if I didn't—if he heard it from someone else, or if he saw it himself on April 14th—it would have been different. I didn't know this before. Today, I knew.

The staff left. Rajesh ji stepped outside. I stayed back near the center island.

He was at the rack. I was staring at the ivory piece.

We were both just there. Neither of us said a word.

Fifteen minutes.

I don't know how those fifteen minutes passed. But they did.

And then I spoke.

"14 April ko engagement hai."

He stayed quiet.

Exactly the way he always stays quiet—that specific silence that processes things, that doesn't judge, that simply... listens. He listens.

"Arjun ke saath?" he asked.

"Haan."

A one-second silence.

"Sach mein ready ho?"

That question.

That exact question.

Three years ago, sitting on a bench in the park, he had asked me—"Upset ho ya irritated?"—and those two simple words had shattered my entire script. Today, it was just one question. Just one.

"Sach mein ready ho?"

No lecture. No "Yeh sahi nahi hai." No imposition of his own opinion. Just that question—direct, stripped of any extra weight, exactly what needed to be asked.

And me—I didn't know the answer.

I don't know why I expected that I would know. I thought that when he finally asked, something would rise up from deep inside me—either a resounding yes, or a definitive no—and I would finally know the truth.

Nothing rose up.

Just that same flat, suffocating silence that has been living inside me since March 18th.

"Pata nahi. Sach mein nahi pata."

He started to get up.

I told him to stop.

Why? I don't know. There was no follow-up sentence. There was no logical reason. I just needed him to stay there for one more second. Just that.

One second. Two.

Then I stood up. Bag. Kurta. Gate.

"Goodnight."

I sat in my car for a full minute.

I didn't start the engine.

He had asked—"Sach mein ready ho?"

And I had said—"Pata nahi."

This was the answer I should have given to Arjun. This was the answer I should have given to Dr. Mehta. But instead, I gave it—inside a half-lit showroom, standing in front of an ivory piece—to him.

Because he asks when he needs to ask. And he stays quiet when he needs to stay quiet.

And me—I know what I should do. Everyone knows what they should do. What we want to do is an entirely different thing.

The two don't always exist together.

I started the engine.

Left turn at the signal.

— N.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary | March 22 – 24, 2026

March 22 | Night

Arjun planned a dinner tonight. The Taj. The exact same place.

He was trying so hard. Dal makhani. No butter naan. Sparkling water. He remembered every single preference perfectly.

But I wasn't there.

I mean—I was. Physically. I was sitting in the chair, my hands were resting on the table, my eyes were directed at him. But I wasn't actually there.

He kept talking—the Q2 expansion, the follow-up for Maa's kurta at the National Museum, playing golf with Papa. Everything was organized. Everything was thoughtful. Everything was exactly the way it was supposed to be.

I nodded. I smiled exactly when I was supposed to smile.

His hand reached across the table and held mine. It was warm. It was deliberate.

I looked at it and thought to myself: This is a hand. This is a table. This is a restaurant. Everything is in exactly the right place.

I am the one in the wrong place.

Then I silently scolded myself—stop thinking like this. Arjun is genuinely a good man. What he did for Maa was incredibly real. Being 'good' and being 'present' are two entirely different things—but presence can be learned. It just takes time.

But the entire three hours of that dinner were spent desperately trying to convince myself of that.

March 23 | Afternoon

I didn't go to the showroom today.

It was intentional.

There was work—Q2 projections, the March-end audit, reviewing files with Rajesh ji. But I didn't go to Gomti Nagar. I sat in the main office and did everything from there. Over the phone. Over email.

Rajesh ji called in the afternoon.

"Ma'am, aaoge aaj?"

"Nahi. Files bhej do."

That was it.

March 24 | Morning

Session with Dr. Mehta.

She sat across from me and asked, "Kya chal raha hai?"

I told her. The engagement. Arjun. The inability to remain present at dinner.

She kept listening, taking her notes.

Then she stopped, looked over her glasses, and asked: "Aur kya chal raha hai?"

"Bas yahi," I replied.

"Naina."

I stayed quiet.

"Bas yahi nahi hai," she stated calmly.

I know what her answer is. I've known it since March 14th, when he was standing at the blue rack and simply said, "Good evening, Ma'am." Those three words perfectly fit into a massive void inside me that I desperately wanted to fill, and was utterly terrified of filling, both at the exact same time.

I didn't tell Dr. Mehta about him.

Some things you don't even tell your doctor.

— N.

CHAPTER 24: THE FIRST SLIP

March 27, 2026 — Lucknow

The phone vibrated. 8:47 AM.

Bank notification.

Account credited: ₹18,500.

I stared at the screen.

The café had paid in cash. Hand to hand. Sometimes more, sometimes less, sometimes three days of nothing. That money had a texture. The SSC years — Bhaiya's support, library fees, odd work here and there.

This was the first time a number appeared on a screen. Solid. With a slip. In an account.

No ambiguity. How much. From where. Why.

I didn't expect to feel anything. No pride. No relief. Just that neutral settling when something becomes exactly what it is. Nothing more. Nothing less.

Showroom. Kurtas. Tags. Customers. Billing.

What is, is.

Bhaiya's room door was open. Laptop bag on the bed.

He glanced at the screen.

"Salary aayi?"

"Haan."

He nodded. Didn't ask the amount. Never had — not during the café, not during the library years. That was Bhaiya's one consistent thing. Acknowledgment without interrogation.

"Achha hai," he said.

Door closed.

Pihu was in the hall.

On the carpet. The Ram Lala toy sat a few feet away where Bhabhi had placed it. Pihu stared at it. Then her hand moved. Slow. Deliberate.

I watched from the doorway.

I'd seen this scene before. March 2023. But the motor skills were different then. Now the hand reached. Fingers gripped fabric. Grip held.

By herself.

I sat on the floor.

She looked up. Hands reached. "Aaa. Uuu."

"Therapy mein madad karunga ab. Apni salary se."

The words weren't for her. But they needed saying. Some things become real when spoken aloud.

She smiled. From the corners. The same smile that first appeared three years ago.

Some things don't change.

Bhabhi came out of the kitchen.

"Eklavya, tumhe bhi apne liye—"

"Bhabhi."

She stopped.

"Mera bhi haq hai. Pihu meri hai."

Her eyes filled. Lips pressed tight. She turned back to the kitchen.

9:15. Phone. Mummy.

"Beta, kaisa hai?"

"Theek hoon."

"Pihu kaisi hai?"

"Better ho rahi. Therapy chal rahi hai."

"Achha. Pooja karte hain uske liye. Tu khaata hai theek se na?"

"Haan, Mummy."

The sequence was the same. During the SSC years too. Result kab aayega — that question would fold itself into her "theek hai beta."

"Mummy, salary aayi aaj. Bhej raha hoon thoda."

One second of silence. Her voice slightly heavy.

"Theek hai. Par zyada mat bhej."

Banking app. ₹500. Transfer done.

Something loosened in my chest. That lightness that comes only from your own money.

Yours.

I dialed Karan.

"Ram Ram bhai."

"Ram Ram."

"₹6,000 transfer kar raha hoon Viram ke liye."

He didn't ask questions.

"Theek hai bhai. Main dekhta hoon."

I picked up the bike keys.

Showroom. Ten AM.

Blue rack. Tag. Fold. Space.

Rajesh Sir emerged from the cabin.

"Owner Mam aa rahi hain. Tees minute mein. Staff review."

Murli moved toward the door. Suresh to the gate area. Anshika aligned files.

I stayed at the blue rack.

2:28. Black SUV.

Naina. Smart kurta, trousers. Professional. She'd come for work.

"Good afternoon, Mam."

"Afternoon."

She scanned the showroom. Racks. Lights. Staff. Then straight to Rajesh Sir.

"Rajesh ji, staff review. Cabin mein."

Glass cabin. Transparent walls.

I stayed on the floor.

Only the tone filtered through the glass.

"...attendance..."

"...targets..."

Then clearly:

"Eklavya ka performance kaisa hai?"

My hands stopped.

Rajesh Sir: "Bahut achha, Mam. Complaints zero. Billing accuracy perfect."

Pause.

Naina: "Naye staff ko encourage karna chahiye. Incentive dena chahiye."

Rajesh Sir: "Standard policy ₹2,000 hai."

Naina: "₹5,000 do. Exceptional performance."

The kurta was half-folded in my hands.

₹5,000.

The number registered. Pihu's therapy. Mummy's "zyada mat bhej." This money would help.

Then the second thing arrived. Tapri. Diary. "Jo tha woh real tha."

That was real.

Real things aren't bought with someone else's money.

The cabin door opened. They both stepped out.

She scanned the floor. Eyes landed on me. One second. Neutral. Professional.

Gate. SUV. Engine. Gone.

Rajesh Sir called.

"Eklavya."

I went to the counter.

"Mam ne ₹5,000 ka incentive approve kiya hai. Exceptional performance."

Three seconds.

₹5,000. It would help. But some things can't be taken. Knowing that is a clarity of its own.

"Sir, yeh standard policy hai? Sabko milta hai?"

Rajesh Sir paused. "Nahi. Specifically tumhare liye."

"Sir, main nahi lunga."

He blinked. "Kyun?"

"Performance ke alawa kuch aur factor involved lagta hai. Professional boundary theek hai. Apni salary se khush hoon."

Rajesh Sir looked uncomfortable. He didn't know the details, but he sensed the layers.

"Eklavya, Mam ne genuinely—"

"Sir. Unka respect karta hoon. Par mera decision hai. Politely bata dijiye."

Long silence.

"Theek hai."

I went back to the rack.

Something heavy sat inside. The kind of heaviness that comes even with the right decision when it costs something.

Tag. Fold. Space.

Night. Home.

Mat on the floor. Sitting.

In for four. Hold. Out.

Baba had said once, by the Sarayu:

"Jo cheez tumhari nahi, use pakdoge toh bhaari lagegi. Jo tumhari hai, woh khud halki hoti hai."

₹500 sent to Mummy. Light.

₹6,000 to Karan — for Viram. Also light.

₹5,000 — heavy even without holding it.

Baba wasn't wrong.

Sleep came.

INTERLUDE

Naina's Diary

March 27, 2026 — Night

I went to the showroom today.

Staff review. Legitimate work. I deliberately didn't look at the blue section. Not once.

But in the cabin, while talking to Rajesh ji, I heard it. Not his voice. Them talking about him.

"Zero complaints. Billing perfect. Punctual."

I already knew. But I listened anyway.

"₹5,000 do. Exceptional performance."

I said it. Didn't think about anything else in that moment. Just gave it.

Rajesh ji's message came at night.

"Mam, Eklavya ne bonus lene se mana kar diya. Bola performance-based nahi lagta. Apni salary se khush hoon."

I read that text three times. Then put the phone down.

I'm standing by the window. March night. The city lights scattered the way they always are.

He refused.

₹5,000 would have helped him. I know exactly — Pihu's therapy, home, he needed that money. But he didn't take it.

Three years ago on a bench he held my life's script together. Even then he didn't ask for anything. Today he didn't take it either.

This one thing has always been consistent in him — what isn't his, he doesn't take. And what I wanted to give him... it was never my right to decide whether it was his or not.

He always knew this. I'm the one who keeps forgetting.

Arjun's goodnight message came. Sweet. Exactly the right words.

I replied. Equally right.

Put the phone down.

That freeze inside — it hasn't thawed yet.

Laptop closed. Light off.

—N

CHAPTER 25 The Zero Equation 1 April 2026 — Lucknow

A. The Message

The message came in the afternoon.

"Eklavya. Mil sakte hain? Bas baat karni thi. Arjun."

I looked at the screen for one second.

Then typed — "Haan. Kahan?"

B. The Shade

He was already there when I arrived.

That was the first thing — he had come early. Arjun, who had walked into every room I'd ever seen him in like the room had been waiting for him. Sitting alone on a bench outside a club in Gomti Nagar, the evening light not quite reaching him under the old tree, his jacket on, collar open — and something in the set of his shoulders that didn't belong to him.

He looked up when he heard me.

And I understood, before he said a single word, why he had messaged.

It wasn't the look of a man who had won and wanted to talk about it.

It was the look of a man who had won everything — the engagement, the family dinner, the ring, the dates, the approval — and had been sitting alone with all of it, unable to understand why his hands felt empty.

I sat down. Ordered chai. He didn't take anything.

C. The Investment

"Do saal," he began. Straight. No preamble. The voice of a man who had rehearsed this and still didn't know how to say it.

"Do saal se main isme hoon. Paise lagaye. Time lagaya. Energy lagayi." He was looking at the road. Not at me. "IIM mein connection banaya. Heritage Threads mein investment ki. National Museum tak paise aur connections lagaye — teen mahine ka kaam tha woh. Teen mahine. Follow-ups. Approvals. Har ek door khud se khola." He paused. "Kyunki jo uske liye matter karta tha — woh mujhe pata tha. Aur main wahi karta raha."

My chai arrived. I held the cup.

"Aur phir bhi." His jaw tightened. "Taj mein us raat — jab usne haan kaha — woh excitement nahi thi. Jo honi chahiye thi. Jo dikhni chahiye thi." He stopped. "Tum samajh rahe ho main kya keh raha hoon?"

I said nothing.

He looked at me then — fully, for the first time since I'd sat down. And something crossed his face. Quick. Gone before it fully arrived.

Because he had just realized — sitting here, asking me this question — exactly what he was doing. Who he was asking. And what that meant.

He looked away.

"Main samajh nahi pa raha," he said, quieter. "Do saal ka har decision sahi tha. Har move sahi tha. Toh kya galat hua?"

D. What He Didn't Have

I set my cup on the bench.

"Woh kabhi Rohan ke baare mein baat karti hai tumse?"

He looked at me. Didn't understand why I was asking that. "Haan. Kabhi kabhi."

"Tab tum kya karte ho?"

He considered it carefully. "Main... use better feel karaane ki koshish karta hoon. Batata hoon ki—"

"Woh better feel karna nahi chahti."

He stopped.

"Jab woh Rohan ke baare mein baat kare — chup raho. Kuch solve mat karo. Woh cheez tumhare paas solution leke nahi aayi — woh sirf chahti hai ki koi sune. Bas. Wahan raho. Itna kaafi hai."

He was quiet. Processing it. I could see it — the way an IIT mind takes in new data and tries to fit it into a structure it already has.

"Gomti ke paas se kabhi nikle ho?" I asked.

"Haan."

"Woh ruk jaati hai. Ek minute ke liye. Do minute ke liye." I wasn't asking. "Kuch mat poocho tab. Kahan jaana hai, kya karna hai — woh baad mein hoga. Pehle woh wahan hogi. Tum bhi wahan raho. Bas."

Arjun said nothing. But his hands, resting on his knees, had gone very still.

"Chhoti baaton par argue karegi woh — aisi cheezein jo shayad matter bhi nahi karti. Tab suno. Judge mat karo. Woh sahi hai ya galat — woh second mein aata hai. Pehle sirf suno."

The road held the silence for a moment.

Then, very quietly — almost like it cost him something to ask:

"Yeh sab tumhe kaise pata?"

I picked up my cup.

"Woh batati hai. Agar tum wahan hote ho — woh batati hai."

He heard that. And this time he didn't look away.

This time he sat with it — with the full weight of what I had just said. That I knew. That I had been there. That she had told me — because I had been present enough for her to tell.

He had the engagement. The family's blessing. The ring.

And I knew how she took her chai. I knew what she looked like standing by the Gomti, not moving. I knew what her voice did when she said Rohan's name.

He had won every single thing that could be won.

And he knew, sitting on this bench, exactly what he didn't have.

E. The Trap

He was quiet for a long time.

When he finally spoke, his voice was different. Flatter.

"Uske maa aur baap." Not a question. "Woh hamesha uski kamzori thi."

"Haan."

"Aur main—" he started, and stopped at the sound of his own voice. "National Museum. Dinner. Taj. Maine sab kuch unke liye kiya." A pause that had something breaking in it, very quietly. "Main use unse strong nahi kar raha tha. Main unke through — use pakad raha tha."

He hadn't asked me anything. He had just told himself the truth out loud, the way people do when they've been carrying it alone too long.

I said nothing. There was nothing to add.

F. The Zero Equation

An auto passed on the road. Then two motorcycles.

"Tum jealous nahi ho."

"Shayad hoti," I said. "Pata nahi."

"Shayad?" His voice had an edge in it now — not anger. Something rawer than anger.

"Jealousy tab hoti hai jab tum kuch khone se darte ho. Mutthi bandh ho." I turned the cup slowly. "Meri mutthi khuli thi. Main bas wahan tha — us pal mein. Door bhi nahi tha. Pakda bhi nahi tha."

He looked at me for a long moment.

Then he traced something on the wood of the bench — invisible, to himself.

$$0 + 0 = 0$$

$$0 - 0 = 0$$

"Aryabhatt ne shunya diya tha duniya ko," he said quietly. "Tab tak log sochte the — khaali jagah ka koi matlab nahi hota."

I said nothing.

"Par shunya hi toh woh jagah hai jahan sab kuch shuru hota hai."

He stopped there. The sentence landed somewhere in him and stayed. He didn't go further. Maybe he wasn't ready to. Maybe that was enough for one evening.

G. The Departure

The music from inside the club was faint now. The kind of sound that reminds you other people are having evenings that don't feel like this one.

Arjun sat for a long time.

"Tum use love karte ho," he said finally — quietly, to the road. "Par love karna aur sahi hona... alag alag baatein hoti hain."

I didn't answer.

Because that was his. Entirely his. Arrived at alone. I had no part in it.

He stood. Straightened his jacket — not from habit. From the need to hold himself in one piece.

"Eklavya."

I looked up.

"Woh pehle tumhare paas thi?"

I didn't deny it. I didn't confirm it.

"Hum dono wahan the. Ek hi waqt par."

He heard that. Gave a small nod — not agreement. Understanding.

He walked to his car.

I stayed on the bench.

The chai had gone cold. The tree's shadow had stretched far past the tree itself — the way shadows do in the evening, always larger than the thing that cast them.

INTERLUDE — Naina's Diary | April 8, 2026 | Late Night

Something is different.

I don't know what. But something in the last few days has shifted and I can't locate it and that is making me uncomfortable in a way I don't have a word for yet.

Arjun called on Tuesday. No agenda. No Q2 update. Just called. I asked what was wrong. He said nothing. We talked for twenty minutes about nothing in particular — I mentioned the supplier visit had run late, he asked about the fabric. Actually asked. Follow-up questions and everything.

I remember sitting in the car afterward thinking — that was strange.

And then, underneath that thought, quieter — yeh pehle bhi hua hai. Yeh feeling pehle bhi thi.

I didn't finish the thought. I put my phone in my bag and drove.

Wednesday. We passed the Gomti on the way back from Hazratganj. I stopped — the way I always stop. Just to stand there for a minute.

He stopped too.

No phone. No "chalein?" Just — there. Beside me.

I stood and looked at the water and something in my chest did a thing I didn't ask it to do. Not warmth exactly. Recognition. The specific feeling of being seen doing something you didn't know anyone had noticed.

I've felt that before.

I know exactly where I've felt that before.

Thursday dinner. I said something I was wrong about. I was ready for the correction — the polite, precise, utterly reasonable correction I have learned to brace for.

It didn't come.

"Haan, ho sakta hai." And he moved on.

I looked at him across the table and the thought came — uninvited, unwelcome, completely clear — yeh uski tarah nahi hai. Yeh kisi aur ki tarah hai.

I am being unfair. I know I'm being unfair.

He is trying. And it is working, in the way that trying always works. I feel it. I'm not made of stone.

But something sits wrong underneath the feeling. Something familiar in a way that has nothing to do with Arjun.

I don't want to finish that thought tonight.

Laptop off. Light off. — N.

INTERLUDE — Naina's Diary | April 13, 2026 | 1:13 AM

I know now.

I wish I didn't.

It was small. That's the thing. Such a small thing that cracked it open.

Arjun mentioned Rohan — carefully, gently, the way you mention something when you've been told to mention it. "Tum kabhi kabhi uske baare mein baat karti ho. Main sunna chahta hoon. Agar tum batana chahti ho."

The particular shape of that sentence made me go very still.

Not because it was wrong. Because it was too right. Too careful. Too exact. Like something constructed rather than felt.

"Tumhe kisne bataya," I said.

He didn't answer immediately. And in that half-second I already knew.

"Arjun."

"Naina—"

"Kisne bataya tumhe. Rohan ke baare mein. Gomti ke baare mein. Yeh sab."

He looked at the table.

"Maine Eklavya se baat ki thi."

He told me everything. Completely — because Arjun does not lie when he has been caught. Rohan. The Gomti. The arguments that don't matter. The chai. The shunya. Aryabhata. The equation.

I put my napkin on the table.

"Kya tum Eklavya ban rahe ho?"

He was quiet for a long time. Then — "Nahi ban sakta." Without argument. Like he had already sat with this. "Uski apni duniya hai, meri apni. Uski journey alag hai, meri alag. Tum dono ka alag alag jaana tha — tum jaanti thi yeh. Woh bhi jaanta tha."

I didn't say anything.

I am sitting here at 1 AM and Arjun is not what is keeping me awake.

What is keeping me awake is this —

Eklavya sat across from him. In a club somewhere in Gomti Nagar. And Arjun asked — and he answered. He told him about Rohan. About the Gomti. About chai and silence and what I need when I am breaking.

And what I cannot stop thinking — what is sitting in my chest like something with actual weight — is not that he shared those things.

It is that he shared them so easily.

Like they were information. Like they could be passed on. Like I was something that could be explained to someone else in an afternoon.

Kya main shunya hoon uske liye?

Kya usne kabhi ek baar bhi jaanna chahaa — main kaisi hoon? Main kya soch rahi hoon? Kya main theek hoon?

Woh jaata raha apni yatra pe. Apne Baba ke paas. Apni Sarayu ke paas. Apna shunya dhundhne. Aur mujhe — mujhe woh de diya Arjun ko. Instructions ki tarah. Jaise main ek problem thi jise solve karna tha aur woh aage nikl gaya.

Agar woh real tha — toh yeh bhi real hai?

Dono ek saath kaise real hote hain?

Kal engagement hai.

Kal sab aa jaayenge. Maa hogi. Papa honge. Arjun hoga. Flowers honge. Log honge.

Aur main wahan khadi hoongi.

Aur mujhe ek cheez jaanni hai pehle. Ek cheez. Sirf ek.

Main kal jaaungi.

Laptop off. — N.

The Crowd and the Zero April 13, 2026 — Gomti Nagar, Lucknow | 9:30 PM

The showroom had just closed.

Gomti Nagar was fully itself at this hour — cars moving fast, horns layering over each other in the distance, the April night carrying that particular heat that arrives before summer does and refuses to leave. Everything loud. Everything in motion.

I was adjusting my bag on my shoulder when I heard her footsteps behind me. Not hurried. Deliberate.

"Walk karein?"

No preamble. No file in her hand. No official reason.

I looked at her for one second. Her face was composed — the way it is when she has already decided something and is simply waiting for the rest of the world to catch up.

I nodded once.

We walked. The wide roads of Gomti Nagar — almost a kilometer, side by side, neither of us speaking. Traffic moved past us. People crossed around us, through us, indifferent. There was a weight between us that the noise couldn't touch — a silence that existed completely separately from everything surrounding it.

I was aware, with each step, that this was not a casual walk.

Then, still looking ahead, her voice came — even, controlled, the particular control of someone keeping something exactly where it is:

"Kuch poochna nahi? Kuch kehna nahi hai?"

I took one beat.

"Hum kyun chal rahe hain?"

She stopped.

The crowd kept moving around her. She turned and looked at me — and for five full seconds she just looked. Not at my face. At something she was trying to find behind it. The way you look at a room you used to know when you're trying to locate what's been moved.

Something in her eyes was not entirely composed.

Her feet looked tired. The rest of her didn't allow it.

"Kya hua," I said — the mock in my voice deliberate. A deflection. The only one I had. "Pair dard kar rahe hain? Exercise nahi karte ho kya?"

She looked at me for one long second.

"Hmm."

That was all. No smile. The "Hmm" of someone who has clocked exactly what you just did and is filing it away.

We turned back toward the showroom.

Half the distance covered. Then she stopped — no warning, no transition — just stopped, in the middle of the pavement, the city moving around her on all sides.

"Tumhe woh mil gaya."

Not a question. The voice of someone reading from something they already know.

"Jiske liye tum gaye the. 10 January ko."

My feet went still.

I turned. "Tumhe yaad hai?"

Something crossed her face. Quick. Gone. The kind of thing that crosses a face when the wrong question has been asked — when the answer is of course I remember, I remember everything, how could you not know that I remember everything.

She stepped directly in front of me. Close. The particular closeness of someone who has decided they are not moving until this is finished.

"Main mazaak nahi kar rahi." Each word separate. Quiet. The quietness of something that has been held for a long time and is now being set down very carefully so it doesn't break anything on the way.

I looked at her.

The panic strip in my pocket. The library's closed room. The Sarayu in January light. All of it there, all of it present.

"Haan." A long breath out. "Kuch mila zaroor hai. Zero. Shunya. Par Aryabhatta ka shunya — jisme sab kuch khatam bhi hota hai aur jahan se sab kuch naye sire se shuru bhi hota hai. Woh purana Eklavya... woh chala gaya."

I started to move.

"Eklavya."

No hand. No touch. Just the name — and the specific weight she has always been able to put into it when she needs it to land.

I stopped.

"Kaise mila." Underneath the evenness now — something tighter. Something that had been waiting its turn. "Itna toh bata sakte ho mujhe. Main jaanna chahti hoon — is yatra mein hum kyun mile hain."

And then, lower — almost to herself, almost not meant for me:

"Ya woh bhi Arjun ko bata diya tha tumne."

There it was.

Not loud. Not accusatory. Just — there. Dropped into the space between us like a stone into still water.

I turned back fully.

She was looking at me with those eyes — the ones that had looked at me from across a library canteen three years ago, from a tapri bench, from the other side of a phone call at 11 PM. The ones that had never once pretended.

They weren't pretending now either.

But there was something in them tonight that hadn't been there before. Not anger exactly — anger would have been easier. Something colder. The particular coldness of someone who has been waiting to be proven wrong and has just been proven right.

The parking lot in front of the showroom was empty. One streetlight burning directly above the entrance — that yellow of Lucknow nights that makes everything look like an old photograph.

I walked to it. Sat down on the pavement beneath it.

After a moment, she sat too. Not close. The cold of the stone coming through immediately. The city's noise still fully there — but somewhere I couldn't reach it from.

She was looking at me. Waiting. The waiting of someone who has already paid a price to be here and intends to get what they came for.

I took a long breath.

And then, in that circle of yellow light, I began.

(Monologue — Eklavya)

यह लो — Chapter 26 से 29 तक के **definitive fixed versions**। हर **feedback incorporated**। एक भी **placeholder** नहीं।

CHAPTER 26

Pavement

April 13, 2026 — Raat

The pavement was cold.

She was sitting two feet away. Not as the owner. Not with the professional distance. Just her.

The streetlight above us. That yellow.

"10 January ke baad," I said.

"Bhaiya ka ghar Mahanagar mein tha. Rent pe. Tumhare ghar se do minute."

She said nothing.

"Woh ghar chhootna pada. Bhaiya ne apna liya — Gomti Nagar. Unka faisla tha. Sahi tha. Main saath aa gaya."

"Mahanagar chhoot gaya."

"Haan."

"Library chhoot gayi."

"Haan."

"Tapri chhoot gayi."

The third one she said differently.

"Haan. Sab kuch ek saath."

"Vinay Khand. Nayi library. Koi nahi jaanta tha mujhe wahan."

"Seat 64. Corner. Wall side. Roz wahi."

"Kitne baje?"

"7:30 se 9:30. Roz."

"Kitne mahine?"

"Saat."

She let the number sit.

"Philosophy band kar di. Krishnamurti. Osho. Sab. Woh tab chahiye nahi tha. Shant karne wala nahi chahiye tha. Ek result chahiye tha. Adrenaline chahiye tha. David Goggins follow kiya. Extreme tha. Par ek cheez sahi thi — jab sab kuch bahar se tod raha ho, khud ko khud bachao. Koi nahi aata."

"Jaante the ki itna push kar rahe the?"

"Haan."

"Aur phir bhi."

"Tab wohi tha."

"Sivi ka status aaya. March 2025. CGL. Selection."

She went still.

"Congratulations likha. Blue tick ho gaya. Reply nahi aaya."

Silence.

"Shayad zaroorat nahi lagi. Woh bhi apne Papa ke liye kar rahi thi. Yeh ek cheez samajh aati thi."

She said — quietly:

"Teen baar poochha tha tumne. Alag alag dinon mein. 'Kya hoga uska?' Main sun rahi thi. Jo tum bol rahe the. Jo nahi bol rahe the. Dono."

A pause.

"Chahti thi kuch karna. Par tum jitna zaroori hota, utna hi bolta tha. Kyun."

"Khaali haath se kya deta."

One second.

She turned and looked at me. Fully. First time since sitting down.

Not because of what I had said.

Because of where she had heard it before.

"August mein answer keys aane lagin. Ek ek. Pehle se andaaza ho jaata tha — kitne sahi. Official baad mein aata. Sab theek ja rahe the."

"Kitne?"

"Kaafi."

"October tak mains ki dates aa gayi thin. Pehli baar sab ek direction mein. Routine sahi thi. Papers sahi ja rahe the."

A pause.

"Fark zyada nahi padta tha. Itne saalon mein dil ne ek taraf se band kar liya tha. Result aata — theek hota — agli taiyari. Agli date. Bas."

"Par ek cheez thi. Pehli baar laga — shayad ho jaega. Bas itna."

"Abhinay Sir ka ek video tha. July 28. CGL complex ke bahar. Bola — ek bachcha teen teen saal taiyari karta hai. Sarkaar chunaav mein uska kaat de rahi hai."

"Pehle police officer tha. Badge chhoda. Chalk uthaya. July 31 — DOPT ke bahar. Bola — jawabdehi tay nahi hogi toh sudhar nahi hoga."

"Tum wahan the?"

"August 24 ko."

"Bhaiya ko nahi bataya."

She looked at me.

"Raat ki train. General coach. ₹180. Standing."

"Akele."

"Haan."

"Ramlila Maidan. 5,000 se zyada log. Stage. Dhoop."

"Abhinay Sir ne kaha — yeh ladaai satta hatane ki nahi. Satta jagane ki hai. Ya sapne bechna band karo — ya is haal pe mat chhodo."

"Jab itne log ek saath chillate hain—"

I stopped.

"Chest mein feel hota hai. Sound wave nahi. Kuch aur. Teen saal akele library. Akele result. Akele. Aur tab — pehli baar — itne log. Ek hi cheez ke liye."

She was looking at me. Not pity. Recognition.

"Raat 8 baje police aayi."

My hand went to my right shoulder. Old reflex.

She clocked it. She always clocked everything.

Her jaw tightened — one degree. Not anger. The tightness of someone who has just understood something they would have preferred not to.

"Lathi lagi. Aman Bhaiya ne bahar nikala. Hotel. ₹850."

"Tum akele the. Hotel mein bhi."

"Haan."

"Bhaiya ko kya bataya?"

"Theek hoon. Kal aata hoon."

She closed her eyes. One second.

When she opened them — something had shifted. That deep anger still there. Par underneath it — woh specific exhaustion. Kisi ke baare mein chinta karna jo jaanta hi nahi tha ki uski chinta ho rahi thi.

"Aage," she said.

"October 13 — NTPC Graduation Level. Pehla mains."

"Sab set tha."

She was still.

"5 October."

The date landed.

She looked at me. Waiting.

"Us din subah tak sab theek tha. Seat 64. Books. Set tha."

I stopped.

The streetlight. The city.

"5 October ko kuch hua."

She didn't ask what.

Then — quietly:

"Shivi ko pata tha?"

I looked at her.

She wasn't looking at me. She was looking at the pavement.

"Haan."

One second.

"Woh tumhare paas thi?"

"Nahi. Par thi."

She didn't ask what that meant. She understood — Shivi had always been the kind of person who didn't need to be in the room to be present. She existed on the other end of a phone that you could open or not open — and either way, she would still be there.

"Usne kya kiya?"

"Kuch nahi. Bas — tha woh. Available. Bina demand ke."

She was quiet.

"Tumhe usse zyada chahiye tha?"

"Nahi."

"Toh?"

"Woh jaanti thi kab nahi poochna. Yeh bahut rare hota hai."

She turned and looked at the street.

That jaw. One degree.

Something else. The specific tightness of someone who has just been shown — very precisely — the one thing they could never do.

She had heard enough to know I would tell her everything.

And that whatever 5 October was — it had changed everything that came after.

Including this pavement. This night. This two feet.

She was sitting very still. The way she sat when something had landed too close to home and she needed a moment before deciding what to do with it.

CHAPTER 27

5 October

October 2025 — Lucknow / Gorakhpur

Normal din tha. Wahi routine. Seat 64, corner, wall side.

October 13 — NTPC Mains. Gorakhpur center. Pata chal gaya tha pehle hi. Preparation sahi chal rahi thi. Har cheez apni jagah thi.

Dopahar mein khana khaaya. Wapas library.

3:43.

Thodi neend si aa rahi thi. Socha — CGL court case ki latest update dekh lete hain. YouTube pe ek advocate tha — Hindi mein samjhaata tha, thoda English. Fil pad leta tha. Uski ek nayi video aayi thi. Play kiya.

Tab hua.

Seene mein kuch utha. Achanak. Bina kisi warning ke.

Aankhein blur hone lagin. Screen pe woh advocate bol raha tha kuch — words aa rahe the, meaning nahi. Headphones ek taraf gir gaye. Itna tez pehle kabhi nahi hua tha.

Ek hi thought aaya, seedha —

Shayad main mar raha hoon.

Ek minute. Shayad ek minute tha pura.

Puri family samne aa gayi bina bulaaye. Bhaiya. Bhabhi. Pihu. Mummy. Papa. Ek ek chehra. Jaise koi file khul gayi ho jo band thi.

Seene ki dard badh rahi thi. Saans khinch raha tha — jor se. Par aa nahi rahi thin.

Agla pal nahi rahega.

Yeh thought aaya. Aur ruk gaya andar. Apni jagah bana li usne.

Kitabein wahin rahein. Bag wahin raha.

Sirf mobile uthaya.

Samajh nahi aaya kisi ko kya batana tha — bas ek cheez thi, ek hi direction tha. Hospital pahunchna. Jitni jaldi ho sake.

Library se bahar aaya. Road thi. Parking thi. Saamne park tha.

Saans khinchi ek baar aur — jor se.

Bike start ki.

Beech mein ek pal laga — gir jaunga. Par pahuncha.

MNS hospital. Emergency.

Doctor aaye. Pehle kaha — parcha banao.

Tab majak nahi laga tha.

Parcha bana. BP check kiya. ECG kiya. Sab normal.

Machine sahi bata rahi thi — unhe laga. Mujhe normal nahi lag raha tha. Par machine ke aage koi argument nahi hota.

Basic dawaai di. Chakkar ki. Ghar jaao.

She hadn't moved.

Woh wahan thi — same two feet, same pavement, same streetlight. Par kuch shift hua tha usmein. Controlled anger abhi bhi thi, andar. Par upar — woh specific stillness jo tab aati hai jab koi sun raha ho aur saans rokna pad raha ho.

Ghar aaya.

Bhaiya ne dekha. Kuch samjha. Poochha — kyun nahi bataya pehle.

"Handle kar sakta tha."

Woh chup raha. Ek din baad — Sunday — wapas hospital. ECG. Normal.

Doosra physician. Triptomer suggest kiya. Paanch din li. Khaane ke baad thoda aaram milta tha. Kuch ghante. Phir wahi.

Par paper 13 ko tha. Gorakhpur.

Jaana tha toh jaana tha.

Cardio ko dikhaya.

Wahan bhi ECG normal thi. Kuch dawaaiyaan badlin. Ek cheez clear hui — heart attack nahi tha.

Woh chhoti si rahat thi. Par thi.

Pehli library mein — Kapoorthala wali — ek ladka tha. Chehra yaad tha, naam nahi. Bahut padhta tha. Job bhi mil gayi thi usse.

Phir ek din uske group mein khabar aayi — heart attack. Woh nahi raha.

Woh chehra baar baar aata tha. Back of the mind mein. Hamesha.

Gorakhpur jaate waqt bhi wahi tha.

Train mein — general coach — ek baar socha tha.

Shayad government job nahi karni chahiye aage.

Pehli baar yeh thought itna seedha aaya tha. Bina lad ke. Bina rok ke.

Par paper dena tha. Toh diya.

Gorakhpur. Chhota sa room. Dawaai khayi. Neend ki bhi ek thi. So gaya.

Subah paper.

Beech mein bhi wahi cheezein thin — utni nahi, par thin. Do minute ruka. Saans dekha. Wahi jo pehle karta tha — saans ko sirf dekhna. Usi mein raha.

Khatam kiya paper.

Theek nahi gaya tha. Par diya. Yahi tha.

Wapas Lucknow. Diwali. Ayodhya — 20 October. Sab log gaye.

Ghar ki woh zameen. Woh khamoshi jo alag hoti hai — purani, gehri.

Thoda aaram tha. Par bheed mein — market, mela, logon ke beech — wahi dard uthta tha. Padh nahi pa raha tha. Bilkul nahi.

22 October. Wapas Lucknow. Bhaiya ke saath gaadi mein.

Cardio ne ek baar kaha tha — agar aaram na mile toh psychiatric ko dikhana.

Dikhaya.

Wahan sab cheezein apni jagah aayin. Dawaaiyaan shuru huin. Jo ab bhi chal rahi hain.

Main chup hua.

Pata nahi kitni der se bol raha tha. Bahar ka koi hisaab nahi tha.

Toh main ruk gaya.

Gomti Nagar apni speed mein chal raha tha. Cars. Horns. Koi group hassta hua nikla paidal. Heritage Threads ka board upar tha — showroom band, lights off, glass mein road ka reflection.

Sab kuch waisa hi tha jaise ek ghante pehle tha.

Sirf yeh pavement alag thi.

Usne kuch nahi kaha.

Koi sawaal nahi. Koi response nahi.

City apni speed mein thi.

Phir — bina dekhe, bina bataye — uska haath mere haath pe aaya. Slowly. The way she had done once before, on concrete steps by the Gomti, when the sun was going down and she had said main tumhe ab kabhi nahi chhodungi.

Woh wala haath nahi tha.

Yeh wala alag tha. Heavier. The hand of someone who has just heard something they cannot unhear, and has no words for it, and is not trying to find any.

Woh sirf wahan thi.

Main sirf wahan tha.

Upar streetlight wahi. Road wahi. City wahi.

Par woh do ghante — ya teen, ya jitne bhi the — sirf humare the. Woh hisaab alag tha. Woh ghadi kisi aur speed pe chal rahi thi.

Kitni der baad, pata nahi —

"November mein Baba ke paas gaya tha," maine kaha. Slowly. "Kusumpur. Sarayu ke paas."

Uska haath nahi hata.

"Woh darwaza jo hamesha khula tha — is baar andar gaya."

She was looking straight ahead now. At the road. At nothing specific.

"Woh alag chapter hai," maine kaha. "Woh alag se sunana padega."

She nodded. Once. Barely.

Par haath wahi raha.

CHAPTER 28

15 Din

November 25 — December 10, 2025 | Kusumpur

April 13, 2026 | Lucknow

Her hand was still on mine.

The city kept going — cars, horns, someone's music from somewhere above. Gomti Nagar doing exactly what it always did. But that pavement, that specific rectangle of cold stone under the Heritage Threads sign, existed at a different speed from the rest of it.

I looked at the road.

"November mein gaya tha. Kusumpur. Ghar."

She didn't say anything. Her thumb moved — barely, once — against the back of my hand. Not a response. Just: I'm here. Keep going.

"Bus stand se rickshaw li. November ki thandi. Wahi gali. Papa ki dukaan door se dikhi — aur pair zameen pe rakhne se pehle, chest tight hua."

"Wahan bhi?" she asked.

"Haan. Wahan bhi."

She closed her eyes. One second.

"Breathing kari. Four in, hold, four out. Do baar. Thoda loosen hua. Ghar ki taraf badha. Mummy darwaze pe thi. Unhone mujhe dekha — ek second ruk gayin. Phir seedha andar le gayin. Dal, roti, aloo ki sabzi. Khaana. Koi sawaal nahi."

Something in her exhaled — not quite a sigh. Smaller than that. The sound of someone releasing a breath they had been holding without knowing it.

"Raat ko Papa aaye. TV on ki. News dekhi. Dus minute baad — bina meri taraf dekhe — bola: 'Kal dukaan pe aa jaana. Baitho thodi der.'"

"Bas itna?"

"Bas itna."

She nodded slowly. She understood — some fathers were built entirely from silences that meant everything.

"Doosre din dukaan pe gaya. Teen ghante sirf baitha. Customers aaye, gaye. Papa ne kaam kiya — billing, weighing, hisaab. Bina kuch poochhe mujhse. Ek aunty ne poochha — 'Padhai ho gayi?' Papa ne kaha — 'Chal rahi hai.' Meri taraf nahi dekha."

"Par?" she said. She knew there was one.

"Par ek chhota sa nod diya. Bas itna."

She looked down at our hands.

"Dopahar wapas jaate waqt — raaste mein — bola: 'Bahut paas ho. Ek baar aur.' Aur chalte rahe. Peeche nahi dekha."

A silence.

"Woh line ruk gayi andar," I said. "Bahut lambe waqt tak."

She didn't fill it.

"Teesre din Baba ke paas gaya."

"Andar gaye?" she asked — quietly, specifically.

"Haan. Is baar gaya."

Something shifted in her face. Small. Real.

"Gate pe khada tha — pair nahi uth raha tha. Baba ki kutiya hai — hamesha khuli rehti hai, hamesha jaanta tha. Par aaj kuch alag tha. Breathing kari. Phir andar gaya. Baba charkha chala rahe the. Unhone mujhe dekha — charkha nahi ruka. Aa gaya beta. Baith ja. Pandra minute charkha chalta raha. Phir band kiya. Mere paas aaye — zameen pe, mere level pe. Haath kandhe pe rakha."

Kaisa hai?

I stopped for a moment.

Theek nahi hoon Baba.

Her hand tightened — once, briefly — on mine.

"Pehli baar kisi se sach bola. Without any wrapper. Seedha."

Pata hai, unhone kaha.

She looked at me. "Unhe pata tha?"

"Chhote gaon mein kuch chhupa nahi rehta."

"Agli subah 6 baje Sarayu gaye. Fog wali roshni thi. Kinare zameen pe baithe."

Aankhein band kar. Saans. Bas saans.

"Pehle minute mein — chest tight. Haath mutthi mein band. 'Baba — nahi ho raha.' Unhone kaha — Hone de. Jo bhi ho raha hai — rokna mat. Unka haath kandhe pe tha. Woh nahi hile. Koi baat nahi. Koi fix nahi. Bas wahan the."

"Roz gaye. 15 din."

She looked at me. "Roz?"

"Roz."

She turned away. Jaw set. The anger still there — that deep one — but its shape had changed. It wasn't at me. It was at something larger. At all those mornings.

"Chhathe din Baba se poochha — yeh panic kyun aaya? Maine kya galat kiya?"

Kuch galat nahi kiya. Body ne signal diya — ab aur nahi chal sakta iss tarah.

Kis tarah?

Barah ghante padhai. Har emotion block. Khud ko force karte rehna. Survive karna.

She said it — quietly, almost to herself: "Survive karna aur jeena."

"Haan. Baba ne kaha — dono alag hain."

She closed her eyes. Long. When she opened them, something was different — not softer. Just open. One layer gone.

"Phir — aathvein din — maine kaha: 'Baba, main aap jaisa banna chahta hoon.' Unhone kaha — Tujhe meri tarah nahi banna. Tujhe apni tarah banna hai. Maine poochha — 'Par main kaun hoon?'"

"Unhone ek sookhi patti uthaayi — bargad ki. Meri hatheli pe rakhi. Agar yeh patti sochti — main bargad jaisa banna chahti hoon — toh woh apni yatra bhool jaati. Tujhe apna swaroop khud dhundhna hoga."

"Nauvaan din Sarayu pe Baba ne kaha — Mahabharat mein Eklavya ne sab kuch de diya. Guru ne liya. Society ne liya. Angootha maanga — usne de diya. Poori zindagi doosron ne define ki."

The streetlight above us. The board behind us.

Tum woh Eklavya nahi ho. Tum kisi ke liye kuch prove karne ke liye nahi ho. Tum bas Eklavya ho — jahan ho, us waqt ho, khud mein poore ho.

She turned and looked at me fully. That look — the one that arrived before she decided to let it.

"Tumhe pata tha?" she asked. "Ki tum prove kar rahe the — kisi ke liye?"

"Tab nahi. Wahan samjha."

"Gyaarahvaan din Karan se mila. Chai pe."

Karan — bachpan se. Woh jo 2009 mein Sarayu ke kinare mere paas khada tha jab Vinay nahi aaya tha.

"Bola — 'Tum ho nahi jo ban rahe ho. Career mein bhi, rishte mein bhi. Dono ek saath nahi hote. Ek din choose karna padega.'"

"Sach tha," I said. "Jaanta tha. Accept nahi kiya tha bas."

"Uske baad Viram ka idea aaya."

"Kahan se?" she asked.

"2009 se. Vinay. Woh Sarayu mein gaya — wapas nahi aaya. Main kinare khada raha. Tab se ek cheez thi andar — kuch banana chahta tha. Usi jagah ke paas. Kuch aisa jo dikhe. Jo rahe. 2016 mein Karan ke Papa ko stroke aaya. Unki ek tapri thi. Jab woh gaye, tapri band ho gayi. Humne milke use modern kiya. Proper stall. Naam rakha — Chai Pe Charcha. Teen saal chali. Jo kamaya — ussi se 2019 mein Ayodhya mein café khola. Pehli baar kuch apna tha. Phir 2020 mein band ho gaya. Lockdown. Shutter gira."

She said — very quietly: "Woh pehla seal tha."

I looked at her. She had said it before I could.

"Haan," I said. "Woh pehla seal tha. Par jab duba — tab samjha. Jo shanti main bahar dhundh raha tha — woh wahan thi hi nahi. Shunya mil gaya tha. Aur wahan se — Viram ka idea aaya."

"Chaudahvaan din — last meditation. 30 minute. Poore. Koi chest tight nahi. Koi darr nahi. Bas khamoshi."

Kya mila?

Darr se bhaagna band ho gaya.

Aur?

Samjha — body ne rok diya kyunki galat direction mein bhaag raha tha.

Aur ab?

Agli step leni hai.

"Unka haath kandhe pe aaya. Tu ready hai. Phir — wapas jaane se pehle — ek cheez kahi."

She was looking at me now.

"Aryabhatta ne shunya banaya. Log sochte hain — shunya matlab khaali. Khatam. Kuch nahi. Par Baba ne kaha — Shunya wahan se shuru hota hai jahan sab kuch khatam hota hai. Aur wahan se sab kuch naya shuru bhi hota hai. Zero ek ant nahi — zero ek naya aarambh hai."

The streetlight. The city.

"Terhavaan din raat ko akela Sarayu gaya. Baba ki kutiya door se dikhi. Diya jal raha tha. Main bahar khada raha. Andar nahi gaya."

"Kyun nahi?" she asked.

"Kabhi nahi jaata andar. Yeh meri yatra hai — mujhe khud chalani hai. Par aata hoon yahan tak. Hamesha."

She looked at the water.

Uske haath ki grip — ek second ke liye — thodi tight hui. Phir wapas wahi. Steady.

"Wahan khade khade yaad aaye — 2004, chawal ka daana, Tu ek bargad banne aaya hai. 2009, Vinay, kinare khada raha, Baba ke paas gaya, kuch nahi bola unhone — bas baith gaye, pandra minute, khamoshi, phir — Maut das saal ke bacche ke rokne se nahi rukti. 2016, gusse mein gaya tha, Baba ne kaha — Ja, apni yatra shuru kar, jab thak jaaye — laut aana, yeh darwaza hamesha khula hai."

"November 2025."

I looked at the road.

"Aaya tha. Thak ke. Darwaza khula tha."

Her hand. Still there.

Kitni der baad — pata nahi.

She looked up at the Heritage Threads sign. Then at the road. Then at her watch.

"1:47 ho gaye."

Neither of us moved for a moment.

Then she stood up. Slowly. The way you stand when your body has been still for a long time and it remembers itself in parts.

I stood too.

She looked at the bike. Then at me.

"Chhod doge?"

Gomti Nagar se Gomti tak — raat mein — woh roads alag hoti hain. Khaali. Sirf streetlights aur occasionally a late auto. The city breathing differently at this hour. Slower. Deeper.

She sat behind me on the bike.

Woh apne haath mere kaandhon pe rakh sakti thi. Usne nahi rakhe. Par thi wahan. Itna kaafi tha.

Raaste mein koi baat nahi hui. The wind was enough.

Riverfront. 2:00 AM.

Concrete steps. The Gomti below — dark, moving, indifferent to whoever sat on its banks. It always had been.

We sat. The same steps where she had once held my hand and said main tumhe ab kabhi nahi chhodungi. Neither of us chose this spot consciously. Feet just knew.

The water kept moving.

Lucknow at 2 AM was almost quiet. Almost.

Uska phone bajaa.

Usne screen dekhi. Kuch nahi bola. Screen band ho gayi.

Phir se bajaa.

Usne phone palti karke rakh diya — screen zameen ki taraf.

Khamoshi.

Gomti aage badhti rahi.

Maine kuch nahi poocha. Usne kuch nahi bataya.

Woh wahan thi — sirf wahan. Is waqt. Is kinare. Is raat mein.

Phone phir bajaa. Baar baar. Woh nahi hili.

Paani ki awaaz. Kahin door ek aakhri auto. April ki raat ki woh specific thandi jo sirf nadiyaan deti hain.

Hum dono bas wahan the.

CHAPTER 29

The Anchor

April 14, 2026 — 2:15 AM | Gomti Riverfront to Mahanagar

The river kept moving.

Kitni der wahan baithe — pata nahi. Koi reason nahi tha uthne ka. Koi reason nahi tha rukne ka. Bas woh specific weight thi jo tab hoti hai jab koi story complete ho jaati hai aur uske baad kya — abhi nahi pata.

Finally she looked at her watch.

"2:15."

I stood. She stood.

Her SUV Heritage Threads ke bahar thi. We walked back. I handed her the spare helmet. She looked at it for a second — the way someone looks at something ordinary that has suddenly become significant — then put it on.

She sat behind me on the bike.

Gomti Nagar se Mahanagar. Empty roads. The city at this hour belonged to a different set of people — watchmen, bakers, truck drivers, insomniacs. We passed through their city quietly.

Koi baat nahi hui. The wind was enough. It always had been.

I stopped the bike outside the white gate.

Porch lights on. The house decorated — strings of marigold on the gate, on the pillars. Engagement. Subah.

She handed the helmet back. Stood on the pavement.

Looked at the house. Then at me.

"Tumhe tumhara shunya Kusumpur mein mil gaya. Mera shunya kahan hai?"

I looked at her.

The marigolds. The light.

"2023 wali entries. Jo tumne likha. Jo tumne nahi likha. Dono."

She looked at me.

"Woh diary mere paas hai."

One second.

"Jaanti hoon," she said.

Neither of us said anything else.

"Kal showroom mein hoon," I said. "10 baje."

I put the helmet on. Started the engine.

She was still standing at the gate when I turned at the signal.

I didn't look back.

Bhaiya ka ghar. Andhere mein. Passage light on thi — Bhabhi hamesha chhodti thi.

Main andar gaya. Apna kamra. Desk.

Woh diary wahin thi. Jaisi thi. 14 mahine.

Maine usse haath nahi lagaya.

Mat folded. Fan on low.

Saans. Bas saans.

Neend nahi aayi jaldi. Par aayi.

INTERLUDE VII

Naina's Diary

April 14, 2026 | 4:47 AM

Maa ke kamre se aayi hoon. Kitni der thi wahan — pata nahi.

Unhone Rohan ki ek baat batayi. 2018 ki. Jo unhone tab nahi boli thi.

"Didi akeli rehti hai. Sabke beech mein bhi. Akela aadmi woh nahi hota jo ghar mein baith kar rota hai. Akela aadmi woh hota hai jo bheed mein sab sambhalta hai aur andar se — khaali hota hai."

Woh dekh sakta tha. Mujhe bhi. Jab main khud nahi dekh paati thi.

Woh diary uske paas hai.

Maine di thi. January 2025. Seedha uske haath mein.

Usne 14 mahine nahi kholee. Mujhe pata hai — woh aisa hi hai. Kuch cheezein sirf rakhta hai. Sambhal ke. Bina dekhe.

Aaj usne kaha — "2023 wali entries padho."

Matlab — woh laaega. Ya main jaaungi.

Kal 10 baje showroom mein hoga.

Subah engagement hai.

Arjun bura nahi hai. Yeh sach hai.

Par ek aur cheez bhi sach hai —

Arjun mere saath khush rahega. Main Arjun ke saath perform karti rahungi.

Survive karna aur jeena. Dono alag hain.

Yeh line usne nahi kahi. Baba ne kahi thi. Usne sirf sunaya mujhe.

Par ab yeh meri hai.

Marigold bahar lage hain. Bahut sundar hain. Yeh bhi sach hai

Subah hone wali hai

— N.

CHAPTER 30

The Khubsurat Mystery

April 14, 2026 — Lucknow

Bhaiya ka bag counter ke paas tha.

ID card. Tiffin. Keys already haath mein. The particular efficiency of a man who has done this same sequence so many times that his hands no longer need instructions from his brain.

"Nikal raha hoon," he said to the room generally.

From the kitchen, Bhabhi's voice: "Haan."

The door clicked shut.

Pihu was on the carpet in the living room. She had her Ram Lala toy in one hand and was examining its left ear with the focused seriousness of someone conducting a structural audit. The ear had passed inspection yesterday. Today it was being re-evaluated.

I sat down on the floor beside her.

She didn't look up. She turned the toy slightly — better angle. Pressed the ear once. Released. Pressed again.

I leaned forward until my face was close to hers. Nose almost at her nose.

She looked up.

Found my face two inches from hers.

A pause. Then she scrunched her nose.

I scrunched mine back.

She stared. Then — slowly — the corners of her mouth went up. That smile. The small one that takes its time arriving and means everything when it does.

I tapped her nose once.

She made a sound — somewhere between a laugh and a breath — and pushed the toy at my face.

"Haan," I said. "Good morning to you too."

She pulled the toy back and went back to the ear.

"Kal raat dost ke paas tha," I told her, my voice casual, letting the words just exist in the morning air. "Kaafi der ho gayi aane mein."

Pihu pressed the toy's ear.

"Pata hai, maine kal apne bohot se secrets kisi ko bataye." I kept my eyes on her hands. "Kyun bataya? Mujhe bhi nahi pata. Bas bata diya."

A pause. The April morning light lay across the carpet in a warm strip.

"Aaj uski engagement hai," I said, my voice dropping slightly. "Kya karna chahiye use? Mujhe nahi pata. Bas... mujhe us pal laga ki woh sach mein janna chahti hai. Aur mujhe bhi zaroorat thi ki main sab kuch bata doon. Jo hai. Jo nahi hai. Us moment mein bas uske paas rehne ki."

Pihu suddenly turned and held the Ram Lala toy directly out toward me. Full extension. Eyes very serious.

I took it carefully with both hands. Examined it. Left ear, right ear, base.

"Sab theek hai," I told her.

She took it back immediately. Satisfied.

I sat there another minute, watched her play, then picked up my bag and left for the showroom.

The shutter was already up when I arrived.

Blue rack. First round. Tag. Fold. Space.

At eleven, the black SUV stopped outside.

I kept folding. I expected bridal wear, or at least the heavy aura of a girl whose house is currently filled with marigolds and relatives.

She stepped out.

A simple rust-orange kurti. Jeans. Sunglasses pushed up into her hair. No makeup. The driver pulled away.

She walked in. Completely normal.

Suresh held the door. She nodded to him, walked past the center island, and didn't even look toward Rajesh Sir's cabin first. She walked straight to the blue rack.

And then, before I could say it:

"Good morning, Eklavya."

No hesitation. No darting of the eyes to check who was watching. The fear of 'log kya kahenge' or 'kya main isey kho dungi' was completely gone from her face.

"Good morning."

She touched the edge of a deep teal kurta on my rack. "Folds behtar hain aaj."

Not a Boss's observation. Just a conversation starter.

"Dhyan rakha hai," I said.

She smiled. A real, quiet smile. Then she walked to the cabin.

At one-thirty, I took my tiffin to the pantry.

Small room at the back. Two shelves with water jars. A low counter. I opened my tiffin. Roti, sabzi, salad, and a small box of kheer.

I had just taken the first bite when the door opened.

Naina walked in. Empty-handed.

She pulled up the stool across from me, sat down, and without asking, picked up a piece of cucumber from my salad container.

"Tum apna nahi layi?" I asked.

"Layi hi nahi." She broke a piece of my roti, dipped it in the sabzi, and ate it. Smoothly. Naturally. Like she had been doing it every day.

The door opened again. Anshika walked in, holding her plastic hostel dabba.

She stopped, saw Naina eating from my box, saw me letting her, and raised an eyebrow.

"Ma'am, aap bhi yahan?" Anshika sat on the edge of the counter, opening her dabba—some questionable yellow dal and rice. "Sahi hai. Mera hostel ka khana dekhne se hi depression hota hai. Main bhi share kar rahi hoon, bro."

Anshika pulled my kheer container slightly toward herself.

"Bro, ek baat batao," Anshika looked at me, her spoon pointing at my face. "Us din Ma'am ne jo tumhari DP lagwayi thi, uspe almost 100 likes aa gaye hain. Kal showroom wali selfie pe bhi tum tag the. Tumne notification check kiye?"

"Nahi."

"Log comments mein pooch rahe hain ki yeh intense look wala naya ladka kaun hai, aur tumne app khol kar bhi nahi dekha!" Anshika complained. "Tum kis pathar ke neeche rehte ho bro?"

Naina chuckled, taking another piece of my cucumber. "Main bata rahi hoon Anshika, iska update system 2018 mein hi ruk gaya tha."

"Wahi toh!" Anshika sighed. "Hum yahan filter pe filter lagate hain, update pe update check karte hain, aur inka alag hi sanyaas chal raha hai."

"Mera kaam filters lagana nahi hai," I said, pulling the kheer back to the center so all three could reach it.

Naina leaned back against the wall, crossing her arms loosely. She looked at Anshika, but there was a mischievous glint in her eye.

"Anshika, tumhe pata hai iski ek dost thi pehle? Sivi." Naina casually dropped the name. "Library mein saath the yeh dono. Uske saath iska ek alag hi, bohot open version tha."

Anshika's eyes lit up. Pure gossip mode. "Sachi? Matlab, Eklavya bro ka ek non-boring version bhi exist karta hai? Kaisi thi wo? Aapki kya bonding thi uske saath bro?"

I looked at Naina. She was watching me. Her eyes were playful, but underneath, there was a genuine, quiet waiting. She was using Anshika to ask the question she couldn't ask directly.

I picked up my spoon.

"Natural thi," I said simply. "Koi boundary nahi thi. Koi limitation nahi thi."

"Boundary nahi matlab?" Anshika asked, eating a spoonful of kheer.

"Matlab hum dono us pal mein the. Aage kya hoga, expectations kya hain, log kya kahenge... woh sab nahi tha. Jarurat thi dono ko wahan hone ki, toh the. Jab tak the, bas wahan the."

Anshika stopped eating. She looked at me, then at Naina.

"Bro," Anshika said, shaking her head. "Aap na ek Netflix mystery series ki tarah ho. Trailer itna tagda chalta hai, main roz dekhti hoon... par aage ka episode kabhi aata hi nahi. Suspense mein hi maar doge."

Naina laughed softly. She looked at me, her gaze lingering just a second longer than normal.

"Mystery toh hai," Naina said, her voice dropping a fraction, just enough for me to hear the shift in tone. "Par yeh aisi mystery hai jise ahista ahista solve karne mein maza aata hai. Khubsurat hai."

Anshika rolled her eyes. "Aap logo ki philosophical baatein mere hostel ke dimaag ke upar se jaa rahi hain. Kheer achhi thi waise."

Anshika packed her plastic dabba and hopped off the counter. "Main floor pe jaa rahi hoon. Aap log apni khubsurat mystery solve karo."

The door clicked shut.

It was just the two of us.

She didn't say anything immediately. She just took the last piece of cucumber from my box.

"Kal Wednesday hai," she said. Not looking at me.

"Haan. Showroom band rahega. Pura din chhutti."

"Main Pihu se milne aaungi."

I looked at her.

"Aise hi," she added. "Bas milne."

She stood up, patted my shoulder lightly—a gesture so natural I barely registered the touch until her hand was gone—and walked out.

INTERLUDE VIII

Naina's Diary

April 14, 2026 — Late Night

I went to Arjun's house this morning.

He was in his study, packing some files. He saw me at the door, saw my face, and before I could say a word, he smiled. A very tired, very knowing smile.

"Tum sach mein Eklavya ban sakti ho?" he asked quietly.

"Nahi," I said. "Aur tum bhi nahi ban sakte. Main hamesha ek performance deti rahungi, aur tum hamesha us ek insaan se compete karte rahoge jo race mein hai hi nahi. Eklavya hamesha se meri duniya ka part tha, aur rahega. Uske bagair main poori nahi hoon."

Arjun just nodded. He didn't argue. He is too smart, too logical to fight for a losing trade.

"Mujhe pata tha," he told me. "Main kal raat hi samajh gaya tha jab tumne sach bola. Goldman Sachs ka jo offer hai London ka, main accept kar raha hoon. As an investor, main Heritage Threads mein rahunga. Ek dost ki tarah."

It ended just like that. No drama. No tears. He has his world, and he will conquer it. He was just trying to win the wrong game here.

When I came back home, Maa was in the kitchen. I told her the engagement is off.

She didn't gasp. She didn't scold me. She just stopped what she was doing, walked over, and held my hand tightly. Just that. It was enough.

Papa found out an hour later. We still don't talk face-to-face. I am the one who keeps the distance, the anger from the past still sitting somewhere inside me. He didn't come to my room. My phone buzzed instead.

"Your life. Your decision. I respect it."

He tries, in his own awkward way. I'm the one who doesn't know how to bridge that gap yet.

In the afternoon, I went to the showroom. I went to him.

I crashed his lunch. I ate his food. Anshika was there, calling him 'bro' and teasing him about the Instagram photo I made him upload. The whole thing was so... light. So incredibly normal.

I brought up Sivi. I used Anshika to ask him how he was with her.

He said: "Koi boundary nahi thi. Jab the, toh bas the."

And suddenly, every mistake I ever made with him over the last three years made sense.

He has my old diary from 2023. I can't read those pages physically anymore, but I don't need to. I remember every plan I wrote in it. The cafes in Koramangala. The trips

to the mountains. The books I would make him read. I was always trying to drag him into my world.

I was wrong. You can't put boundaries and plans on someone who breathes freely only when he is let go.

I don't need to drag him into my world.

Main uski duniya mein jaaungi. Bina us par bojh daale. Bas dekhungi ki uski duniya kaisi hai.

Anshika called him a Netflix mystery today. I told her it's a beautiful one.

Because it is.

Kal Wednesday hai. Showroom band rehta hai.

Main Pihu se milne uske ghar jaungi. Ek 'Owner Ma'am' ki tarah nahi. Ek dost ki tarah. Ek aam insaan ki tarah.

Let's see what happens when there are no boundaries.

— N.

CHAPTER 31

The Weight of Water

April 15, 2026 — Lucknow

Wednesday. The showroom was closed.

It was just past two in the afternoon. Bhabhi was in the kitchen. I was lying on my back on the living room carpet.

Pihu was resting on my chest and stomach, completely still, like something delicate that had found the right place to settle. She liked sleeping on people this way. Her small, light weight pressed into me with a warmth that asked for nothing. She breathed slowly, rising and falling with my chest.

She had her Ram Lala toy in one hand. She kept bringing it close to my face, then suddenly pressing her small mouth against my cheek. Her new teeth. Her wet lips. A clumsy, uncoordinated baby kiss. She didn't know what it meant, but she liked the contact. She would press her mouth and teeth against my face, make a small happy sound, and then put her head back down on my chest. The pleasure was entirely hers. The warmth was entirely mine.

I placed both hands on her small back, steadying her.

The doorbell rang.

Bhabhi came out of the kitchen and opened the door.

Naina was standing there. Faded blue jeans. An oversized white shirt, sleeves folded to the elbow. No sunglasses. No sharp manager's look.

She stepped inside. Her footsteps stopped.

She was looking at the carpet. At Pihu lying on my chest without any fear, pressing her mouth against my face every few minutes. Something settled in Naina's expression — the way a person looks when they have been moving for a long time and have suddenly found shade.

She came forward quietly and sat cross-legged on the carpet beside us. She ran her hand lightly over Pihu's back. Pihu lifted her head, looked at her, and held the torn Ram Lala toy out toward her.

"Isko naya chahiye," Naina said, touching Pihu's cheek gently. Her voice carried the same quiet that was already spread across the room. Then she looked at me. "Mujhe bhi chalna hai. Tumhare aur Pihu ke saath."

Bhabhi came back with two cups of chai. She smiled when she saw Naina — naturally, without ceremony.

"Achha hai aa gayi," she said, setting the cups on the table. "Aise bhi hum 19 tarikh ko Ayodhya jaane ka soch rahe the. Chaturthi hai us din. Bada snan hota hai."

Naina handed the toy back to Pihu. "Chaturthi?"

I sat up slowly, settling Pihu in my lap, and picked up the chai.

"Haan," I said. "Par sirf snan nahi hota. Wahan ek aur process hota hai. Ghade ka."

Naina picked up her cup. There was a question in her eyes, but she didn't rush it. She gave me the space to take my time.

"Log rote hain, depression mein jaate hain, par kuch grief aise hote hain jo bahar nahi aate," I began. "Woh andar baith jaate hain. Ek ruke hue, stagnant paani ki tarah. The mind cannot process abstract grief. It needs a physical form — something to hold, and something to release."

Naina's grip on her cup tightened. I knew who she was thinking about. Nandini ji. Her mother. The woman who had been carrying that stillness inside her like a lake with no outlet, since the day Rohan left.

"Isliye mitti ka ghada use karte hain," I said, my fingers moving through Pihu's hair. "The pot is filled with water. That water is everything you have been holding. When you set it into the Sarayu — into the moving current — it joins the flow. Yeh sirf religion nahi hai Naina. It's a deeply scientific, psychological trigger. The brain physically watches the thing that was frozen take a new shape and move. The burden transfers."

The room went entirely quiet.

Pihu sat still in my lap. Naina held the cup in both hands, exactly where she was. Her eyes had gone slightly wet, but she wasn't crying. She was just — feeling the weight of the idea.

"Maa," she said. One word. Very quietly.

"Unhe zaroorat hai us flow ki," I said. "Woh Rohan ko bhoolengi nahi. Par woh us stagnant paani se bahar aa jayengi."

Naina took a long breath. "Hum unhe le jayenge. 19 ko."

She looked at me. There was no formality in it. Just a very deep, settled understanding.

A while later, Bhabhi took Naina to the kitchen to feed her.

I carried Pihu to my room and put her down to sleep. Straightened the books on the desk.

Then I heard footsteps.

Naina was at the doorway. She didn't ask to come in, but she didn't walk straight in either. She looked at the room first.

Then she stepped inside.

Her eyes went to the rough chart on the wall. Then to my desk.

The notebook was lying open. The first draft of Viram. A riverbank. A few benches. An empty space in the center.

She came to the desk. Her hands were clasped behind her back. She just looked at the drawing. Felt what was on that paper — the stillness I had sketched — without asking what it was for.

Then her gaze shifted slightly to the side.

The diary was there.

The one she had given me in January 2025.

Her hands came forward. She picked it up. It didn't look untouched. The leather at the edges had worn soft. The pages were slightly curved, the way pages curve when they have been opened many times, when time has been spent with them.

Naina's hands stilled on the cover. Her eyes closed.

She remembered the day she had placed it in my hands. Her voice that day, slightly unsteady —

“Jab lage ki meri yaadein dhundhli ho rahi hain, tab isse padh lena. Mujhe bhoolna mat Eklavya|”

She didn't turn a single page. The wear on the cover had already told her everything she needed to know.

She pressed the diary against her chest. Took a slow breath and released it. One tear came loose and moved down her cheek, but her face held a quiet that didn't belong to grief.

"Tumne mujhe bhoolne nahi diya," she said, without turning around. The weight in her voice settled into the room and stayed there.

I didn't say anything. There was nothing that needed to be said.

She turned. Set the diary back on the desk, carefully, with both hands.

"19 ko chalte hain," she said. Her eyes held both the tear and the peace at the same time. "Maa ko us behti nadi ki zaroorat hai. Aur mujhe... is thehraav ki"

INTERLUDE IX

Naina's Diary

April 15, 2026 — Night

I went into his room today.

I saw his notebook on the desk. A draft of something he calls Viram. I didn't ask him what it was. I just looked at it. It looks like a pause. A place where you don't have to become anything. You just exist.

And then I saw the diary.

The one I gave him in January 2025.

It wasn't sitting there untouched. It looked worn out. The edges of the pages were soft, the leather had the marks of being held over and over again.

“Jab meri yaadein kam hone lagein, toh isse padh lena. Mujhe bhoolna mat|”

That's what I told him when I gave it to him. I was so scared that he would move on, that my face would fade from his memory in this fast-moving world.

He didn't let it.

I had spent three years thinking I was the only one holding this thing together. But he was sitting in that room, with my words, keeping me alive in a place the world couldn't reach.

Mujhe lagta tha main akele us rishte ko bacha rahi hoon. Par woh is kamre mein baith kar, meri likhi hui yaadon ke sahare, mujhe khud mein zinda rakhe hue tha|

On the 19th, we are taking Maa to Ayodhya.

She needs to let Rohan's memories mix with the flowing river.

But looking at my old diary on his desk today — I know I am never going to let Eklavya go. He is my river. And I have finally stepped into the water.

— N.